

Tuesday, August 4, 2026

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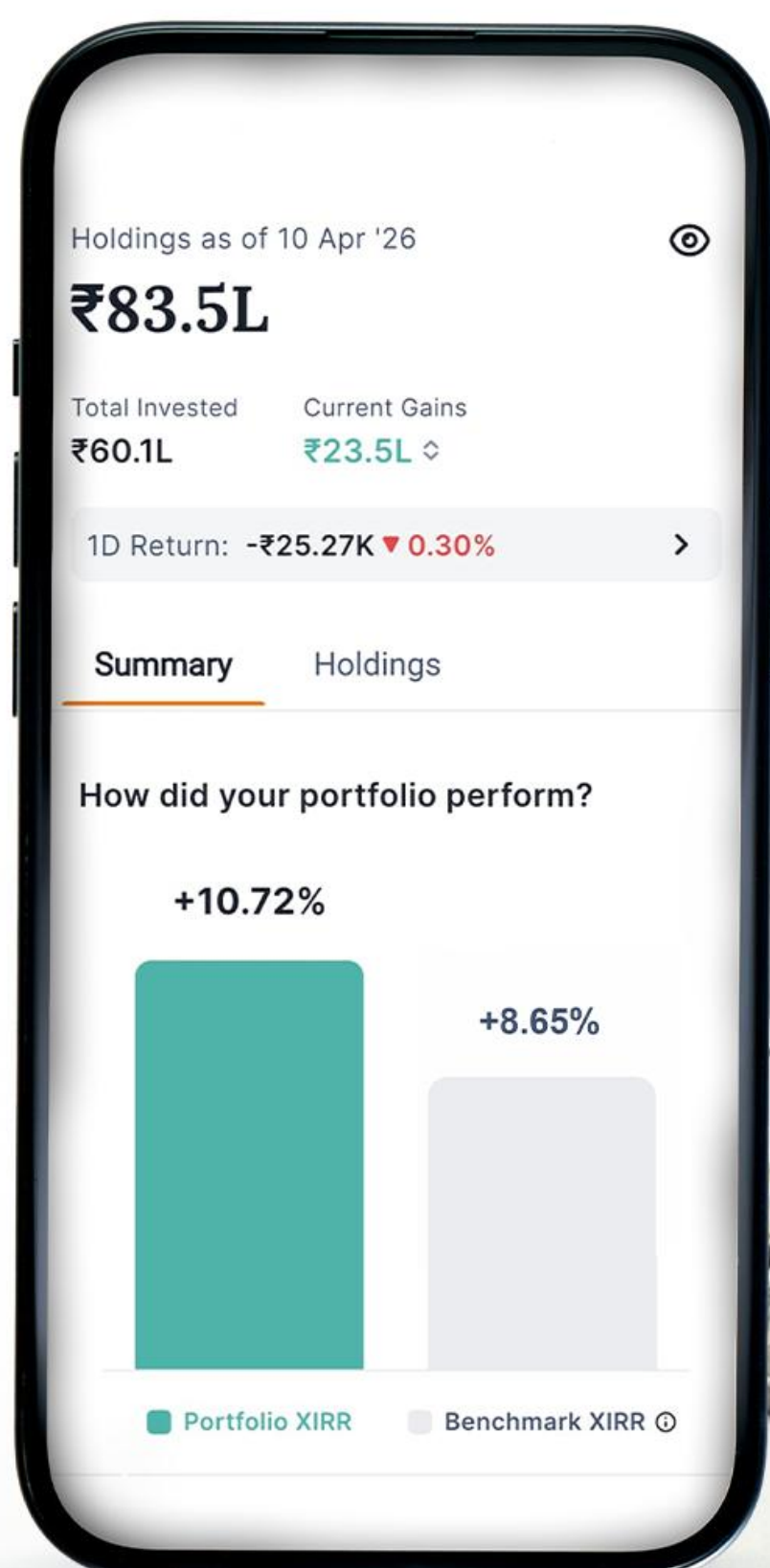
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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why the IBC ruling is a win for homebuyers

BY YASH TIWARI & KRISHNA YADAV

Promoters of insolvent real estate firms can no longer use the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) to fend off homebuyers' legal action. The Supreme Court has ruled that the IBC moratorium protects only the company, not promoters or directors. *Mint* explains



1 What was the case before the SC?

Homebuyers of Bengaluru's Mantri Manyata Energia project moved the National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission (NCDRC) in 2023 against the developer, its promoters, directors and others, alleging failure to hand over homes by the promised 31 December 2018 deadline despite receiving payments. After the company entered insolvency, the NCDRC stayed the case under the Section 14 moratorium, prompting the buyers to move the Supreme Court. A Section 14 moratorium pauses legal and recovery proceedings against a company during insolvency.

2 What did the Supreme Court hold?

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta on 27 July held that Section 14 moratorium applies only to a corporate debtor and cannot be extended to promoters, directors, subsidiaries, personal guarantors or other non-corporate parties unless the law specifically provides otherwise. The court said proceedings against promoters and directors may continue if based on their independent legal liability, even as cases against the company remain stayed. It also held that NCDRC should have stayed proceedings against the company and allowed the case against the remaining respondents to continue.

3 What does the ruling mean for homebuyers?

Lawyers said the ruling clarifies that the Section 14 moratorium does not bar proceedings against promoters and directors, allowing homebuyers to pursue them, likely improving recovery prospects. Homebuyers made up 43.9% of the 5,785 complaints IBBI got, making them largest stakeholder group under IBC, as per an IBBI Governing Board note (2022).

4 What does the ruling mean for promoters?

The ruling increases promoters' accountability without automatically making them liable. Lawyers said creditors can pursue promoters during a firm's insolvency, but their personal liability must still be established. They expect the judgment to have implications beyond real estate by clarifying the limits of the IBC moratorium where insolvency proceedings run alongside civil or criminal actions against promoters. It could also lead creditors to pursue promoters and guarantors earlier.

5 Why is real estate insolvency different?

Real estate insolvency is complex because it affects not just lenders but also thousands of homebuyers. Since the IBC lacks a project-wise insolvency framework, developers with multiple projects are resolved at a company level. As of September 2025, 221 ongoing real estate insolvency cases involved about 109,000 homebuyers. An Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI) committee has recommended a project-wise framework to speed up project completion and improve protection for homebuyers.

QUICK EDIT

Plaza deal redux?

The US acted in concert with Japan last week to boost the yen as it slipped close to a 40-year low amid a struggling economy and very low interest rates. This echoes the logic of the Plaza Accord of 1985; signed by the US with its trade partners Japan, the UK, France and Germany, it was aimed at a coordinated weakening of the dollar in aid of America's export competitiveness. Washington's current grouse is that Asian currencies look underpriced. Although China's yuan is its bugbear, it is Japan that cannot risk losing its US security shield. US President Donald Trump called the joint action "good for the world economy." This conflation of US interests with the world's is par for the Trump course. How it works out is under watch. If Japan liquidates its US Treasury bonds to sell dollars in bulk too quickly, it could push up yields and thus the US government's cost of finance. In 1988, Trump bought the hotel in New York where the 1985 pact was signed, hailing it as a "work of art." It went bust and he sold it in 1995. By then, Japan was probably ruining the deal, given how badly it worked out for its economy. While Tokyo may value US protection highly, it also needs economic-policy autonomy.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

The future will not belong to traditional banks or non-banks, but to platforms that connect people with what they need—contextually, seamlessly and smartly.

K. V. KAMATH
Chairman, Jio Financial Services Ltd



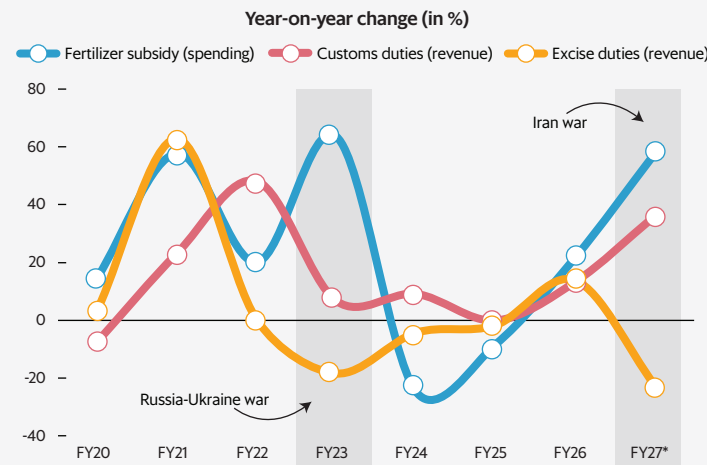
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mint | DATA BITES

HOW THE WEST ASIA WAR IS IMPACTING GOVT FINANCES

Higher prices due to the West Asia war drove government's fertilizer subsidy up 57.6% year-on-year in April-June. Fuel excise duty cuts caused a 22.4% drop in collections, while higher gold tariffs boosted customs duty revenue by 36.1%.



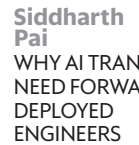
COLUMNS



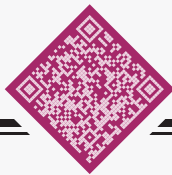
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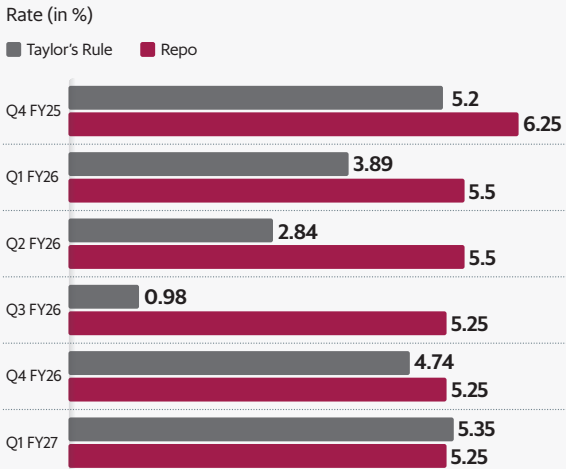


WILL A PAUSE PUT RBI BEHIND THE CURVE?

BY DEEPA VASUDEVAN

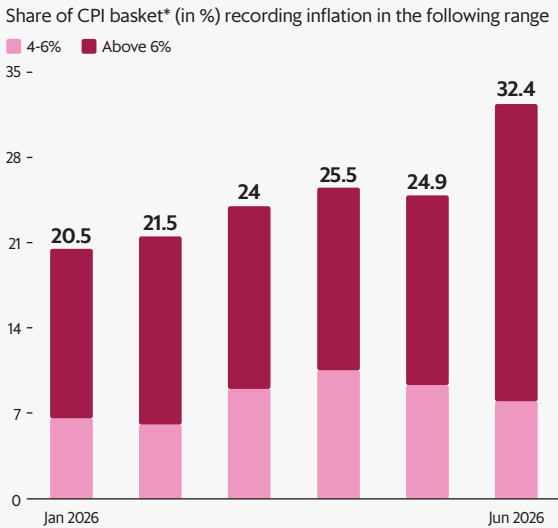
Amid rising inflationary risks from the West Asia war and El Niño, the RBI faces a dilemma over whether to hold repo rates or hike them to curb mounting price pressures.

RBI may have fallen slightly behind the curve based on Taylor's Rule estimations



The Taylor's Rule guides central banks in setting target interest rates based on inflation target deviations and economic output gaps. Assumptions: neutral rate at 1.65% (average of the 1.4-1.9% range by RBI) and potential output growth at 7%.

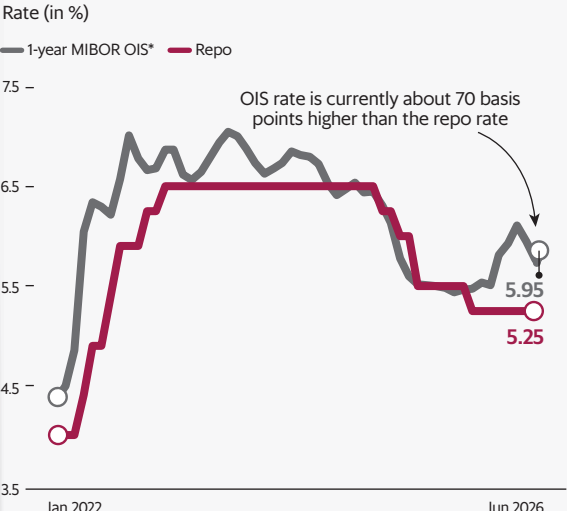
Retail inflation is rising but is not alarmingly broad-based yet



*Based on analysis of 358 items adjusted for their respective weights in the basket. CPI: Consumer price index.

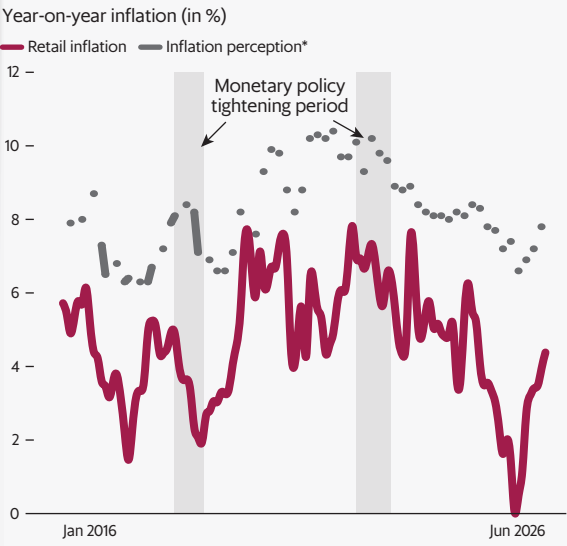
Source: Reserve Bank of India, Statistics ministry, Clearing Corp of India, author's calculations

OIS rates suggest that markets are factoring in a couple of rate hikes in a year



*The benchmark interest rate (weighted average) at which banks in India lend unsecured funds to each other on an overnight basis.

Despite slight delay, previous rate hike cycles curbed inflation and cost perceptions



*Household inflation perception as per Reserve Bank of India survey.

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When the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI's) Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meets this week, it will face a choice between holding the policy repo rate and raising it from 5.25% currently. Both courses of action have some justification. A pause makes sense given that economic growth remains robust and inflation has surpassed the RBI's 4% target rate only once this year (in June 2026).

A pre-emptive rate hike to shield against inflationary pressures and protect capital inflows also seems justified—after all, many advanced-economy central banks (Europe, Japan, Australia) began tightening earlier this year. If the RBI chooses to pause, as widely expected by market experts, will it fall behind the curve? A central bank is "behind the curve" if it fails to raise rates quickly in response to inflation. Naturally, the RBI is not expected to respond to a single over-4% inflation print with a rate hike. But if it waits too long and reacts too slowly, it risks a rapid build-up in inflation.

The MPC meeting is currently underway and a decision will be announced on Wednesday. All 10 economists polled by *Mint* expect a pause in rate and a neutral stance in the current meeting. Several economists described it as a policy "non-event", but said the RBI's communication is likely to strike a cautious, if mildly hawkish, tone.

TAYLOR'S RULE

In 2022, James Bullard, then president of the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis, identified two ways to assess whether a central bank was behind the curve. The first approach is to use monetary rules such as Taylor's Rule to determine the appropriate level of policy rates. If the actual policy rate is below the recommended rate, then the bank is likely to be behind the curve. A simple Taylor specification for India, assuming a 4% inflation target, 7% potential growth rate, and equal coefficients on inflation and output gaps, suggests that monetary policy was tighter than prescribed until recently. However, the RBI seems to have fallen slightly behind the curve in April-June: according to Taylor's Rule, a rate hike is recommended.

Of course, there are drawbacks to following monetary rules. Policy rates adjust slowly over a rate cycle; they cannot be instantly increased or decreased as per rule-based benchmarks. In addition, recommendations are only as good as underlying assumptions—even a slight change in model parameters can completely alter the interpretation. For example, if the neutral interest rate is set at 1.5% (instead of 1.65%), the Taylor Rule throws up a recommended policy rate of 5.20%, suggesting that the RBI may need to cut rates.

MARKET SIGNALS

A second, and more intuitive approach is to rely on market rates such as the highly traded 1-year Overnight Interest Swap (OIS) rate, which is a reasonably good predictor of the policy repo rate. The 1-year OIS rate has been on an uptrend since the US-Iran war started in February; it dropped slightly in June after measures were announced to shore up dollar inflows. By mid-July, renewed hostilities in Iran and rising oil prices pushed OIS rates up again. On 30 July, the 1-year OIS rate was about 5.95%. This suggests that markets expect the repo rate to rise by 70 basis points, which implies at least two 25 bps hikes in the current financial year.

INFLATION-RUPEE MIX

But monetary policy is much more than following a formula or reading market signals. Rate decisions need to reflect current economic reality while simultaneously being forward looking. In this context, three points are worth highlighting.

First, while inflation is rising, it has not yet become so generalized and broad-based as to be a cause for alarm. In June

AT A GLANCE

● The Reserve Bank of India faces a critical choice between maintaining the 5.25% repo rate or raising it to manage emerging inflationary risks.

● Taylor's Rule suggests policy was tighter than required lately, but recent economic shifts suggest the central bank may slightly lag behind inflation trends.

● Market indicators like 1-year Overnight Interest Swap rates show rising expectations for around two rate hikes due to geopolitical tensions and surging oil prices.

● While inflation remains contained within specific sectors, potential risks from uneven monsoon rains and energy costs may need future rapid policy adjustments by the RBI.

2026, items with 32% weight in the CPI basket had inflation above 4%, and 24% had inflation over 6%. For comparison, during the previous high inflation episode in Jan-Dec 2022, the corresponding shares of over-4% and over-6% weights were 79.5% and 52.8%, respectively.

Second, there is considerable uncertainty about the future path of inflation. The resumption of US-Iran hostilities could push up oil prices: indeed, the price of Brent crude has already surged above \$100 per barrel in July. El Nino is another key risk: uneven rainfall distribution, delayed start of monsoon, and lower reservoir levels add to inflation risk. The fact that inflation is not broad-based across all items favours a pause, but the threat of El Nino fuelling food prices favours a hike. Uncertainty over inflation trajectory is not limited to India: last week the US Federal Reserve, the Bank of Japan and the Bank of England all opted to pause rates.

Third, the rupee continues to fall, despite RBI intervention and the prospect of dollar inflows through the Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) and External Commercial Borrowing route. The total amount of dollars mobilized will be known only by September. Until then, it is tough to predict whether these flows will stabilize the rupee.

POLICY ROOM

The August MPC is important because there are consequences to falling behind the curve—once inflation is high and entrenched, it is harder to manage with monetary policy. But it is not a now-or-never decision. IMF research shows that a small delay, when combined with aggressive rate action, is equally effective in controlling inflation. We saw this in the last two rate hike cycles: RBI started raising rates after some months of over-4% inflation, but made up for it with rapid rate hikes that brought down actual inflation as well as household perceptions of inflation.

Hence, pausing now may not mean falling behind the curve, provided the RBI signals a willingness to act swiftly if inflation remains persistent.

The author is an independent writer in economics and finance.



MINT SHORTS

India moots tax break extension for contract manufacturing

New Delhi: India proposes to extend tax exemptions until 2041 for foreign companies that provide machinery to contract manufacturers, handing a big win to Apple that had lobbied for such changes. As per a draft of the proposed amendments seen by *Reuters*, "to provide (tax) certainty" the government has extended tax breaks until 31 March 2041 to foreign companies that provide equipment to contract manufacturers in India. **REUTERS**

IMD warns of flash flood risk in North-East as rains intensify



New Delhi: The monsoon is set to intensify across large parts of India this week, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) warning of risks of flash floods in parts of the North-east and forecasting extremely heavy rainfall in several states over the next seven days. IMD has flagged a low to moderate flash flood risk over the next 24 hours for parts of Arunachal Pradesh, Assam and Meghalaya, where widespread heavy rain is expected. **VIJAY C. ROY**

Joint committee of parliament backs corporate law overhaul

New Delhi: A joint committee of parliament has, in its report on the Corporate Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, tabled in Parliament on Monday, backed an overhaul of India's corporate law framework, proposing further decriminalization of procedural lapses, compliance relief for small businesses, and relaxed corporate social responsibility (CSR) norms. **HARSH KUMAR**

Rajya Sabha clears bill to tackle delay in payments to MSMEs



New Delhi: The Rajya Sabha on Monday passed a bill that seeks to tackle delays in payments to MSMEs by prescribing timelines to ensure faster adjudication of disputes, provide recovery of the settlement agreement, and address their liquidity issues, even as Opposition members continued to disrupt the House. The Micro Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026 seeks to empower courts to order payment of at least 50% of the awarded amount to MSME suppliers, if the application to set aside an order is pending for more than six months. **PTI**

Bill to raise SC judge count passed by Lok Sabha without debate

New Delhi: The Lok Sabha on Monday passed a bill to replace an ordinance that increased the number of Supreme Court judges from 34 to 38 without a debate as opposition members persisted with slogan-shouting over the issues of Neet paper leak and alleged theft of Ram temple donations. After the passage of the Bill, the House was adjourned for the day. **REUTERS**

Kharif sowing lags last year's pace by 2.9% despite July rains revival

New Delhi: Kharif crop sowing continued to lag last year's pace despite an improvement in monsoon rainfall, with farmers planting crops across 89.4 million hectares (mn ha.) as of 31 July, 2.65mn ha. less than the 92 million covered during the year-ago period, as per agriculture ministry data. The normal (2020-21 to 2024-25) kharif acreage was 110.46 mn ha. **VIJAY C. ROY**

India's new cars to 'talk' to each other from Oct 2028

For road safety, draft norms moot phased V2V communication in new cars starting Oct 2027

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In a move to boost road safety and reduce accidents on India's highways, the ministry of road transport and highways has proposed making vehicle-to-vehicle (V2V) communication systems mandatory in all new vehicles in a phased manner from October 2027, according to a draft notification issued on Monday.

The proposal seeks to amend the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, and is expected to lay the foundation for connected mobility and intelligent transport systems in India.

The ministry has invited public comments and stakeholder feedback on the draft over the next 30 days, after which a final notification will be issued.

Under the proposal, vehicles in categories L (two- and three-wheelers), M (passenger vehicles) and N (goods vehicles) made 1 October 2027 onwards will need to comply with the newly-developed AIS-230 standard wherever they are equipped with V2V communication systems. A year later, from 1 October 2028, all newly manufactured vehicles in these categories will need compliant V2V systems.

The phased plan is designed to give manufacturers enough time to prepare.

The move marks one of the most significant technology-driven safety



The road, transport and highways ministry has invited feedback on the draft safety norms for vehicles in the next 30 days. **REUTERS**

interventions by the government since rollout of the advanced vehicle safety norms and is likely to complement the advanced driver assistance systems (ADAS) being adopted in premium passenger vehicles.

Unlike conventional safety systems that mostly depend on onboard sensors, cameras and driver reaction, V2V enables vehicles to exchange real-time information such as speed, position, direction, acceleration and braking status.

This allows vehicles to alert drivers—or automated safety systems—to potential hazards even when they are beyond the driver's line of sight.

To explain how this would work: every vehicle will continuously send out its location, speed and direction as tiny radio signals. They will also relay information on sudden braking by a vehicle ahead, forward collision risks, unsafe lane changes, wrong-way driving and the approach of emergency vehicles. The receiving car's system compares this information with its own location, speed and direction to predict a possible collision and, if necessary, alerts the driver or automatically intervenes.

The ministry said the standard has been developed around cellular vehi-

cle-to-everything (C-V2X) technology operating in the 5.875-5.925 GHz band. The telecom department exempted this spectrum from licensing norms on 10 June, clearing the way for commercial deployment of V2V applications.

AIS-230 specifies the minimum technical, functional, environmental, performance and cybersecurity norms for factory-installed onboard V2V communication units. It covers radio performance, receiver sensitivity, global navigation satellite system (GNSS) positioning, power supply, electromagnetic compatibility and communication security requirements. It also defines performance norms for key road safety applications and provides for the phased introduction of use cases such as emergency brake alert, forward collision warning, wrong-way driving alert and emergency vehicle alert.

The draft follows proposals of a task force on Intelligent Transportation Systems, set up to develop a roadmap for connected mobility with an emphasis on V2V communication. It recommended adoption of 5.9 GHz ITS frequency band for vehicle communications to improve road safety. The standard was later examined by the Central Motor Vehicles Rules-Technical Standing Committee in May before it was proposed for regulatory adoption.

For an extended version of the story, go to [livemint.com](#).

AIS-230
Standard vehicles with V2V systems will need to follow

5.9GHz ITS
Frequency band for vehicle comms to improve safety

Manufacturing activity hits a near 5-year low, shows survey

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The HSBC India Manufacturing PMI fell to 53.5 in July, down from 54.2 in June. **BLOOMBERG**

India's manufacturing activity expanded at its slowest pace in over five years in July as a sharp moderation in new orders curbed input purchasing, even as export demand strengthened and inflationary pressures eased, per a survey released Monday.

The HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) fell to 53.5 in July, down from 54.2 in June, and below the flash reading of 53.9, underscoring that renewed tensions in West Asia have raised fresh doubts among manufacturers. However, the reading remained above the 50-mark that separates expansion from a contraction.

The index is a gauge of overall conditions derived from measures of new orders, output, employment, supplier delivery times, and stocks of purchases. The latest reading "was the lowest since August 2021 and below the long-run series average of 54.2," the survey said.

Despite receding only marginally from June, the growth in new orders was the second-weakest in over four years. Panel members indicated that advertising and demand resilience supported sales, somewhat curbed by challenging market conditions and lower client interest for key items.

As per the survey, manufacturers continued to benefit from resilient demand, with a sustained rise in new orders underpinning further output growth in July. Growth, however, cooled again in metrics such as total sales, input pur-

chasing and employment.

The survey noted a welcome development in new export orders, which rose at a faster rate. Many firms noted gains from Canada, Egypt, Indonesia, Kenya, Nepal, South Africa, Thailand and the UAE. There was also a mild recovery in business optimism.

Operating expenses rose further, especially for transportation, but the overall rate of cost inflation eased to a five-month low. Hence, output charges increased only moderately, said the survey.

"The suppliers' delivery times index rose in July, an encouraging sign that supply chain delays are continuing to unwind. However, renewed tensions in the Middle East have raised fresh doubts about how durable these improvements will be," said Pranjud Bhandari, chief India economist at HSBC.

The HSBC India Manufacturing PMI is compiled by S&P Global from a survey of around 400 manufacturers.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

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India, Uzbekistan to double bilateral trade in three years



Piyush Goyal, commerce and industry minister. **REUTERS**

India and Uzbekistan are looking to more than double bilateral trade to about \$3 billion over next three years. Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal on Monday said the two countries could also explore a free trade agreement (FTA) as they deepen economic ties.

The two countries are looking to diversify economic ties beyond traditional sectors, with Uzbekistan inviting Indian firms to expand investments in mining, metallurgy, chemicals, energy, pharmaceuticals, automobiles and digital infrastructure. They have also agreed to work towards easing market access and lowering trade barriers.

Addressing the India-Uzbekistan Business Forum in New Delhi, Goyal said trade would have to "lead from the front" in strengthening bilateral relations and urged businesses to seize opportunities for long-term partnerships. Goyal said that though bilat-

United Spirits moves HC vs FSSAI order

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United Spirits Ltd, maker of McDowell's No.1, Royal Challenge, Antiquity Blue, and Signature Whisky, has moved the Bombay High Court against an order by the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) restricting the sale of one of its rum products.

The move comes as FSSAI steps up enforcement against what it says is the misleading use of identical flavouring and age-related claims in alcoholic beverages, a move that could reshape long-standing manufacturing practices across India's Indian Made Foreign Liquor (IMFL) industry.

In a stock exchange filing on Monday, the Diageo India-owned company said it had filed a writ petition challenging FSSAI's 29 June order concerning a product manufactured at its Baramati unit in Maharashtra. The regulator alleged the labels violated provisions of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.

United Spirits said its labels comply with the legal and regulatory norm and reflect long-standing industry practice. The plea was filed on 1 August. The company said the order has no material operational or financial implications.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

eral trade grew 30% last year, topping \$1.3 billion for the first time. "We hope to reach \$2 billion by next year, and we should work to increase our trade to \$3-5 billion in the coming years," Kudratov said. He said the two sides were working to improve market access, streamline procedures and reduce administrative barriers to facilitate trade.

The countries are also working on a trade facilitation agreement and related memoranda to create more favourable conditions for exporters and importers, Kudratov said.

Uzbekistan offers significant potential in mining and metallurgy, chemicals, energy, digital infrastructure, automobiles and pharmaceuticals, he said, reiterating its interest in attracting greater Indian investment in these sectors.

The trade push follows the conclusion of the India-Uzbekistan Bilateral Investment Treaty (BIT), which Goyal said will boost investor confidence and encourage businesses to make long-term investments.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Govt scouts for new DCGI chief amid flak for widened eligibility norm

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The Centre has kicked off the search for a successor to Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI) Rajeev Singh Raghuvanshi, whose tenure was extended twice since he took charge in February 2023 amid a lingering succession issue, according to two officials and a document reviewed by *Mint*.

The health ministry has invited applications for the post of the drugs controller to head the apex drug regulator Central Drugs Standard Con-

trol Organisation (CDSO).

The development assumes significance for India's \$60 billion pharmaceutical market, with the DCGI responsible for ensuring the safety, efficacy, and global quality standards of drugs, medical devices, and clinical trials, the officials cited earlier said, both speaking on condition of anonymity.

The government revised the recruitment rules for the position in an April 2026 notification, widening eligibility to include non-pharmacy disciplines such as engineering with specialization in mechanical, electrical and computer science, sparking fierce oppo-



The Centre's widening of eligibility norms for DCGI to include non-pharmacy disciplines like engineering, raised opposition. **BLOOMBERG**

sition from regulator officials.

As per the revised rules, candidates must hold a master's degree in fields such as

engineering, pharmacy, chemistry, life sciences, or medicine, with a doctorate considered a plus. Applicants

also need at least 15 years of practical experience in drug manufacturing, safety testing, clinical trial regulation, or medical device oversight, alongside proven expertise in enforcing national drug laws.

Raghuvanshi, an IIT-BHU alumnus with a PhD from the Delhi-based National Institute of Immunology, had previously led the Indian Pharmacopoeia Commission and has held senior roles at Dr. Reddy's and the erstwhile Ranbaxy. He reached the superannuation age of 60 in February 2025, but got a second extension in February 2026 that will keep him in office until March 2027

or until a successor is named. Queries emailed to the spokespersons of health and family welfare ministry, DCGI office on Saturday and Raghuvanshi on Sunday remained unanswered until press time.

The broadened criteria have sparked sharp reactions. The All India Drugs Control Officers' Confederation (AIDCOC), representing over 3,000 regulatory officers, gave a representation to the health ministry in April, opposing the rule change and alleging statutory violations and technical incompatibility.

AIDCOC argued that expanding the qualifications

to non-pharmacy engineering streams violates Rules 49A and 50A of the Drugs and Cosmetics Rules, 1945, which strictly mandate background in pharmacy, pharmaceutical chemistry, clinical pharmacology, or microbiology for licensing and controlling authorities. It said such candidates, regardless of professional exposure, lack the academic foundation necessary to adjudicate complex drug-related issues.

The age limit for the position, advertised on 1 August, is 58 years. The application has a deadline of 30 September.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

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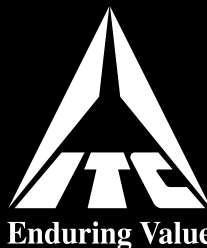
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ITC: Partnering India in its Defining Decade

Excerpts from the Address by
Shri Sanjiv Puri, Chairman & Managing Director, ITC Limited

115th Annual General Meeting, ITC Limited | 23 July 2026



We meet today at a time of deep significance — for the world, for India, and for enterprises that aspire to create enduring value. The prolonged uncertainty arising from the West Asia crisis has severely impacted the global economy, threatening energy security and trade. Indeed, the multitude of events in the recent past only reinforce the fact that **global volatility is no more sporadic; it is now systemic**. Last year, in my address, I had described this as an era of **TURN** — a world constantly confronted by **Turbulence, Uncertainty and Rapid change**, calling for **Novel strategies** to reimagine our tomorrows. Today, that reality stands even more pronounced, as a deeper structural shift reshapes the future of nations, societies and enterprises.

What makes this juncture a perfect storm of exceptional complexity and consequence is the confluence of multiple forces at scale. On the one hand, global progress is challenged by the catastrophic climate emergency, widening inequality and advances in disruptive technologies like AI. On the other hand, decades of hyper-globalisation have given way to fragmented multi-polarisation — creating a world that is still deeply connected, but less trusting; still trading yet marred by weaponisation of supply chains; still global, but increasingly nationalistic. These tectonic shifts are being felt across everyday lives — through volatile commodity prices, inflationary pressures, disruptions in trade and the rising vulnerability of food, energy and supply chains.

It is said that crisis challenges the status quo like no other and spurs innovation to forge new pathways for growth, competitiveness and resilience. We stand today at such an inflection point with an unparalleled opportunity to make a meaningful difference to all our shared tomorrows.

It gives us immense pride, therefore, that India's resolute fortitude in accelerating the journey to a competitive, resilient and inclusive nation has earned it widespread trust, respect and admiration.

India's Ascent: A Beacon of Hope and Progress

Against this backdrop, the Hon'ble Prime Minister's powerful clarion call for an **Aatmanirbhar** and a **Viksit Bharat** assumes even greater significance. It has inspired multidimensional interventions enabling India to emerge as the fastest-growing major economy in the world. The far-reaching measures announced in successive Budgets have provided strong foundations to unleash growth. India's ascent is not merely about outpacing other large economies. It has demonstrated that a nation of continental scale, democratic depth and extraordinary diversity can drive momentum with stability, pursue reform with inclusion, and convert aspiration into resilient growth.

The India story is indeed an inspiring example of how the Government is creating an all-pervasive **Bharat Capability Stack** through exemplary foresight and foundational action to reinforce competitiveness for today, resilience for tomorrow and strategic readiness for the decades ahead.

Role of Business: Responsible Competitiveness

It is my deep conviction that businesses, as a crucial organ of society, serve a larger transformational purpose by contributing meaningfully to **national competitiveness, sustainable and inclusive development**.

This philosophy is reflected in your Company's ethos of **Responsible Competitiveness**, which has guided our thought, strategy and action over the years and inspires our commitment to be a **national value multiplier**. To my mind, businesses make a lasting contribution to the nation when they frame their growth agenda around three imperatives.

First, as engines of national competitiveness, it is mission critical for Indian enterprises to be **future-ready and globally competitive**. This calls for trusted Indian brands that anchor domestic ecosystems and create value in the country; investments in state-of-the-art national assets that support India's ambition to become a global hub for manufacturing, services and exports; a deeper focus on cutting-edge innovation and R&D as well as capabilities for AI-led transformation. **The Hon'ble Prime Minister's vision of Build More, Produce More and Export More** raises our collective aspirations to even bolder heights to craft products and services of world-class quality and trust, that earn their rightful place in households and markets across the world.

Taking this tenet further, the **second imperative** is for businesses to evolve as architects of **national resilience and anti-fragility**. While resilience sharpens the capacity to bounce back amidst adversity, anti-fragility goes beyond, to convert adversity into future opportunities. Strengthening resilience calls for locally anchored value chains, stronger MSME partnerships, diversified and trusted sourcing, import substitution, climate stewardship and robust digital adoption. However, the winners of tomorrow must also thrive amidst adversity, nurture new competencies, accelerate innovation and spur new engines of growth. Resilience is no longer the dividend of efficiency nor is anti-fragility a distant objective, they are the very foundation of our right to grow. **When enterprises embed resilience and embrace anti-fragility, they fortify the nation's foundation and position it to rise stronger with every adversity**.

Third, businesses must advance a paradigm of Compassionate Capitalism. Competitiveness gives enterprises the power to win, anti-fragility the right to win the future and purpose the legitimacy to win. Businesses exist to serve both an economic and social purpose. The enormous climate risks, livelihood challenges, inequality and regulations make it a **crucial responsibility of businesses to embed sustainability and inclusion as an integral component of strategy**. This belief lies at the core of your Company's approach.

A few years ago, your Company laid the foundations of the **ITC Next strategy** to drive scale, accelerated growth and profitability and make the enterprise even more future-ready. Guided by the Company's credo of "**Nation First, Sab Saath Badhein**", our north-star is to create growing value for all our stakeholders — by building national competitiveness that is globally benchmarked, resilience that is locally anchored, and growth that is anti-fragile, inclusive and sustainable.

ITC: Ushering in NextGen Agri, Strengthening Rural India

I begin with agriculture — the lifeline of our economy and the foundation of rural India. India possesses vast arable land, diverse agro-climatic zones and leadership in several commodities. Yet, low productivity, fragmented holdings, limited value addition, climate vulnerability and inefficient market access continue to constrain its potential. This points to a defining opportunity to **transform Indian agriculture from volume-led production to value-led competitiveness**, not only to fortify food security but to raise farmer incomes, deepen rural capability and enhance exports.

The Government has spearheaded several commendable measures to support growth of the agri-food sector. Higher farmer incomes can trigger a virtuous cycle of consumption, investment, employment and rural prosperity. This requires a structural shift to shape **NextGeneration Agriculture** — from fragmented productivity to integrated competitiveness, from undifferentiated commodities to high-value agriculture, and from vulnerable farming systems to climate-smart, technology-enabled rural ecosystems.

With over a century of engagement with agriculture, 94% of your Company's businesses are linked to agri-crops or plantations, generating substantial livelihoods. ITC nurtures **21 value chains across 23 States to source nearly 6 million tonnes of agri-produce**. In this address, I will focus on ITC's Agri Business, which is now the country's largest private sector agri-enterprise, **doubling segment revenue in just over 5 years to nearly ₹20,300 crore** in FY26. The **ITC Next strategy** is today transforming the Agri Business, while ushering in NextGeneration farming and rural empowerment.

At the core of this transformation is the **ITCMAARS** phygital ecosystem, designed to empower FPOs with digital technologies, hyper-personalised advisories, quality inputs, market linkages, scientific agronomy and climate-smart practices to improve farm competitiveness and resilience. In a short span, ITCMAARS has onboarded **over 2.6 million farmers** across 11 States, with the ambition to benefit 10 million farmers by 2030. Initial estimates indicate **crop yield gains of 15-20% and improvement in net returns by 25-30%**.

Building on a recent horticulture pilot, anchored by FPOs, for the supply of high-quality fruits and vegetables, ITC plans to develop 4 additional hybrid Open-to-Sky and Controlled Environment Agriculture clusters to create a reliable, traceable supply chain for fresh produce. Progressively, **ITCMAARS is introducing precision-led agriculture and advanced agri-tech solutions, like IoT-enabled weather tracking, remote-sensing, drone-based services, to promote smart farming**.

A vital component of your Company's agri strategy is to promote **Value-Added Agriculture** to enable farmers scale the next horizon of profitable growth. This portfolio, which has grown at a CAGR of 33% over five years, today encompasses **certified organic crops, processed agri-products, such as food-safe spices, horticulture, premium coffee, aquaculture and attribute-specific commodities, like high-starch maize and high-glyten wheat**.

Taking this further, **ITCMAARS will drive a Farming as a Service (FaaS) ecosystem to 'Grow the Buy', where crop value chains are customised to meet specific buyer needs**.

Certifications, traceability and responsible sourcing establish **trust systems at scale**, linking Indian farmers to domestic and global export markets. ITC's Spices Business, for example, is today the country's leading exporter of organic spices, supported by certified cultivation, backward integration and **one of Asia's largest spices processing facilities at Guntur**.

In an era of climate stress and rising food security imperatives, production of **high-quality, resilient seeds and hybrids** is vital to enhancing productivity, improving quality, increasing climate resilience, strengthening nutritional security and raising farmer incomes. Your Company's wholly owned subsidiary Technico, a **global leader in pre-basic potato seeds, is investing in the world's largest state-of-the-art aeroponic facility** with 60 hi-tech controlled-environment greenhouses, taking the combined capacity to 100 million TECHNITUBER[®]s.

Fostering an effective **science-to-farm ecosystem**, ITC's LSTC is leveraging advanced breeding technologies, molecular genetics and digital tools to develop higher-yielding, climate-resilient, hybrid and disease-resistant varieties across crops such as tobacco, wheat, potato, eucalyptus and subabul. **These have led to yields improving by 15-50%**.

Your Company is making appreciable progress in high-value, future-facing categories, such as **Biological Extracts**, with the commencement of a US FDA-compliant, export-oriented, **nicotine derivative** processing facility, serving customers in Europe, USA and South Korea. In addition, ITC's **medicinal and aromatic plant ecosystem** is developing high-active varieties and proprietary formulations, besides manufacturing high-purity extracts for domestic and global markets together with farmer

training in best practices.

As we look ahead, ITC will continue to work towards shaping a more competitive, resilient and inclusive Agri Business, which is not only creating **new growth drivers** but also **contributing to enriching rural India, raising farmer incomes, fortifying food and livelihood security, and establishing globally trusted value chains**.

ITC: Proudly Indian Brands — Creating and Retaining Value in India

In a growing consumption-led economy, strong domestic brands assume strategic importance because they channel consumer aspiration into national value. Brands are vital **repositories of trust, quality, innovation and intellectual property**. When successful Indian brands win consumer preference at scale, they **retain larger value within the country**.

That is why **'Vocal for Local'** is not merely a sentiment; it is a **strategy to reinforce domestic capability, create and nurture brands that are born in India but made for the world** with impeccable quality and trust that can delight consumers globally.

Your Company's aspiration to be India's No. 1 FMCG player is anchored on this larger vision. Today, ITC's portfolio of over 30 world-class FMCG brands represents annual consumer spends of **nearly ₹37,000 crore** and reaches around **280 million households** while being exported to over **70 countries**. It is indeed difficult to find parallels globally of an enterprise that has launched so many large, successful and trusted home-grown brands in a relatively short period.

ITC's brands enrich everyday moments in Indian homes — from **Sunfeast** biscuits in the morning, to breakfast choices of **Aashirvaad Besan chillas** and **Yoga Bar** cereals, to **Fiana** bathing experiences, **Mangaldeep** devotional moments and **Classmate's** joy of learning, from baby and pet-safe clean homes with **Nimley** to meals with **24 Mantra Organic**, **Aashirvaad** staples and **Sunrise** spices, to fun times with **Bingol**, **ITC Master Chef** and **Prasuma** snacks, mini meals with **YIPPeel** and ending the day with **Fabelle** for luxurious indulgence and **Pranah** for relaxation.

The Indian FMCG market is poised for significant expansion, with your Company's addressable market estimated at around ₹8 trillion by 2035, pointing to the immense headroom to grow. The consumer landscape in India is also evolving rapidly. The rise of Aspirational Bharat, premiumisation, Gen Z and Gen Alpha consumers, expanding digital access and the growth of quick commerce are reshaping categories, channels and expectations. Today's **'maximiser consumer'** simultaneously seeks taste and nutrition, convenience and trust, indulgence and wellness, value as well as premium experiences.

In line with the **ITC Next strategy**, your Company is making rapid progress in not only scaling its core power brands but developing a future-ready portfolio that is constantly alive to evolving consumer needs. A critical foundation is ITC's **AI-led consumer insight ecosystem**, that drives **targeted micro-segmentation** to help craft a pipeline of differentiated

offerings — be it by life stages, lifestyle, channel, occasion, shelf-life requirement and health need, among others. This vibrant portfolio has been enriched with new acquisitions in areas of promise that are already clocking an ARR of around ₹1,350 crore, effectively synergising the entrepreneurial energy of start-ups with ITC's scale and institutional strengths. These differentiated products reach millions of homes through your Company's smart omni-channel network with unique multidimensional capabilities across ambient, chilled, frozen and perishable supply chains.

India today faces the twin challenges of adequate nutrition and rising lifestyle-related health concerns. Aligned to ITC's **'Help India Eat Better'** Mission, a **Good-for-You** portfolio is being built to address **deficiencies in protein, fibre, micronutrients and gut health**. These include the **Yoga Bar protein range** for Gen Z, **Sunfeast Breakfast Protein-rich shakes** for early jobbers and **Aashirvaad Protein Atta** for the entire family. The **Right Shift** range for the **40-plus cohort** is fortified with fibre, protein and micronutrients. **24 Mantra Organic** provides trusted organic products, while **Aashirvaad Millet Flour**, **Multigrain Flour**, **Sunfeast Farnite biscuits**, and **Yoga Bar** high-fibre breakfast cereals serve the growing need for better fibre intake and gut health.

Leveraging emerging spaces such as wellness and naturals, your Company's Personal Care portfolio reflects the convergence of nature, and science. **Nimley** brings the goodness of Neem into homecare, while **Savlon** continues to expand its trusted hygiene equity across personal wash, germ protection, surface disinfection and medicated skincare. The acquisition of **Mother Sparsh** marks ITC's strategic presence in premium natural baby care, rooted in traditional Indian knowledge for new-age mothers seeking specialised solutions. Building on **Fiana's industry-first gel bar technology**, the new **Japanese Hokkaido Milk range**, which is being patented, reflects sensorial innovation that promises non-sticky moisturised skin.

Innovation is at the heart of your Company's future-ready portfolio, which is powered by **ITC's Life Sciences and Technology Centre**, with over 400 world-class scientists. What sets the Centre apart is not just its deep research capabilities and future-ready platforms, but its focus on **end-to-end value chains, from seed to fork and tree to paper, enabling your Company to craft winning products of impeccable quality**.

We recognise that **business innovation is as crucial as product innovation**. Consumers increasingly seek fresh cooked food solutions where freshness, speed, quality and trust converge. Responding to this, your Company launched the **Fresh Food Business**, leveraging ITC's institutional strengths in trusted brands, food sciences, cuisine expertise and digital capabilities. With over 70 cloud kitchens across five cities, the business has grown over 100% in the last three years through a delectable portfolio comprising **Aashirvaad Soul Creations**, **ITC Master Chef Creations**, **Sunfeast Baked Creations** and **Sansho** from ITC Master Chef, which have consistently received top consumer rankings.

Your Company's growing standing in **FMCG, powered by the trust of millions of consumers, gives us the confidence to dream boldly — of a future where an ITC product adorns every household in India and makes its mark across continents**. ITC's world-class Indian brands will continue to be a significant enduring strength, creating larger value for the enterprise and its stakeholders.

ITC: Powering Make in India for a Viksit Bharat

Your Company's **Bharat Built Manufacturing architecture** has created world-class national assets across **FMCG, Paperboards & Packaging and export-oriented value-added Agri Processing**. Today, ITC's manufacturing ecosystem spans **over 300 factories**, including 45 owned plants, engaging with more than **9,500 MSMEs**. These large investments in modern facilities provide strong levers of competitiveness, resilience and local value-chain development.

In the true spirit of Make in India, nearly **90% of ITC's value addition takes place within the country**. The agri and food processing industry has high employment-to-capital intensity. Therefore, your Company's 170 factories in this sector are a **powerful economic multiplier, deepening inclusive farm-to-consumer value chains and linking farmers to domestic and global markets**.

Your Company's confidence in the India story is reflected in its proposed medium-term capex of ₹20,000 crore for the Group in areas that have a multiplier impact. Close on the heels

of 8 recently commissioned facilities, 6 new projects are in the pipeline. Your Company's leadership as **India's largest integrated paperboards and paper business** will be reinforced by the forthcoming acquisition of Century Pulp & Paper, raising capacity by over 50% to 1.5 million metric tonnes. The newly established **state-of-the-art Moulded Fibre Products** facility is pioneering complex engineered compostable solutions for single-use plastic substitution for both domestic and global markets. As each of your Company's businesses scales up in line with the ITC Next strategy, its manufacturing ecosystem is poised to expand further, contributing to India's aspiration to be a global manufacturing powerhouse.

Your Company's distributed manufacturing network is also a **vibrant hub of innovation, quality, sustainability and safety besides providing structural competitiveness**. An AI-first digital backbone in ITC's manufacturing facilities enhances efficiency, cost optimisation and responsiveness. Several units now meet nearly 100% of their electricity needs from renewable sources, are Platinum-rated green buildings or have achieved global AWS standards.

In line with ITC's deep commitment to an **Aatmanirbhar Bharat**, your Company is also placing sharper thrust on indigenisation and import substitution to **build structural competitiveness**. Your Company pioneered the **Bharat Fibre chain for its Paperboards business through massive afforestation, substituting imports and saving foreign exchange while creating a green cover, substantial rural livelihoods and larger value in India**. Today, this initiative has greened nearly **1.5 million acres, generating over 270 million person-days of employment**.

ITC also established the **first-of-its-kind Bleached Chemi-Thermo Mechanical Pulp Plant** at Bhadrachalam, creating domestic capability in specialised pulp, and is now investing in a second BCTMP mill. Additionally, investments have also been made in domestic capsule manufacturing capacity and a Decor Paper plant to substitute imports. These interventions will significantly enhance cost competitiveness while also enabling foreign exchange savings exceeding **₹17,500 crore over the next decade**.

For us at ITC, this is the larger meaning of **Bharat Built Manufacturing** in action — to **build globally competitive domestic manufacturing assets**, substitute imports, enrich the environment and support sustainable livelihoods.

ITC: Supporting Climate Action & Inclusive Growth

I now turn to two defining imperatives of our times — **climate resilience and livelihood generation** — both vital for a sustainable, inclusive and competitive future. For India, climate risks are acute, severely impacting agri-food security, livelihoods, productivity and infrastructure.

While the Government has spearheaded world-leading efforts, the consequences of the climate crisis demand far more urgent, collective and sustained action at scale — globally, nationally and locally.

To my mind, enterprises can take transformational measures to combat climate change and also foster inclusive development. ITC's comprehensive approach addresses climate risks through large-scale programmes aimed at decarbonisation, adaptation, nature-based solutions and circularity, while also implementing a mosaic of solutions for rural empowerment.

What differentiates ITC's sustainability journey is a triad of achievements. First, **Longevity**, that is reflected in decades of sustained environmental impact. Second, **Scale**, which is demonstrated through the massive creation of ecological capital and support to millions of livelihoods. Third, **Integration**, through a distinctive model where sustainability and inclusivity are core pillars of strategy, governance and programmes.

ITC is the only company in the world to be **carbon positive, water positive and solid waste recycling positive for around 2 decades now**. ITC's businesses support nearly **9 million sustainable livelihoods**.

Decarbonisation remains an important element of our climate action. Over the years, your Company has made significant investments in areas like renewable energy, green infrastructure and mobility. It is a matter of immense satisfaction that ITC has **surpassed several of its ambitious 2030 Sustainability 2.0 targets**, even as our businesses have expanded considerably. We are now committed to achieving **Net Zero Operations by 2050**, entailing a reduction in GHG by over 85% in the next 25 years.

While Decarbonisation has gained significant traction globally, **Adaptation** measures have not drawn the attention they deserve. The world, after breaching the 1.5°C threshold last year, is headed towards 2.8°C warming in this century if stronger pathways are not pursued. This is clearly alarming and calls for decisive and urgent action.

Recognising this, ITC has implemented impactful **Adaptation and Nature-based Solutions** for ecosystem restoration that strengthens climate resilience, enhances farm productivity, water availability, green cover and biodiversity while supporting rural livelihoods. ITC's **Climate Smart Agriculture**, which now spans nearly **32 lakh acres** across 17 States, benefits over **12 lakh farmers**. It is premised on focused programmes that **build strong capabilities through skilling, technology adoption and development of institutional linkages**. We propose to cover **40 lakh acres under this initiative by 2030**. Impact studies have shown that CSA practices in rice and wheat have reduced costs by **over 20%, improved yields by around 10% and enhanced net returns by over 23%** compared to conventional practices.

Your Company has built deep capabilities in water stewardship, afforestation and biodiversity conservation. ITC's **large-scale water management interventions** follow a three-pronged approach — community-led watershed programmes, demand-side agricultural water management and revival of river sub-basins. Demand-side initiatives, focussing on **"more crop per drop"**, cover over 20 lakh acres, creating annual water-saving potential of up to **50% across 15 crops, aggregating to 1.5 billion cubic metres**.

Supply-side watershed projects cumulatively span nearly **20 lakh acres**, helping around **90% of farmers** in catchments to cultivate through the year. Four river sub-basins have been made water positive, with work under way on the fifth. Such water stewardship interventions have improved gross cropped area by as much as 12%, cropping intensity and groundwater levels by up to 14 and 15% whilst delivering larger benefits for communities.

Biodiversity conservation is a key priority area for sustaining natural ecosystems, strengthening agri-food security, supporting rural livelihoods and building long-term resilience. Your Company's programme focuses on restoring ecosystem services that support agriculture. This is expected to cover **nearly 10 lakh acres by 2030**.

Your Company's **Social Investments Programme** spans **275 districts in 20 States**, cumulatively benefiting over **10 million people**, including **6 million women** while amplifying impact with 98 public-private-partnerships. While the scale and outcomes are deeply satisfying, what inspires us to do more are the human stories behind the numbers.

It is heartening to witness farmers with better incomes, women with greater economic agency, children with stronger learning foundations and youth

with improved employability. This larger purpose to make a meaningful difference defines the core of our social endeavours. India's ancient wisdom enshrined in **Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam** reminds us that the world is one family, and the responsibility to protect our only home — the planet as well as its people — rests on all of us. We believe that our **'dharma' of Responsible Competitiveness** and the spirit of **'Aparigraha'** to mindfully use resources as well as **'Abhyudaya'** which is premised on **simultaneous economic and societal progress**, are timeless principles that will continue to inspire us in creating enduring value for all stakeholders.

In Conclusion

As India advances towards becoming a developed nation, ITC will remain steadfast in its commitment to serve with purpose, innovate with responsibility, grow with the nation and multiply value for our country. **Our heart and soul have always belonged to India. This has been our legacy. It will remain our promise**.

It is a privilege for ITC to be part of this momentous journey — powered by an inspiring Vision, guided by unshakeable Values, and energised by renewed Vitality.

As I conclude, I would like to reaffirm my belief that your Company's greatest and most enduring asset is its people. It is their dedication, ingenuity and unwavering commitment that give wings to our ambition, resilience to our efforts and purpose to our progress. Their dedication gives us the courage to dream boldly and shape ITC as an exemplary institution of a new India with **passion, performance and purpose**.

On behalf of the Board and myself, I thank all our stakeholders for their continued trust, support and encouragement.

Together, let us partner India and help build a future worthy of the aspirations of this great nation.



BSE Sensex				Nifty 50				Nifty 500				Nifty Next 50				Nifty 100				BSE 150 MidCap				BSE 250 SmallCap			
CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE		PERCENT CHANGE	
78,639.03		0.70		24,774.30		1.60		23,802.85		1.46		74,608.70		1.30		25,880.45		1.55		17,143.20		0.73		7,152.45		1.32	
PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN		PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	
78,094.64		78,883.34		24,383.60		24,572.70		23,460.70		23,619.15		73,651.30		74,109.30		25,486.35		25,676.75		17,018.58		17,150.19		7,059.06		7,096.88	
HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW		HIGH		LOW	
78,895.10		78,497.34		24,774.30		24,515.15		23,803.75		23,578.55		74,611.80		74,055.80		25,880.65		25,627.20		17,191.09		17,076.46		7,167.70		7,089.19	

ITC: is worst behind after Q1?

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The tide appears to be turning for ITC Ltd. After months of pressure, investors looked past a bruising June-quarter (QIFY27) show in its cigarette business, sending the stock higher on Monday.

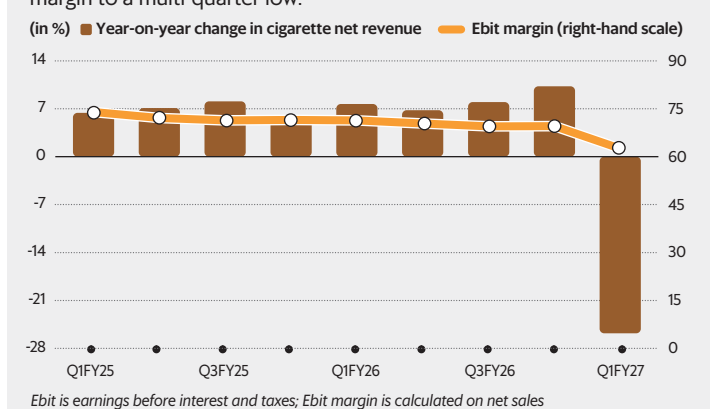
The cigarette segment's Ebit fell 35% year-on-year to ₹3,341 crore in Q1, reflecting the first full-quarter impact of the sharp tax increase that took effect on 1 February. Note that the cigarette Ebit at Godfrey Phillips India Ltd and VST Industries Ltd declined 52% and 41%, respectively.

The cigarette business contributes 76% of ITC's total segment Ebit, down from nearly 84% in FY26. "The profitability was worst hit in Q1 and within that, in April, followed by month-on-month improvement aided by the staggered price hikes," said analysts from Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India).

Following higher taxes, ITC staggered price hikes to limit the risk of smokers shifting to illicit products. Even after cumulative price hikes

Cause and effect

ITC's net cigarette revenue dipped sharply in QIFY27, dragging the Ebit margin to a multi-quarter low.



exceeding 20%, cigarette net revenue fell 25% on-year. Although volume erosion was less than feared.

"ITC's cigarette volume decline of 5% on-year in QIFY27 (versus 2% and 14.4% fall for Godfrey Phillips and VST) was much lower than the 10% decline that we/Street were expecting," said Nomura.

Against that backdrop, Jefferies India expects management to gain confidence to push through additional price hikes while limiting volume declines to the mid-single-digit for the rest of FY27. It also expects pressure on cigarette profitability to ease going ahead.

ITC's Q1 cigarette Ebit decline

"reflects only partial price hikes, especially those implemented towards the end of the quarter and this should get better, ahead," wrote Jefferies analysts in a report dated 1 August.

The weak showing in cigarettes, ITC's largest profit engine, weighed on overall earnings, which missed Street expectations. Standalone net operating revenue fell 14.4% on-year to ₹16,907 crore, while Ebitda margin contracted 500 basis points to 26.7%. The rest of the business, however, was encouraging.

The FMCG business delivered 12% revenue growth and a 20% increase in Ebit. Dairy, snacks, noodles and frozen snacks grew more than 20%, while personal care posted mid-teen growth. The *atta* business was hurt by heatwaves, liquified petroleum gas (LPG) shortage and benign wheat prices.

ITC's portfolio of digital-first and organic brands is now running at an annual revenue rate of about

₹1,500 crore. Inflation in edible oils, fuel and packaging was partly offset by inventory hedges, pricing actions and cost controls.

The paperboards, paper and packaging business also performed well, with revenue rising 9% and Ebit

jumping 38%, helped by stronger realizations, easing wood costs and a richer mix of value-added products.

The agri business remained the laggard. Revenue fell 17% because of weaker leaf tobacco demand, delayed wheat trading and the West Asia war disruptions. ITC shares were up about 2% on Monday but are still down 29% so far in 2026. "Although the demand environment remains

resilient across rural and urban, the current geopolitical situation, commodity volatility, and monsoon, etc., remain key monitorables," said the Jefferies report. The firm has upgraded ITC stock to Buy, enthused by volume resilience and expects improvement in the coming quarters.

BEYOND THE SMOKE

ITC's cigarette Ebit fell 35% y-o-y after steep tax hikes, hurting overall earnings

HOWEVER, cigarette profitability could improve ahead, aided by price hikes

Muthoot Finance's golden run starts to lose momentum

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Muthoot Finance's stock tanked as much as 7% on Monday after its reported net interest margin dropped sequentially by 297 basis points to 10.41% in the June quarter (QIFY27), leading to downgrades in earnings estimates.

A lower yield on gold loans played spoilsport for the company as prices of the yellow metal softened. The yield decline was due to lower lending rates and normalization, following strong interest recoveries and loan renewals

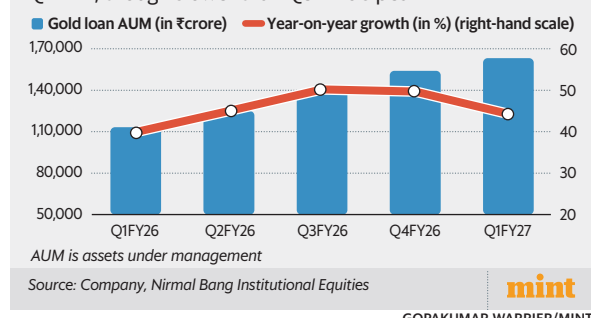
in FY26, aided by a rally in gold prices, the management said.

Gold loan disbursements to new customers grew 41% year-on-year. Gold loan assets under management (AUM) rose 44% on-year, improving customer addition, uptick in tonnage, higher loan-to-value and stable asset quality. Gold loan AUM growth seems decent in the current backdrop, though it was lower than the Q3FY26 peak of 50.2%.

Muthoot reiterated its AUM growth guidance of about 15% in FY27 but will revise the target after Q2FY27 earnings. The management acknowledged that competitive inten-

Dimming sparkle

Muthoot Finance's gold loan AUM growth was decent in QIFY27, though slower than Q3FY26's peak.



sity has risen substantially, with the company taking calibrated pricing cuts to defend AUM growth.

To strengthen its distribution muscle, Muthoot added 86 branches in Q1 at the group level, taking the total count to

7,654. It plans to add 500-600 branches this year.

While Muthoot should continue to deliver industry-leading profitability of about 5.5% return-on-assets and about 25% return on equity, loan growth is expected to normalize, said Nirmal Bang Institutional Equities.

Yields are expected to stabilize at 18-18.5% versus 17.93% in Q1 and 19.56% in Q4FY26, supported by new product offerings and pricing initiatives. But, according to the management, sustaining FY26-level yields is unlikely. A downside risk to yields lurks as several large and well-capi-

talized non-banks continue to scale-up gold loan franchises. Motilal Oswal Financial Services said there could be a brief period of aggressive customer acquisition in the industry, leading to persistent pressure on pricing, spreads and margins and so Muthoot may face a trade-off between protecting market share and preserving profitability despite robust demand.

Monday's sharp fall means the stock is down about 30% from its 52-week high of ₹4,149 on BSE on 29 January.

At the FY28 price-to-book, it trades at an expensive 1.98x, showed *Bloomberg* data.

FPIs return as net buyers for the first time since Iran war

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Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) turned net buyers in India's secondary cash market in July for the first time in five months, injecting ₹6,731.97 crore since the West Asia war began on 28 February.

Combined with ₹35,099 crore in purchases by domestic institutional investors (DIIs) and FPI short-covering of ₹3,297 Nifty and Nifty Bank futures contracts, the buying spree pushed the Nifty up 2.17% month-on-month to close July at 24,383.60, according to exchange and depository data. Short covering refers to traders closing out bearish derivatives positions by buying them back.

Analysts expect stronger foreign cash inflows and further short-covering in index futures to power a rally back towards pre-war levels of 25,178.65, provided geopolitical tensions cool

and, to a lesser extent, if the global AI trade continues to unwind. However, any escalation in the West Asia war could upset that forecast, they warned.

"The dampening of the AI trade and rising prospects of peace in war-torn West Asia have led to a slight recovery in FPI cash market inflows," said Kruti Shah, quant analyst at Equirus Securities. "If the geopolitical situation eases, we could break out of the 23,000-24,000 range the market has been stuck in since the war began, and head to the pre-war 25,000 level. If it gets worse from here, all bets will be off the table," she added.

On 27 February, the day before the war broke out, the



The buying spree pushed the Nifty up 2.17% in July. PTI

Nifty closed at 25,178.65. It has yet to reclaim that peak.

Even though Brent crude surged 24% to \$90.12 a barrel in July amid renewed US-Iran fighting, hopes are growing for a resolution that could drag prices back towards their pre-war level of \$72.48 seen on 28 February. To be sure, Brent tumbled 7.5% intraday on Monday from Friday's close after the US held back weekend strikes, as diplomatic efforts through interlocutors

resumed to fully reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

The unwinding of the AI trade has hit tech-heavy indices hard, with South Korea's Kospi dropping 22% month-on-month through the end of July, Taiwan's Taiex falling 13%, and the Nasdaq slipping 3.2% as June-quarter earnings missed expectations.

"The continued easing of crude prices and the possibility of increased rotation of funds from South Korea and Taiwan to India by global emerging-market funds could support a Nifty rally to its pre-war level," said Sudhir Joshi, consultant at Khambatta Securities.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

How Nifty, Sensex fell out of step on Mon

FROM PAGE 1

doing the opposite."

"The first day (of the closing auction) is a disaster, clearly reflective of an imbalance in demand and supply in the absence of a vibrant stock lending and borrowing mechanism," said Rajesh Baheti, director at Crosseas Capital.

A regulatory officer, who requested anonymity, said the divergence did not appear to be a systemic issue, but rather one of awareness asymmetry. "Closing auction is a new product and many people are unaware of how it works. Though the exact reason for the move in Nifty will be determined by NSE, such price movements should settle down in a day or two as awareness and participation goes up," this person said.

Queries to Sebi and the NSE remained unanswered till press time. On Monday, the 200-point surge in Nifty happened between 3:28 and 3:30 pm. The move coincided with the random order-closing window during the 20-minute auction from 3:15-3:35 pm, driving up the benchmark 1.6% to 24,774.3, while the Sensex rose 0.7% to 78,639.03. Even the Nifty futures rose only 0.87% to 24,664.9.

Unlike the earlier system, which calculates the closing price of a stock using the VVAP of trades over the last 30 minutes of a session, a closing auction framework determines a stock's closing price through demand and supply around a reference or volume weighted average price



The unusual trend followed the first day of the closing auction session for futures and options stocks. REUTERS

arrived at between 3 pm and 3:15 pm when continuous trading ends.

From 3:15 pm to 3:20 pm, no orders can be placed as a transition happens from continuous trading to auction. Orders can be placed in a +/- 3% band around the reference price during 3:20-3:30 pm, with the exchange closing the order window randomly between 3:28 pm and 3:30 pm.

All these orders are then matched by the exchange algorithm to determine the closing price, which is the one where most buy-sell trades are executable, released at 3:35 pm.

To be sure, the NSE has 93.1% share of the cash market with BSE holding the rest, and so, auction interest is likely to be greater on the former.

Baheti said the impact might have hit clients harder

were it an expiry day of weekly Nifty options (which incidentally falls on Tuesday), as these options derive their prices from the underlying Nifty index, which surged unexpectedly during the auction.

"Just imagine what could have happened on expiry day,

where deep out-of-the-money options (OTM) become in-the-money (ITM) ones and vice versa," he said. "After today's swing, I would expect many traders to square off their

options ahead of CAS tomorrow (Tuesday) so as to not be caught on the wrong foot."

OTM call options in this context refer to options that trade above spot prices. ITM refers to options that trade below the spot and, therefore, have intrinsic value.

Other market participants attributed the outsized moves

to orders being placed by large institutions during the auction.

"There is a possibility that institutional funds could have deployed incremental SIP money at closing (Monday), leading to more orders in a few index-based heavyweights on NSE, which has the lion's share of the cash market," said an official from a top brokerage in the context of the spike.

Indeed, heavyweights like ICICI Bank, HDFC Bank, Reliance Industries, Infosys and Bharti Airtel were among the top stocks traded at the auction worth a combined auction value of ₹244 crore, which was almost a fifth of the total auction value of ₹1,276.2 crore. Together, these stocks have a weighting of 36.33% on Nifty as of 31 July.

Another official said it is also likely that traders closed their intra-day positions during the initial few moments of the CAS unknowingly at 3:15 pm as they would usually offload such positions at that time.

Most of the people *Mint* spoke requested anonymity as the CAS was a regulatory mandate that took effect after intense consultations between the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) and market stakeholders, including exchanges and brokers, for a more robust price discovery mechanism. After two consultation papers in December 2024 and August 2025, Sebi fixed 3 August 2026 as the day for exchanges to implement the CAS.

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HSBC, SBI, ICICI get half of FCNR flows

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HSBC, State Bank of India (SBI) and ICICI Bank garnered half of all inflows under the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) deposit incentive scheme to attract dollars and strengthen the rupee, official data showed.

The new FCNR scheme allows non-resident Indians (NRIs) to make leveraged and unlevered deposits at Indian banks with the central bank taking the hedging risk, offering the potential for high returns. FCNR stands for foreign currency non-resident account and allows NRIs to keep fixed deposits in India in foreign currency. The scheme was announced on 5 June and rolled out three days later, running till the end of September.

Presenting data on the scheme's deposit inflows in Parliament on Monday, junior finance minister Pankaj Chaudhary said that as the fresh deposits mobilized by banks will be swapped with RBI, it is expected to increase the foreign exchange reserves as well as the banking system liquidity after the first leg of the transaction, and the same will be reversed on maturity.

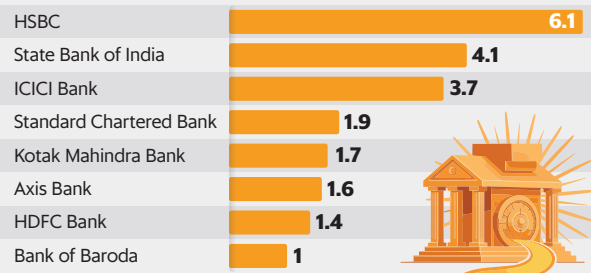
"The increase in foreign exchange reserves and banking system liquidity will depend on the total amount of foreign currency mobilized under the forex swap facility during the period," he said.

The data presented in Parliament showed the amount of outstanding FCNR deposits on 5 June—when the scheme was

Forex boost

Banks received \$36.7 billion under the FCNR route till 31 July.

Banks with largest net inflows into FCNR(B) scheme (\$ billion)



FCNR: Foreign currency non-resident. Net inflows calculated by subtracting outstanding numbers on 30 July and 5 June.

Source: Lok Sabha reply

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

announced—and where it stood on 30 July. For the banking sector, the difference between the two is \$28 billion. This is the net number and would account for withdrawals as well. Interestingly, RBI said in a statement on 1 August that banks have received \$36.7 billion under this route till 31 July.

A similar effort in 2013 had raised \$26 billion.

While for HSBC, the outstanding FCNR deposits rose to \$6.1 billion, for SBI and ICICI Bank, the deposits were \$4.1 billion and \$3.7 billion, respectively. Other banks that raised over \$1 billion include Standard Chartered Bank (\$1.9 billion), Kotak Mahindra Bank (\$1.7 billion), Axis Bank (\$1.6 billion), HDFC Bank (\$1.4 billion), and Bank of Baroda (\$1 billion).

Mint reported on 15 July that HSBC was offering non-NRIs leverage, or the use of

borrowed funds to enhance returns, of up to 19 times their own capital to create FCNR deposits through its GIFT City branch. This was touted as the largest such leverage offered by banks under the scheme. The leverage structure allows customers to pledge a relatively small amount of their

own capital and borrow the balance from the bank to create a much larger FCNR(B) deposit. Public-sector banks got \$8.8 billion under the scheme, private-sector banks \$10.7 billion and foreign banks \$8.4 billion. The remaining came into small finance banks and cooperative banks.

Apart from the FCNR scheme, RBI had also announced incentives to encourage foreign currency borrowings. Chaudhary said on Monday that to ensure the effectiveness of the schemes,

various factors such as prevailing market conditions, interest rate differentials, expected returns for investors, hedging costs and compliance requirements were considered.

"The potential cost of providing the swap facility would depend on the quantum of foreign exchange mobilized, the maturity of the swaps and exchange rate as well as the forward premia at the time of the swap," he said.

Analysts are bullish on the prospects of the RBI scheme. Suresh Ganapathy, managing director and head of financial services research at Macquarie Capital wrote to clients on Monday that at the current rate of \$10 billion per week run rate of FCNR flows, and considering the deadline is 30 September, and 31 December for the foreign currency borrowing windows, India will comfortably be past the initial expectations of \$80 billion.

Goldman Sachs said in a note on 31 July that RBI's June measures have attracted strong foreign currency inflows. The note said that in an interview (to *The Hindu Business Line*), RBI governor (Sanjay Malhotra) highlighted that banks have garnered around \$32 billion of inflows under RBI's swap facilities, with the deposits under the FCNR(B) scheme accounting for a bulk of the inflows.

"However, the corresponding increase in RBI's foreign currency assets (FCA) has been more modest, thus far, at around \$8 billion, reflecting the lag between banks getting deposits and subsequently swapping these inflows with RBI," the note said.



Family offices bring patient capital to deeptech startups

Deeptech ecosystem investments rose from \$302 million in 2020 to \$1.34 billion in 2025

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India's wealthiest families are stepping into one of the country's toughest startup funding gaps, backing deeptech firms that often require years of patient capital before becoming commercially viable.

India's family offices have grown to more than 300 in 2024 from 45 in 2018, managing \$30-35 billion in assets, according to a November 2025 PwC report. Their startup investments surged to about \$1.8 billion in 2025 from \$654 million in 2020, Venture Intelligence data showed.

Within that, investments by single family offices into deeptech startups surged nearly 30-fold to \$467.1 million in 2025 from \$15.3 million in 2020, according to Tracxn, as investors increasingly backed companies developing technologies such as space, semiconductors, artificial intelligence (AI), and defence.

Overall investment in India's deeptech ecosystem rose from \$302 million in 2020 to \$1.34 billion in 2025. Single family office investment stood at \$215.6 million year-to-date as of 27 July 2026, Tracxn data showed.

Unlike venture capital funds, which must return capital within fixed fund cycles, family offices invest their own wealth without fixed investment horizons, allowing them to back deeptech companies over 15 to 20 years or longer—often the time needed to commercialise complex technologies.

"Since venture funds manage other people's money, they typically promise returns within five to six years. Deeptech businesses often don't fit that timeline because they require continuous investment and refinement before they become commercially viable. That's where family offices have an

Doubling down

Investments by single family offices into deeptech startups surged nearly 30-fold from \$15.3 million in 2020 to \$467.1 million in 2025.

Funding by single-family offices in India's deep-tech startups

Funding year	Total funding (in \$ million)	Number of rounds
2016	2.2	3
2017	45.0	7
2018	5.9	4
2019	61.1	4
2020	15.3	7
2021	66.7	15
2022	218.3	23
2023	189.9	23
2024	153.4	25
2025	467.1	18
2026*	215.6	5

*Data up to 27 July 2026
Source: Tracxn

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

advantage. They are able to take a longer-term view and support businesses that need patient capital," said Suraj Malik, founding partner at Legacy Growth, a multi-family office boutique firm specializing in family business succession planning and transac-

tion advisory services. Malik, whose firm has advised on deeptech deals, said the lower year-to-date investment figure was "more of a momentary phase in how the data is being interpreted. I don't believe there's any structural reduction in investments. It may simply be a tempo-

rary fluctuation rather than a long-term trend." Conviction is also showing up in cheque sizes. Average investments increased from \$4.4 million in 2021 to \$26 million in 2025 and \$43.1 million year-to-date, according to Tracxn.

DEEPLY PATIENT

AS family offices invest without fixed investment horizons they can back the startups for longer

INVESTMENTS by family offices rose from \$4.4 mn on average in 2021 to \$26 mn in 2025

FAMILY offices are also increasingly investing alongside specialist venture funds

THESE family offices use specialist funds' technical expertise to evaluate complex technologies

tion advisory services.

Malik, whose firm has advised on deeptech deals, said the lower year-to-date investment figure was "more of a momentary phase in how the data is being interpreted. I don't believe there's any structural reduction in investments. It may simply be a tempo-

"Back in the day, it would probably have been ₹3-5 crore. Now, family offices are more than happy to go to about five or eight times, possibly even 10 times, what they were investing earlier," said Sanjeev Rajput, founder and chief executive of Capital Connect, an investment banking advisory firm.

Beyond patient capital, family offices are increasingly investing alongside specialist venture funds with the technical expertise to evaluate complex technologies.

"As a family office, we follow a split strategy, 10% allocation to new managers who have domain expertise and skin in the game, and 90% allocation to experienced venture capital funds," said Jai S. Rupani, chief investment officer and principal, Dinesh Hinduja Family Office.

Rupani cited Yali Capital, which raised \$104 million for its debut deeptech fund in 2025. "In my mind, every investment today is deeptech because the world has become heavily data-driven," he added.

Government support has also strengthened investor confidence. The Centre's ₹1 trillion Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund has begun deploying capital, with space-tech startups receiving ₹833.89 crore in the first round of approvals—the largest allocation across sectors, according to a government document reviewed by *Mint*.

"Family offices are increasingly looking at deeptech because the government has made it a strategic priority...Countries like the US and China are moving aggressively, with hundreds of space missions planned every year, while India is still at a much earlier stage. That gap itself creates a significant investment opportunity," said Anirudh Damani, managing partner at Artha Venture Fund, a micro-VC firm founded by the Damani family office.

Artha Venture Fund has backed Agnikul Cosmos since March 2020 and last invested in 2025, when the rocket startup raised ₹150 crore at a \$500 million valuation.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Peak XV-backed Neo Group to enter investment banking

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Peak XV Partners- and TVS Capital-backed wealth and asset management platform Neo Group has appointed veteran investment banker Vikas Khattar to build and lead its investment banking business, according to three people with knowledge of the development.

Khattar, currently co-head of investment banking and head of equity capital markets (ECM) and the financial services group at Ambit Capital, will build Neo's merchant banking business from the ground up, the people said.

The move reflects a broader trend of new-age financial services firms branching into investment banking as India's fast-growing wealth management industry fuels demand for capital markets and advisory services.

"The firm has applied for merchant banking licence with the capital markets regulator-Sebi (Securities and Exchange Board of India)," one of the persons cited above said.

Khattar, a BITS Pilani and IIM Calcutta alumnus, has more than three decades of experience across DSP Merrill Lynch, Citibank, Morgan Stanley, HSBC, Jefferies and Ambit.

He joined Ambit Capital in 2018, where he built the firm's ECM business. Since then, Ambit has completed more than 250 equity capital markets transactions across initial public offerings (IPOs), block deals and follow-on public offerings, according to its website.

Among the marquee trans-



Neo Group operates in more than 30 Indian cities and has a presence in the US, employing over 850 professionals. ISTOCKPHOTO

actions Khattar has worked on are the Coal India IPO, BSE IPO, Motherson Sumi's Euro bond issue, Laurus Laboratories' IPO and ICICI Bank's ADR, among others.

Ambit Capital offers investment banking, asset management, wealth management, institutional equities and SME lending. Its investment banking arm advises on corporate finance, equity capital markets and mergers and acquisitions. In 2024, the group's NBFC arm, Ambit Finance, raised ₹410 crore from Japanese investment bank Daiwa Securities Group.

Earlier this year, Ambit appointed Skanda Jayaraman as co-head of its investment banking business.

"Khattar is likely to hire a team of bankers to set up the investment banking practice and will also help oversee the larger growth of the firm," another person cited above said.

Emailed queries to Khattar, Ambit Capital, and Neo Group did not elicit any response until press time.

Neo Group has been expanding rapidly. In July, it raised ₹350 crore in a funding round led by Peak XV Partners, following a ₹550 crore investment from TVS Capital. Valued at ₹10,000 crore, the company became one of the latest financial services unicorns.

Founded in 2021 by Nitin Jain, also an IIM Calcutta alumnus, Neo managed about ₹1.3 trillion in client assets as of June. It operates in more than 30 Indian cities and has a presence in the US, employing over 850 professionals, including more than 150 senior wealth advisers.

Neo's expansion comes as India's wealth management industry is growing rapidly, driven by rising disposable incomes, an expanding base of high-net-worth individuals and increasing financialization. According to Deloitte, assets under management in the country's wealth management industry are projected to reach \$2.3 trillion by FY29.

Backed by deep-pocketed investors, new-age firms such as Deserve, Groww, Asset Plus, Centricity and Wealthy are expanding their offerings in an effort to capture a larger share of the market.

EXTRACTS OF UNAUDITED CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30 JUNE 2026				
Sr. No.	Particulars	For the quarter ended		
		30 June 2026	30 June 2025	31 March 2026
		Unaudited	Unaudited	Audited (Refer note 3)
1	Total income from operations	11,278.54	10,207.14	11,337.19
2	EBITDA *	1,329.14	1,309.80	1,454.84
3	Net profit for the period (before tax, exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	1,033.59	969.05	1,158.02
4	Net profit for the period before tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	1,033.59	969.05	1,112.32
5	Net profit for the period after tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	768.66	714.66	834.21
6	Total comprehensive income for the period (comprising profit for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive income (after tax))	766.03	713.57	920.15
7	Paid up equity share capital (face value of ₹ 2/- each)	164.82	164.73	164.79
8	Other equity	20,417.22	17,249.22	19,626.49
9	Securities premium account	4,145.35	4,120.10	4,134.58
10	Net worth	20,582.04	17,413.95	19,791.28
11	Paid up debt capital #	99.00	99.00	99.00
12	Outstanding redeemable preference shares	-	-	-
13	Debt equity ratio	0.38	0.35	0.37
14	Earning per share (EPS) (face value of ₹ 2/- each)			
	a) Basic (in ₹)	9.34	8.67	10.24
	b) Diluted (in ₹)	9.32	8.66	10.22
	(EPS for the quarter not annualised)			
15	Capital redemption reserve	62.50	20.00	62.50
16	Debt redemption reserve #	-	-	-
17	Debt service coverage ratio	5.40	2.94	4.96
18	Interest service coverage ratio	9.90	9.57	10.39
* EBITDA = Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation & amortisation and other income				
# Listed debenture				
Notes:				
1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly/yearly financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 and Regulation 52 read with Regulation 63 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 [SEBI (LODR)]. The full format of the standalone and consolidated quarterly/yearly financial results along with other line items referred in Regulation 52(4) of the SEBI (LODR) are available on the Company's website: (www.jindalstainless.com) and on the websites of Bombay Stock Exchange (www.bseindia.com) and the National Stock Exchange of India Ltd. (www.nseindia.com). The same can be accessed by scanning the QR Code provided below.				
2 Standalone financial information of the Company, pursuant to regulation 47(1)(b) of SEBI (LODR) :				
Particulars	For the quarter ended			For the year ended
	30 June 2026	30 June 2025	31 March 2026	31 March 2026
	Unaudited	Unaudited	Audited (Refer note 3)	Audited
Total income from operations	10,676.55	10,340.51	10,826.47	42,680.22
EBITDA*	1,028.41	1,047.79	1,111.16	4,322.20
Profit before tax (before exceptional items)	815.27	862.78	932.97	3,579.68
Profit before tax (after exceptional items)	815.27	862.78	1,115.39	3,736.57
Profit after tax	605.89	641.64	891.57	2,842.95
3 The figures for the quarter ended 31 March 2026 are the balancing figures between audited figures in respect of full financial year and published year to date figures upto the third quarter of year ended 31 March 2026.				
By Order of the Board of For Jindal Stainless Limited				
Tarun Kumar Khulbe Chief Executive officer and Whole Time Director DIN: 07302532				
Place: New Delhi Date: 03 August 2026				

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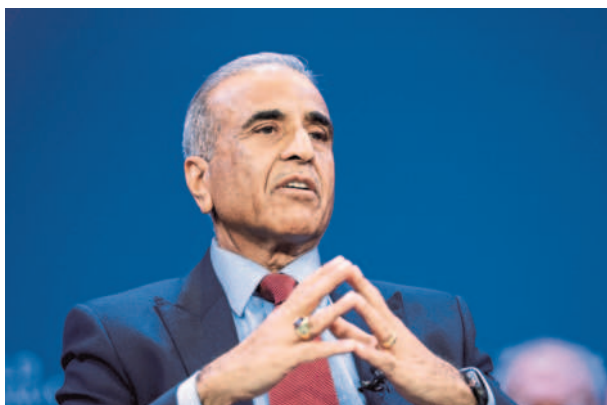
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Sunil Bharti Mittal, Bharti Airtel chairman

REUTERS

Network spends to stay high at Airtel

Jatin Grover

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Bharti Airtel Ltd signalled that elevated network spending is here to stay, with chairman Sunil Bharti Mittal saying the telecom operator expects to keep investing \$3-4 billion (approximately ₹28,500-38,000 crore) annually despite completing the bulk of its 5G rollout.

The guidance signals that even as the peak 5G rollout phase winds down, technology upgrades and network expansion will continue to require multi-billion-dollar investments. It also comes as telecom operators grapple with a key challenge: turning heavy 5G investments into meaningful revenue growth.

"This is a highly capital-intensive industry. A large part of our cash flow that generates, gets into networks, whether it is cables, data centres, towers, more radio base stations, transmission elements and indeed laying out fibre across the country. We will continue to do so," Mittal said at the

company's 31st annual general meeting (AGM) on Monday.

According to Mittal, Airtel's capex has typically been \$3-4 billion a year, with a large part of its 5G investments made over the past three years.

"Over a period of time, you should start seeing tapering off of the capex, but I would say that, given the nature of industry, where technology shifts keep on happening at a breakneck speed, capex will always be multi-billion dollars - \$3 to \$4 billion a year," he said.

Airtel spent about ₹1.45 trillion on capital expenditure, including its 5G rollout, between FY23 and FY26, according to quarterly reports. Annual consolidated capex stood at \$3-5.9 billion between FY24

Airtel spent about ₹1.45 trillion on capital expenditure, including its 5G rollout, between FY23 and FY26

and FY26, as per its March quarter earnings report.

Mittal's comments are significant because much of Airtel's recent spending was driven by 5G deployment. Yet the company acknowledged in its FY26 annual report that monetisation remains challenging due to limited compelling consumer use cases.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Swiggy, Eternal take different routes to grow food delivery

Swiggy is banking on affordability through Toing while Eternal is investing in Blinkit's Bistro

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Swiggy Ltd and Eternal Ltd—India's two listed food delivery companies—acknowledge that the next phase of growth will hinge on adding new users rather than driving higher order frequency among existing customers. However, their latest shareholder letters reveal sharply divergent strategies to achieve this.

Swiggy is banking on affordability through its dedicated, standalone meals app Toing to attract price-sensitive consumers, using its existing restaurant and delivery ecosystem. Zomato's parent Eternal, however, emphasises that lower-priced meals cannot be sustained by simply reducing commissions and delivery fees. Instead, it is investing in Bistro by Blinkit, a separate vertically integrated food business that redesigns kitchen operations and supply chains to prepare low-priced meals.

The divergence comes even as both companies continue to report steady growth in their core food delivery businesses. Swiggy's food delivery gross order value (GOV), or the total value of orders placed, rose 17.4% to ₹9,490 crore in the June quarter. Zomato's net order value (NOV), which excludes customer discounts and certain charges, grew more than 20% to ₹10,769 crore, its fourth straight quarter of accelerating growth.

Swiggy's food delivery business served an average 19.2 million monthly transacting users during the quarter, compared with Zomato's 27 million, indicating that both companies are now looking for incremental growth.

This underscores a broader shift in how India's food delivery leaders are



The divergence comes even as both companies continue to report steady growth in their core food delivery businesses.

PTI

thinking about expansion. Rather than repositioning their flagship apps around cheaper meals, both have opted to build separate propositions aimed at new consumption occasions while preserving the positioning of their core brands.

Bain Capital Ventures to expand its kitchen setup in March this year.

Swiggy has positioned Toing as a vehicle to expand the food delivery market rather than merely redistribute existing demand. The company said in

GROWTH PLAY

SWIGGY is banking on affordability through Toing to attract price-sensitive consumers

TOING is positioned as a vehicle to grow food delivery, rather than redistributing existing demand

ETERNAL says that lower-priced meals cannot be sustained by simply reducing commissions

INSTEAD, it is investing in Bistro by Blinkit, a separate vertically integrated food business

This comes as competition in food delivery intensifies. Rapido has entered the market with its zero-commission platform Ownly in Bengaluru, while Flipkart is preparing its own launch later this year. Meanwhile, Swish raised \$38 million in funding from Hara Global and

its June quarter shareholders' letter that two out of every three new Toing users are either new to Swiggy or previously dormant customers, while restaurants are already seeing meaningful incremental volumes from the platform. It has expanded Toing to about

50 cities and said the app runs on Swiggy's existing logistics network, limiting the need for significant incremental infrastructure.

"We have been able to launch Toing without any significant incremental fixed costs (unlike new competition who will have to build the entire stack from the ground up) by leveraging our existing tech and execution capabilities. The initial investment in Toing is largely on new user acquisition, which is discretionary in nature and can be quickly scaled or cut-back depending on the progress," Swiggy said in its letter.

The Bengaluru-based company has also been careful to distinguish Toing from Bolt, its quick-preparation food offering sitting in the main Swiggy app. While Bolt is designed around speed and convenience for existing users, Toing operates as a separate app focused on lower-priced meals and attracting more value-conscious consumers.

The affordability push also follows Swiggy's decision earlier this year to shut down Snacc, its standalone 15-minute food delivery app, after finding the rapid-delivery model difficult to scale profitably.

Eternal, however, believes affordability alone is not enough. Responding to investor questions on Toing and Rapido-backed Ownly, founder Deepinder Goyal said such platforms have had limited impact so far because they rely on lower commissions and delivery fees to offer cheaper prices without fundamentally changing how food is produced or delivered. "What we are spending energy on is Bistro—which is our answer to the question these platforms are pretending to solve. If you want to make food delivery work at ₹50-150 price points, you can't do it without supply chain innovation," Goyal wrote in the shareholder letter.

Mega IPOs in September to add fuel to rebound

FROM PAGE 1

according to Prime Database.

Recent listings this year include SBI Funds Management, Manipal Health, Indo-IMM, Cube Highways and Juniper Green Energy, signalling that companies are once again finding investor demand.

In comparison, IPO fundraising touched ₹61,500 crore in January-July 2025, with the full year seeing a record ₹1,75,914 crore of funds being raised, from ₹1,59,784 crore in 2024.

"We are seeing a clear revival in IPO activity as market volatility has moderated and investor confidence has improved. Several companies that had deferred launches due to global uncertainty are now actively preparing to access the market," said Raghav Gupta, joint CEO of IIFL Capital. He added that the pipeline of companies that have either filed or are preparing to file is among the strongest in recent years.

According to Ankita Rajgaria, partner at Bahuguna Law Associates, the volume is substantial, "with about 245 DRHPs in the pipeline includ-

Street party

Monthly IPO fundraising in 2026		
Month	No of issues	Issue amount (in ₹ crore)
Jan	3	4,765
Feb	7	8,162
Mar	8	5,852
Apr	2	1,076
May	NA	NA
Jun	7	2,718
Jul	12	28,584
Aug	1	420

Source: Prime Database

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

ing 175 under Sebi observation."

The current pipeline spans financial services, healthcare, consumer, manufacturing, technology and new-age businesses, including Dhoot Transmissions, Zepto, Shiprocket, PhonePe, Oyo and Milky Mist.

Gupta added that if market conditions remain supportive, IPO capital raised in 2026 could surpass last year's levels. "More importantly, we expect higher quality issuers and a wider sector mix, which would make this cycle more sustainable," he said.

Emails sent to Jio and NSE

on Friday remained unanswered.

To be sure, IPO activity has been concentrated in the latter half of recent years, with the first half often disrupted by macroeconomic uncertainties such as covid-19, wars and tariffs, said Prime Database managing director Pranav Haldea. "With DIIs (domestic institutional investors) increasingly playing a huge role, listing activity has sustained through December," he added.

The IPO market has navigated geopolitical conflicts, trade wars and foreign investor outflows since the

start of the year, leaving DIIs to play a larger role in price discovery.

DIIs have pushed back against aggressive valuations in several offerings, resulting in sharp markdowns from companies' last private funding rounds. While such corrections are inevitable, companies are recalibrating issue sizes and staggering fundraising plans to better match investor demand, Gupta said.

While global investors remain selective, strong participation from DIIs and retail investors has provided a solid foundation for the IPO market, he said. Foreign capital, though selective, would further strengthen demand, particularly for well-priced, high-quality large IPOs.

Not all IPO-bound companies, however, are rushing to market. Several are reassessing timing as market volatility has compressed valuations and altered issue sizes, forcing them to refile draft papers or defer listings altogether.

Quick commerce company Zepto, for instance, said last week it would raise funds through a pre-IPO private placement before proceeding with its public listing after facing steep valuation haircuts during investor roadshows.

While the regulator does not intervene in valuation pricing, "it is aggressively stress-testing the factual basis

behind high-valuation narratives", said Archana Balasubramanian, partner at Agama Law Associates. "In DRHP reviews, the strongest push-back centres on

key performance indicators, related-party transactions, and vague allocations toward 'general corporate purposes'.

The regulator is insisting on empirical verification from merchant bankers for operational metrics to ensure retail investors aren't buying into inflated storytelling," she added.

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For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Centre to sell up to 6.5% stake in LIC

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The government will sell up to a 6.5% stake in Life Insurance Corp. (LIC) at a floor price of ₹382/share through a two-day offer for sale (OFS) beginning Tuesday.

The issue opens for non-retail investors on Tuesday and for retail investors on Wednesday.

If fully subscribed, the sale of over 822.2 million shares or a 6.5% stake at the given floor price will fetch about ₹31,000 crore to the disinvestment kitty.

"Government offers to disinvest 2.5% equity with an additional 4% as a green shoe option," Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (Dipam) secretary Arunish Chawla said in a post on X.

The floor price is at a 10% discount over Monday's closing price of LIC shares of ₹424.35 on the BSE.

The stake sale will help LIC achieve the minimum public shareholding requirement mandated by the Securities and



The issue opens for non-retail investors today.

REUTERS

Exchange Board of India (Sebi) ahead of schedule.

Sebi had given LIC time till 16 May 2027 to achieve a minimum 10% public shareholding. At present, the government holds a 96.5% stake in LIC.

It had earlier sold 3.5% through an initial public offering (IPO) in May 2022 at a price band of ₹902-949 per share, raising about ₹21,000 crore.

LIC currently has a market capitalization of over ₹5.36 trillion. LIC shares settled at ₹424.35 on Monday, down 0.12% over the previous close on BSE.

India's power grid infra is tripping on data centre boom

FROM PAGE 1

Since releasing its data centre policy in April 2022, Odisha has drawn significant technology investments. Key projects include a ₹14,257 crore AI-ready data centre from HCLTech and unicorn Sarvam, an ₹800 crore investment by the Adani Group, and smaller sites such as CtrlS's 5MW unit in Chandrasekharpur and Airtel subsidiary Nxtra's 1 MW facility.

Now, the state is racing to install the required power infrastructure. Sharma told *Mint* that Odisha is currently installing a 400 kilovolt (kV) substation, work on which "is expected to be completed in

12-14 months".

"We're then installing a new 765kV power grid, which will take roughly 2.5-3 years to build," Sharma added. High-voltage power substations are crucial for running power-hungry facilities such as data centres without sapping the electricity meant for consumers and other industries.

Odisha is not alone in acknowledging the transmission infrastructure shortage. A senior official at the Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd said the state's power transmission network "cannot support the scale of demand being sought by AI developers".

"With the existing network, if a data centre wants 500MW or 1GW of power capacity within a year, that demand can't be met. Mumbai's total demand currently stands at close to 4.5GW; supplying the next 5GW would need new 400kV and 765kV substations, and high-voltage transmission lines. Building this would take 4-5 years," the official said.

The state is working to meet this demand. On 13 March, Bajaj Projects Ltd, formerly a unit of Bajaj Electricals Ltd, announced a deal worth over ₹700 crore from MSETCL to establish a 400kV power substation along with transmission lines. It also won a ₹100 crore contract from Tata Power for additional power

infrastructure from an existing substation on 16 March, a ₹300 crore, two-year contract for a 765kV substation from Power-Grid Corp. of India Ltd on 13



For operators, the primary operational bottleneck has shifted from land to power.

REUTERS

infrastructure from an existing substation on 16 March, a ₹300 crore, two-year contract for a 765kV substation from Power-Grid Corp. of India Ltd on 13

May, and another ₹400 crore, two-year deal from an unnamed data centre company for a 400kV substation on 3 June—all in Maharashtra.

In short, public and private firms have poured ₹1,500 crore into upgrading Maharashtra's power infrastructure

over the past four months—a critical boost for India's data centre hub. The state government said in March it has signed deals for ₹5 trillion of data centre investments. The state is expecting additional 5GW by 2030.

A senior official at Tamil Nadu Generation and Distribution Corp. (Tangedco), who also requested anonymity, said

that apart from a power infrastructure shortage, Chennai, which is India's second-largest data centre hub, faces another major challenge: land for new substations.

"Existing data centres are accommodated, but expanding capacity takes years as land for new substations is scarce," the official said.

This mismatch between project construction and grid readiness is becoming acute. Sabyasachi Majumdar, senior director at credit rating firm CareEdge,

said, "Today, data centres are ready in 12-18 months and solar farms in 18-24 months. But transmission infrastructure still takes 3-4 years, which is why regulators, discoms, transmission utilities and private companies need to plan long-term."

A July 2026 report by consulting firm KPMG said the rise of AI workloads is expected to sharply increase demand for higher-capacity electrical infrastructure. AI racks typically require 50-60kW of power each, compared with 8-12kW for conventional data centre racks, necessitating heavier-duty power distribution equipment and stronger grid connectivity.



Pushback follows a proposed overhaul by Sebi.

BLOOMBERG

Sebi urged to not eliminate ODR platforms

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Executives from several online dispute resolution (ODR) platforms are writing to the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to urge the regulator to refine the existing dispute framework rather than dismantle independent platform roles.

The pushback follows a proposed overhaul by the market regulator that could eliminate independent ODR entities, stranding multi-year investments in technology, compliance, and specialized teams, according to industry executives and experts.

Executives noted that Sebi had not discussed with them about the proposed changes. Typically, the regulator engages in formal or informal discussions with affected entities before issuing public proposals.

"We are planning to make a representation to Sebi to upgrade the existing ODR system but in consultation with ODR platforms. Ideas should be shared with us and moved forward," said Deepika Kinhal, chief executive at the Centre for Online Dispute Resolution (CORD).

Currently, investor complaints pass through Sebi's SCORES platform before escalation to seven empanelled ODR platforms: CORD, Centre for Alternate Dispute Resolution Excellence (CADRE), Webnyay, Presolv360, Sama, Just Act, and Jupitice.

Mint's queries emailed to Sebi did not elicit a response.

CORD's Kinhal noted that platforms have repeatedly warned Sebi about an unviable fee structure: while handling a conciliation costs an ODR platform around ₹2,500, it receives just ₹600 from the total fee (₹3,240 for an unsuccessful conciliation and ₹4,800 for a successful one), with the remainder going to the conciliator.

To make matters worse, market participants fail to pay the conciliation fee in nearly 30% of cases, forcing ODR platforms to pay conciliators out of pocket while waiting for reimbursement, she said. "This problem will not be solved even if MIs take charge, as MIs could have anyway come in to penalize the market participants for non-payment of fees, but that did not happen," Kinhal added.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



Nexus Select eyes eight retail acquisitions

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Nexus Select Trust, India's only publicly listed retail real estate investment trust (Reit), is planning its next phase of expansion with eight retail acquisitions across multiple cities, as it enters eastern India and deepens its presence in existing markets.

The pipeline spans shopping centres in the capital cities of states including Bihar and Jharkhand, one asset in southern India, and additional land and built-up space at two locations where the Reit already operates in north India, according to people familiar with the plans. Two of the transactions are currently in the due diligence stage, these people said.

Among the deals, the Blackstone Group-backed Reit is acquiring a 500,000 sq. ft shopping centre in Guwahati as part of a brownfield development that will also include a 164-key hotel.

On Monday, the Reit reported an 11% year-on-year increase in net operating income to ₹510 crore for the April-June quarter. It declared a distribution of ₹370 crore (₹2.44 per unit), up 10% from a year earlier.

"Backed by a strong balance sheet, low leverage, and nearly \$1 billion of available debt headroom, we are well-positioned to capitalize on inorganic growth opportunities and continue scaling our platform," Dalip Sehgal, executive director and chief executive at Nexus Select Trust, told *Mint*.

Nexus Reit owns 19 shopping centres across 15 cities, along with three hotel assets and three office assets.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

New capital pools emerge to fuel India's net-zero push

As projects mature, investors shift towards transmission, storage and climate infrastructure

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New pools of long-term capital are emerging for India's energy transition, with investors broadening their focus beyond renewable power generation to include transmission, energy storage, and climate infrastructure.

Speaking at the *Mint* Sustainability Summit during a discussion on the new economics of net zero, Ajay Chaudhary, chief executive officer of NIIF Infrastructure Finance Ltd (NIIF IFL), said, "The real game changer will be the entry of long-duration capital from sovereign wealth funds and pension funds into sustainable infrastructure."

India's transition towards its 2070 net-zero target is expected to require significant investments across renewable energy, transmission networks, storage, electric mobility and other low-carbon infrastructure. As these sectors mature, investors said the financing landscape is also becoming more sophisticated.

"Construction-stage assets attract one category of investors. Once projects become operational and cash flows become predictable, another pool of capital is ready to take over those assets," Chaudhary said, adding that investors are increasingly specialising according to the level of risk they are willing to assume.

He said the market is already witnessing the emergence of dedicated investment vehicles targeting climate infrastructure. "We are seeing investors create dedicated platforms with long investment horizons. Large private equity firms have already started transmission platforms with over a billion dollars of equity committed," he said.

Development finance institutions are also increasingly positioning them-



(From Left) Ajay Chaudhary, Shilpa Kumar and Ashok Kumar Sharma.



selves as catalysts to attract private capital into newer segments of the climate economy. "Our role is to invest where commercial capital is not yet willing to go. We look for opportunities where our capital can catalyse much larger pools of private investment," said Shilpa Kumar, managing director and head of India at British International Investment (BII).

As sectors mature and project risks reduce, a broader range of institutional investors is expected to participate, she said. "As sectors mature and projects become de-risked, you open them up to a much larger pool of capital," Kumar said. She added that BII also actively seeks to bring in like-minded institutional investors alongside its own investments.

"One of the things we focus on is whether other investors with similar

ESG standards and a willingness to finance these sectors can join us on that journey," Kumar said. BII had recently invested nearly \$300 million alongside Copenhagen Infrastructure Partners in one platform, while another investment later attracted a global fund focused on Africa and Asia after project risks had reduced.

Environmental, social and governance (ESG) standards are expanding the investor universe. "Strong ESG performance improves the long-term sustainability of businesses and enables them to attract follow-on capital," Kumar said.

This comes even as lenders maintain that financing availability in India remains robust. "Nearly 96% of the debt flowing into India is domestic capital. Foreign debt accounts for only about 4%. The bulk of the money flow-

ing into India is Indian money," said Ashok Kumar Sharma, deputy managing director, chief credit officer and chief sustainability officer at State Bank of India.

Sharma added that liquidity has remained ample in the banking system. "Money is not the issue. Banks have consistently been sitting on surplus liquidity of around ₹4 lakh crore for many years," he said.

The panelists said the next phase of India's climate financing story will be shaped less by the availability of capital and more by the ability to create bankable, de-risked projects capable of attracting increasingly diverse pools of long-term investors.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

Aadhar Housing sees no immediate need to raise funds

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NEW DELHI

Aadhar Housing Finance Ltd, the Blackstone-backed lender, is sufficiently capitalized to fund its planned expansion and annual loan growth of about 20%, and does not expect to raise fresh capital for at least the next four years.

"Our capital adequacy today is upwards of 40%. Even if we keep expanding by around 50 branches every year for the next four years and grow at 20-22% annually, we do not need capital," Rishi Anand, managing director and chief executive officer, said in an interview with *Mint*. "There is no capital raise on the anvil right now. We are sufficiently capitalized."

The company plans to add about 50 branches in FY27, taking its network beyond the current 628. Of these additions, 70% will be in emerging locations and 30% in urban centres. The expansion will be focused on key markets,,

including Gujarat, while the lender remains relatively cautious on parts of eastern India and Kerala.

Anand said the lender's increasing presence in *tabu*s and district centres is expected to strengthen growth without compromising asset quality. While the gross non-performing asset (NPA) ratio stood at 1.31% at the end of the June quarter, he described it as seasonal and reiterated that the company will close the current financial year with GNPA in the range of 1.08-1.10%, broadly in line with the previous year.

According to Anand, lend-



Rishi Anand, MD & CEO, Aadhar Housing Finance.

ing in smaller markets allows the company to be more selective in choosing borrowers while also earning higher risk-adjusted spreads.

"When you do small business, you can pick and choose the better consumer profile. Second, these locations give us risk-adjusted higher spreads. We anticipate the risk and price accordingly, so the portfolio remains balanced," he said.

The company is targeting relatively modest incremental

business in new locations, aiming for ₹50 lakh to ₹1 crore of additional monthly business from individual branches, rather than pursuing aggressive volume growth.

Anand said Aadhar Housing continues to focus primarily on retail home loans. During the April-June quarter, home loans accounted for about 74% of disbursements while loans against property constituted 26%, compared with its usual mix of about 70:30.

He added that affordable housing demand remains stronger than expected.

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MUNJAL SHOWA LIMITED				
CIN: L34101HR1985PLC020934				
Registered Office & Works: Plot No. 9-11, Maruti Industrial Area Sector-18, Gurugram-122015 (Haryana) Tel: +91-124-4783000 Fax: +91-124-2341359 Email: pgupta@munjalshowa.net Website: www.munjalshowa.net				
EXTRACT OF THE STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30, 2026				
(₹ in Lakhs, except per equity share data)				
S. No.	Particulars	3 months ended	Year ended	3 months ended
		30.06.2026	31.03.2026	30.06.2025
		(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)
1.	Total Income from operations	34,749.81	1,31,542.15	28,604.06
2.	Net Profit for the period before tax and exceptional items	1,286.95	3,177.77	988.13
3.	Net Profit for the period before tax and after exceptional items	1,286.95	2,957.75	988.13
4.	Net Profit for the period after tax and after exceptional items	1,122.58	2,187.17	828.17
5.	Total comprehensive income for the period (after tax)	1,114.57	2,155.15	811.95
6.	Equity Share Capital	799.93	799.93	799.93
7.	Reserves excluding revaluation reserve as on March 31, 2026		67,002.78	
8.	Earnings Per Share (after extraordinary item/s) (of Rs. 2/- each)	2.00	2.00	2.00
	Basic: (In rupees)	2.81	5.47	2.07
	Diluted: (In rupees)	2.81	5.47	2.07
Note: The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing obligation and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com and on the Company's website www.munjalshowa.net .				
For and on behalf of the Board Sd/- (Yogesh Chander Munjal) Chairman & Managing Director DIN 00003491				
Place : Gurugram Date : August 03, 2026				

NTPC Green Energy Limited
(A Subsidiary of NTPC Ltd.)
Reg. Office: NTPC Bhawan, SCOPE Complex 7, Institutional Area, Lodhi Road, New Delhi - 110003
Advt. No. 03/26

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How to Apply: Interested eligible candidates may visit the career section of our website www.ngel.in for viewing detailed eligibility criteria, qualification, experience requirement, remuneration details & full text of advertisement for applying. Only online mode of application will be accepted. Any further addendum/corrigendum/updates will only be published on our website.

Start date of online application 11.08.2026 (From 10:00 Hrs)
Last date of online application 31.08.2026 (Till 18:00 Hrs)

INDRAPRASTHA GAS LIMITED
Corporate Identity Number (CIN): L23201DL1998PLC097614
Regd. office: IGL Bhawan, Plot No. 4, Community Centre, Sector-9, R.K. Puram, New Delhi-110022. Website: www.iglonline.net, Email: investors@igl.co.in, Tel No. - 011-46074607

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL), a leading City Gas Distribution Company, invites 'Expression of Interest (EOI)' from interested suppliers/manufacturers for supply of MDPE Pipe Fittings & Valves. Details are available on our website www.iglonline.net and e-tender portal <https://gl.ebizard.in>. Interested vendors may go through the details and submit their proposals.

HAR EK KAAM DESH KE NAAM

INSTITUTE OF BANKING PERSONNEL SELECTION
(An Autonomous Body set up by Reserve Bank of India, Central Finance Officer and Public Sector Banks)
आवृत्ति: 01, 02, 03, 04, 05, 06, 07, 08, 09, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33, 34, 35, 36, 37, 38, 39, 40, 41, 42, 43, 44, 45, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50, 51, 52, 53, 54, 55, 56, 57, 58, 59, 60, 61, 62, 63, 64, 65, 66, 67, 68, 69, 70, 71, 72, 73, 74, 75, 76, 77, 78, 79, 80, 81, 82, 83, 84, 85, 86, 87, 88, 89, 90, 91, 92, 93, 94, 95, 96, 97, 98, 99, 100, 101, 102, 103, 104, 105, 106, 107, 108, 109, 110, 111, 112, 113, 114, 115, 116, 117, 118, 119, 120, 121, 122, 123, 124, 125, 126, 127, 128, 129, 130, 131, 132, 133, 134, 135, 136, 137, 138, 139, 140, 141, 142, 143, 144, 145, 146, 147, 148, 149, 150, 151, 152, 153, 154, 155, 156, 157, 158, 159, 160, 161, 162, 163, 164, 165, 166, 167, 168, 169, 170, 171, 172, 173, 174, 175, 176, 177, 178, 179, 180, 181, 182, 183, 184, 185, 186, 187, 188, 189, 190, 191, 192, 193, 194, 195, 196, 197, 198, 199, 200, 201, 202, 203, 204, 205, 206, 207, 208, 209, 210, 211, 212, 213, 214, 215, 216, 217, 218, 219, 220, 221, 222, 223, 224, 225, 226, 227, 228, 229, 230, 231, 232, 233, 234, 235, 236, 237, 238, 239, 240, 241, 242, 243, 244, 245, 246, 247, 248, 249, 250, 251, 252, 253, 254, 255, 256, 257, 258, 259, 260, 261, 262, 263, 264, 265, 266, 267, 268, 269, 270, 271, 272, 273, 274, 275, 276, 277, 278, 279, 280, 281, 282, 283, 284, 285, 286, 287, 288, 289, 290, 291, 292, 293, 294, 295, 296, 297, 298, 299, 300, 301, 302, 303, 304, 305, 306, 307, 308, 309, 310, 311, 312, 313, 314, 315, 316, 317, 318, 319, 320, 321, 322, 323, 324, 325, 326, 327, 328, 329, 330, 331, 332, 333, 334, 335, 336, 337, 338, 339, 340, 341, 342, 343, 344, 345, 346, 347, 348, 349, 350, 351, 352, 353, 354, 355, 356, 357, 358, 359, 360, 361, 362, 363, 364, 365, 366, 367, 368, 369, 370, 371, 372, 373, 374, 375, 376, 377, 378, 379, 380, 381, 382, 383, 384, 385, 386, 387, 388, 389, 390, 391, 392, 393, 394, 395, 396, 397, 398, 399, 400, 401, 402, 403, 404, 405, 406, 407, 408, 409, 410, 411, 412, 413, 414, 415, 416, 417, 418, 419, 420, 421, 422, 423, 424, 425, 426, 427, 428, 429, 430, 431, 432, 433, 434, 435, 436, 437, 438, 439, 440, 441, 442, 443, 444, 445, 446, 447, 448, 449, 450, 451, 452, 453, 454, 455, 456, 457, 458, 459, 460, 461, 462, 463, 464, 465, 466, 467, 468, 469, 470, 471, 472, 473, 474, 475, 476, 477, 478, 479, 480, 481, 482, 483, 484, 485, 486, 487, 488, 489, 490, 491, 492, 493, 494, 495, 496, 497, 498, 499, 500, 501, 502, 503, 504, 505, 506, 507, 508, 509, 510, 511, 512, 513, 514, 515, 516, 517, 518, 519, 520, 521, 522, 523, 524, 525, 526, 527, 528, 529, 530, 531, 532, 533, 534, 535, 536, 537, 538, 539, 540, 541, 542, 543, 544, 545, 546, 547, 548, 549, 550, 551, 552, 553, 554, 555, 556, 557, 558, 559, 560, 561, 562, 563, 564, 565, 566, 567, 568, 569, 570, 571, 572, 573, 574, 575, 576, 577, 578, 579, 580, 581, 582, 583, 584, 585, 586, 587, 588, 589, 590, 591, 592, 593, 594, 595, 596, 597, 598, 599, 600, 601, 602, 603, 604, 605, 606, 607, 608, 609, 610, 611, 612, 613, 614, 615, 616, 617, 618, 619, 620, 621, 622, 623, 624, 625, 626, 627, 628, 629, 630, 631, 632, 633, 634, 635, 636, 637, 638, 639, 640, 641, 642, 643, 644, 645, 646, 647, 648, 649, 650, 651, 652, 653, 654, 655, 656, 657, 658, 659, 660, 661, 662, 663, 664, 665, 666, 667, 668, 669, 670, 671, 672, 673, 674, 675, 676, 677, 678, 679, 680, 681, 682, 683, 684, 685, 686, 687, 688, 689, 690, 691, 692, 693, 694, 695, 696, 697, 698, 699, 700, 701, 702, 703, 704, 705, 706, 707, 708, 709, 710, 711, 712, 713, 714, 715, 716, 717, 718, 719, 720, 721, 722, 723, 724, 725, 726, 727, 728, 729, 730, 731, 732, 733, 734, 735, 736, 737, 738, 739, 740, 741, 742, 743, 744, 745, 746, 747, 748, 749, 750, 751, 752, 753, 754, 755, 756, 757, 758, 759, 760, 761, 762, 763, 764, 765, 766, 767, 768, 769, 770, 771, 772, 773, 774, 775, 776, 777, 778, 779, 780, 781, 782, 783, 784, 785, 786, 787, 788, 789, 790, 791, 792, 793, 794, 795, 796, 797, 798, 799, 800, 801, 802, 803, 804, 805, 806, 807, 808, 809, 810, 811, 812, 813, 814, 815, 816, 817, 818, 819, 820, 821, 822, 823, 824, 825, 826, 827, 828, 829, 830, 831, 832, 833, 834, 835, 836, 837, 838, 839, 840, 841, 842, 843, 844, 845, 846, 847, 848, 849, 850, 851, 852, 853, 854, 855, 856, 857, 858, 859, 860, 861, 862, 863, 864, 865, 866, 867, 868, 869, 870, 871, 872, 873, 874, 875, 876, 877, 878, 879, 880, 881, 882, 883, 884, 885, 886, 887, 888, 889, 890, 891, 892, 893, 894, 895, 896, 897, 898, 899, 900, 901, 902, 903, 904, 905, 906, 907, 908, 909, 910, 911, 912, 913, 914, 915, 916, 917, 918, 919, 920, 921, 922, 923, 924, 925, 926, 927, 928, 929, 930, 931, 932, 933, 934, 935, 936, 937, 938, 939, 940, 941, 942, 943, 944, 945, 946, 947, 948, 949, 950, 951, 952, 953, 954, 955, 956, 957, 958, 959, 960, 961, 962, 963, 964, 965, 966, 967, 968, 969, 970, 971, 972, 973, 974, 975, 976, 977, 978, 979, 980, 981, 982, 983, 984, 985, 986, 987, 988, 989, 990, 991, 992, 993, 994, 995, 996, 997, 998, 999, 1000

CRP CSA -XVI
COMMON RECRUITMENT PROCESS (CRP)
FOR RECRUITMENT OF CUSTOMER SERVICE ASSOCIATES (CSA) IN PARTICIPATING PUBLIC SECTOR BANKS (Vacancies of 2027-28)
Official Website: www.ibps.in
In case of queries / complaints please log in to <https://cgrs.ibps.in>

The Online Examination (Preliminary and Main) for the upcoming Common Recruitment Process (CRP CSA-XVI) for Recruitment and Selection of Customer Service Associate (CSA) Post in the Participating Public Sector Banks is tentatively scheduled as:

IMPORTANT DATES	
Activity	Timeline
Online Registration by Candidates	01.08.2026 to 21.08.2026
Payment of Application Fees/ Intimation Charges	01.08.2026 to 21.08.2026
Edit Window for Candidates to Modify/ Correct Application Form (including online payment for Edit)	After closure of Registration (will be notified on Official IBPS website)
Conduct of Pre-Examination Training (PET)	September, 2026
Online Examination - Preliminary	October, 2026
Result of Online Examination - Preliminary	November, 2026
Online Examination - Main	December, 2026
Provisional Allotment	March, 2027

Candidates are advised to regularly visit the official IBPS website www.ibps.in for details and updates.

Candidates intending to apply for CRP CSA XVI are advised to read the detailed Notification carefully and ensure that they fulfil the minimum eligibility criteria on the stipulated dates before registering online. Candidates must follow the instructions mentioned in the detailed Notification.

Mumbai
Date: 01.08.2026

DIRECTOR

JM FINANCIAL LIMITED
Corporate Identity Number: L67120MH1986PLC038784
Registered Office: 7th Floor, Nergu, Appasaheb Marathe Marg, Prabhadevi, Mumbai-400 025. Tel. No.: +91 22 6630 3030
Fax: +91 22 6630 3223 • Website: www.jmfi.com
Email: ecomunication@jmfi.com

STATEMENT OF UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE FIRST QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30, 2026

The Unaudited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results for the first quarter ended June 30, 2026 have been reviewed by the Audit Committee, and on its recommendation, have been approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on August 3, 2026, in accordance with Regulation 33 of the SEBI Listing Regulations. The said results have been subjected to limited review by the Statutory Auditors of the Company, who have issued an unmodified reports thereon.

The aforementioned financial results along with the Limited Review Report are available on the website of BSE (www.bseindia.com) and NSE (www.nseindia.com) and are being uploaded on the Company's website at <https://jmfi.com/investor-relations/financial-results> and the same can be accessed by scanning the given QR code.

By and on behalf of the Board of Directors

Vishal Kampani
Vice Chairman and Managing Director
(DIN: 00009079)

Place: Mumbai
Date: August 3, 2026

Note: The above intimation is in accordance with Regulation 33 read with Regulation 47(1) of the SEBI Listing Regulations

Rajasthan State Road Development And Construction Corporation Ltd., JAIPUR
No. NIT/2026-27/5381-98
आवृत्ति: 01, 02, 03, 04, 05, 06, 07, 08, 09, 10,

Wipro, others suffer as Meta shuts digital marketing unit

Wipro may lose \$25 mn in revenue; co also manages IT support, customer services for Meta

Jas Bardia
jas.bardia@livemint.com
BENGALURU

Meta Platforms Inc. has slashed at least a quarter of the IT work it outsources to Wipro Ltd after an artificial intelligence (AI)-led overhaul shuttered its digital marketing arm, marking the second major business loss from a top client for India's fourth-largest IT services firm in under six months.

According to two people aware of the matter, Wipro is now expected to generate about \$75 million in annual revenue from Meta, which is among the IT services company's 20 largest accounts. The Bengaluru-based firm manages IT support, customer services, and digital marketing-related work for the firm.

In fiscal year 2026 (FY26), Wipro generated about \$100 million in annual revenue from Meta, which is among the IT services company's 20 largest accounts. The Bengaluru-based firm manages IT support, customer services, and digital marketing-related work for the firm.

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Wipro is now expected to generate \$75 million in annual revenue from Meta..

MINT

200 Wipro employees managing the account from its Gurugram office being placed on the bench. According to the second person, an email was sent earlier this month regarding the termination of this work, and each of the 200

renewal every year.

For Wipro, this loss of business comes even as the company struggles to reverse its fortunes under Srini Pallia, who took over as chief executive in May last year. It ended last year with

annual revenue from New York-based Estée Lauder. The global cosmetics major shifted the Bengaluru firm's share of work in a half-a-billion dollar, five-year deal to Accenture.

Brokerages expect the company to have another muted year in FY27. "We believe demand remains constrained by longer decision-making and slower project execution, while AI-led productivity continues to limit growth from the existing business. We expect WPRO to lag peers, with FY27 likely to be another year of flat to slightly negative growth," said Motilal Oswal Financial Services analysts Abhishek Pathak and Keval Bhagat, in a note dated 16 July.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

HARD DRIVE			
THIS loss comes even as the company struggles to reverse its fortunes under Pallia	WIPRO lost up to \$100 million in annual revenue from New York-based Estée Lauder	BROKERAGES expect the company to have another muted year in fiscal year 2027	IN fiscal year 2026, Wipro generated about \$100 million in annual revenue from Meta

have been benched to be redeployed in other projects.

To be sure, homegrown IT services companies usually partner with large technology firms through annual contracts, with businesses coming up for

\$10.5 billion in revenue, down 0.3% on a yearly basis.

This is the second jolt that the company has faced in less than six months.

According to a *Mint* report on 3 March, Wipro lost up to \$100 million in

JioStar targets 'many Indias', looks to blur TV-digital lines

Lata Jha
lata.j@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

JioStar, the media and entertainment arm of Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL), is consciously backing stories that extend beyond India's major metros to resonate with audiences across sub-cultures and economic segments, acknowledging that a one-size-fits-all approach does not work in a country of this scale.

A senior executive said the company is taking a selective, considered approach to green-lighting content across films (Star Studio18), linear television (including general entertainment channels like Colors and Star Plus) and streaming (JioHotstar), with a strong focus on profitability as viewers turn increasingly screen-agnostic and the lines between TV and OTT continue to blur. "A higher level of thoughtfulness and selectiveness has come into the picture, along with a focus on profitability. There was a time in the industry, five to six years ago, when we were expanding the market and wanted to see what would work. We now have a strong view on what we want to do and are looking closely at how to make it profitable over a period of time," Alok Jain, head-Hindi and English entertainment business (streaming, TV and studios), JioStar, said in an interview to *Mint*.

While the company has backed small and high-profile shows such as *Chiraiya* and *Pritam and Pedro* for JioHotstar, Jain noted that film acquisition costs for OTT platforms have seen a sharp correction. Riding on the success of

heavy investments in original long-form content have failed to translate into significant subscriber growth



Major platforms have slashed budgets by 50% since the peak of the pandemic.

ISTOCKPHOTO

Chiraiya, the tenth most-watched OTT property in the first six months of 2026, according to Ormax, the platform now plans to strengthen its regional language slate with *Bhojpuri Bawaal*, a Bhojpuri reality show.

Six other reality shows, including *Koffee With Karan*, *Bigg Boss* and *Khatron Ke Khiladi*, are slated to launch across TV and OTT within the next four months. Meanwhile, on the studio side, while the company benefits from the distribution of Hollywood titles, it is also releasing Ajay Devgn's *Drishyam 3* later in the year.

JioStar, formed by the merger of Reliance's Viacom18 and The Walt Disney Co.'s

Disney Star, reported a 14.5% year-on-year increase in net profit to ₹665 crore in the June quarter.

To be sure, these moves come at a time when the Indian OTT industry is struggling with content clutter as well as limited ad and subscription revenues. Major platforms have slashed budgets by 50% since the peak of the pandemic and active paid subscriptions have

flattened as user growth leans more towards ad-supported models. Meanwhile, heavy investments in original long-form content have failed to translate into significant subscriber growth.

Beyond programming for 'many Indias', given the country's young, large and culturally diverse population, Jain said the big focus post-merger has been on blurring the lines between TV and digital platforms. To build on that strategy, recent shows such as *Bareilly Ke Bacchan* and *Mahadev & Sons* have been deliberately set in small towns.

"We do not see India as one homogeneous culture. India has a lot of Indias within it, and it's important that we look at these smaller cohorts deeply and programme for them," Jain said, adding that even global content on JioHostar from Disney, Marvel and Peacock is dubbed into multiple local languages.

In film production, JioStar operates Star Studio18, which was created through the phased merger of UTV, Star Studios and Viacom18 Studios. Jain said the vertical functions at arm's length from the company's other businesses.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Ather Energy hits Ebitda breakeven

Ayaan Kartik
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NEW DELHI

Ather Energy Ltd has become India's first pure-play new-age electric scooter maker to post an operating profit before depreciation, finance and amortization costs.

The Bengaluru-based electric vehicle maker, founded in 2013, reported an earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization (Ebitda) margin of 0.8% in the June quarter, an over 16-percentage-point improvement from -15.7% a year ago. This came on the back of revenue nearly doubling to ₹1,260 crore from ₹673 crore as electric vehicle (EV) sales surged owing to fuel price hikes and supply concerns amid the West Asia war.

Its net loss narrowed to ₹51 crore from ₹178 crore, bringing the firm closer to breakeven, although higher commodity prices triggered by the war weighed on margins.

An Ebitda breakeven indicates that the company has achieved core profit from its operations without the accounting-related costs.

"Recognizing the strong



Ather is the first e-scooter maker with Ebitda breakeven

REUTERS

demand that our products already had, we were able to run a really tight ship on fixed costs, particularly marketing and sales, and deliver our first-ever positive Ebitda quarter," said Tarun Mehta, co-founder and chief executive at the earnings call.

Ather has achieved margin breakeven ahead of cross-town rival Ola Electric Mobility Ltd, after surpassing the company in annual sales, revenue, and market valuation in FY26.

To be sure, Zelio E-Mobil-

ity, a seller of low-speed electric two-wheelers that do not require registration, is also profitable but is generally not compared with mainstream EV makers that sell regulated e-two-wheelers.

Among legacy players, Bajaj Auto's electric two-wheeler and three-wheeler business combined is Ebitda-positive, with e-two-wheeler moving closer to core profitability, it said in a 21 July earnings call.

TVS Motor Co. Ltd doesn't disclose the profitability of its

The company's net loss narrowed to ₹51 crore from ₹178 crore, bringing the company closer to breakeven

EV division.

"It's a small number, but this is the first time ever we have delivered one, so I'm very happy to report it. Challenges do continue for the coming quarters. There will likely be, in fact, some ups and downs," Mehta added.

The turnaround comes just over a year after Ather's May 2025 listing. Since then, its shares have surged over 300% to above ₹1,280 apiece. After the results announcement, the stock rose 1.6%, outperforming Nifty Auto's 1.5% rise.

Electric two-wheeler sales rose 67% to 513,208, per data from the Federation of Automobile Dealers Association (Fada), as government pushed for EV adoption to reduce India's oil imports and accelerate electrification. EV penetration reached 10.6% in June.

Ather benefited from the war-driven EV boom, with sales up 81% to 83,173 units during the quarter, as per its investor presentation. TVS Motor and Bajaj Auto also saw a surge in EV sales.

Mehta noted that the surge in electric two-wheeler sales is here to stay.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

DLF's bookings crash 94% in June qtr as it skips new projects

Madhurima Nandy
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BENGALURU

Realty major DLF Ltd's new sales bookings slowed to a trickle in the April-June quarter in the absence of fresh project launches, which typically boost sales momentum.

The developer's first new sales bookings were at ₹657 crore, down 94.3% from ₹11,425 crore a year ago, driven mainly by major luxury projects such as DLF Privana North in Gurugram.

The Gurugram-based realtor's June quarter revenue from operations fell 52.8% to ₹1,280.34 crore from ₹2,716.70 crore a year earlier, while net profit rose 3.9% to ₹794 crore.

DLF said on Monday that the new sales bookings for the quarter reflect "the timing impact of deferred launches".

"We remain well-positioned to bring our upcoming products to the market and expect the requisite approvals to be received soon for the planned launches. With sustained customer demand, strong brand



DLF's Q1 revenue from operations fell 52.8%.

MINT

positioning, deep market presence and a defined launch pipeline, we remain confident of achieving our stated medium-term growth goals," the company said in a statement.

DLF reported strong surplus cash generation during the quarter, boosting its net cash position to ₹15,200 crore.

The realtor has set a sales goal of ₹20,000 crore for FY27, unchanged from last year, as it prioritizes margins and cash flow over aggressive sales growth. It has lined up launches worth about ₹20,000 crore this year across

Gurugram, Mumbai and Goa.

India's top four listed real estate developers—DLF, Godrej Properties Ltd, Prestige Estates Projects Ltd and Lodha Developers Ltd—are targeting a combined ₹1.19 trillion in housing sales in FY27 as they sharpen their focus on increasing profits and acquiring new land in a calibrated manner. They crossed a major sales milestone with ₹1.05 trillion of sales in FY26, as demand for top branded developers remained strong.

Among DLF's peers, Mumbai-based Lodha saw a 4% rise in sales bookings to ₹4,629 crore in Q1 despite no fresh launches. It aims for ₹24,000 crore of sales from housing projects this year. Bengaluru-based Prestige recorded ₹6579.30 crore in sales, down 46% year-on-year after record-high launches last year.

DLF, which holds a 50-million-sq-ft office and retail-led rental portfolio, expects its retail segment to grow significantly this fiscal as three new projects begin operations.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Elevation plans twin stake sales in Paytm, Meesho

Agnidev Bhattacharya
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MUMBAI

Elevation Capital is set to offload shares worth up to ₹2,002 crore (about \$210 million) in Paytm parent One 97 Communications Ltd through a block deal on Tuesday, according to the terms reviewed by *Mint*.

The venture capital firm will also offer shares in Meesho Ltd, along with Peak XV Partners, worth a total of ₹1,912 crore (about \$201 million) through a separate block deal on the same day, as per a separate term sheet seen by *Mint*.

Morgan Stanley India is serving as the placement agent for both deals.

Elevation's stake sale in Paytm comes days after the company dropped plans for a proposed bonus share issue. Saif Partners India IV Ltd, Saif III Mauritius Co. Ltd, and Elevation Capital V Ltd, listed as public shareholders of Paytm, are offering up to 14.9 million shares, which equal 2.3% of the company's shares, according to the term sheet.

Saif Partners India IV holds 3.63%, while Saif III Mauritius Co. holds 8.55%. Elevation V holds less than 1%.

The floor price is set at ₹1,339.65 per share, implying a 4.99% discount to the closing price of ₹1,410 in Mumbai on Monday.

Elevation, which invested in Paytm in 2007, is one of the earliest backers of the Vijay Shekhar Sharma-led firm. Elevation and Peak XV's stake sale in Meesho comes on the heels of the e-commerce marketplace's June-quarter earnings. The recently listed company reported a consolidated net loss of ₹132.8 crore.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Della bets on 3,600-key hotel pipeline to drive township projects

Varuni Khosla
varuni.k@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Della Group, known for its 300-room resort in Lonavala, Maharashtra, plans to build about 3,600 hotel keys across township projects, marking its expansion from operating a single destination resort to developing hotels at scale in partnership with developers.

The privately-held company, founded by Jimmy Mistry, has signed 12 projects in Pune, Ahmedabad, Nagpur and Raipur, with one in Hyderabad likely soon.

The strategy comes as India's hospitality sector is

seeing strong travel demand and developers look beyond conventional mixed-use projects to differentiate residential offerings.

Della is betting that destination attractions such as adventure sports, wellness, motorsports and weddings can generate year-round footfall, boosting both hotel occupancy and the value of surrounding real estate.

"We don't do vanilla real estate hospitality projects. We are now doing theme-based, hospitality-driven developments which creates value for the traveller and the developer," Mistry told *Mint*. "Adventure-related hospitality drives demand. Weddings



The privately held company, founded by entrepreneur Jimmy Mistry, has signed 12 projects across cities.

drive a whole different segment and so do gastronomy and entertainment. Each of these brings its own footfalls."

Projects by developers such

as DLF, Brigade and Prestige typically combine hotels with offices, retail and residences.

In recent years, several top-end resorts like Indian Hotels

with its Ama Stays have expanded wellness programmes, while integrated developments are increasingly

TRAVEL MAGNET

DELLA Resorts & Adventure Pvt. Ltd, reported revenue of about ₹200 crore in fiscal year 2025

IT has about 3,600 hotel keys across 12 projects with a combined GDV of about ₹46,000 crore

In Pune, we did a collaboration with the Hiranandani Group. On this land, they were selling at ₹7,000 (per sq ft). We are now selling at

₹200 crore in FY25, up from ₹170 crore in FY24. The company has about 3,600 hotel keys across 12 projects with a combined gross development value (GDV) of about ₹46,000 crore. Its largest announced project is a 1,100-acre township near Ahmedabad with a 1,200-room hotel alongside residential, retail and leisure assets.

"In Pune, we did a collaboration with the Hiranandani Group. On this land, they were selling at ₹7,000 (per sq ft). We are now selling at

₹17,500 per sq ft," he said.

Unlike hotel operators such as Indian Hotels, Marriott or InterContinental Hotels, which mostly expand through hotel management agreements, its model is tied to township development. The company does not acquire land but partners with developers, contributing the hospitality concept, design and operations. It also takes an equity stake in parts of the hospitality business, Mistry said.

According to HVS Anarock, the industry saw 64-66% occupancy in April-June, with average room rates rising 6-8% year-on-year to ₹8,100-8,300.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

www.dlf.in

DLF

EXTRACT OF UN-AUDITED CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS
FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30 JUNE 2026

(₹ in crores unless otherwise stated)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
		30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited) (refer note 2)	30.06.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1.	Total income	1,605.56	2,093.82	2,980.88	9,816.04
2.	Net profit for the period/ year [before tax, exceptional items and share of profit in associates and joint ventures (net)]	422.76	621.19	515.30	2,728.90
3.	Net profit for the period/ year [before tax, share of profit in associates and joint ventures (net) and after exceptional items]	422.76	649.07	515.30	2,931.82
4.	Net profit for the period/ year [after tax, share of profit in associates and joint ventures (net)]	793.90	1,268.56	762.67	4,414.68
5.	Total comprehensive income for the period/ year	793.52	1,264.60	766.02	4,408.34
6.	Paid up equity share capital (face value of ₹ 2/- per share)	495.06	495.06	495.06	495.06
7.	Other equity	—	—	—	44,978.31
8.	Earnings Per Share (face value of ₹ 2/- per share) (not annualised)				
i) Basic (₹)		3.21	5.12	3.08	17.83
ii) Diluted (₹)		3.21	5.12	3.08	17.83

1. The above consolidated financial results of DLF Limited ("the Company"), its subsidiaries, partnership firms (together referred as "the Group") and its joint ventures, joint operations and associates have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on 3 August 2026. The Statutory Auditors have carried out Limited Review of above consolidated financial results of the Group.

2. The figures for the quarter ended 31 March 2026 are the balancing figures between the audited figures in respect of the full financial year up to 31 March 2026 and the unaudited published year-to-date figures up to 31 December 2025, being the date of the end of the third quarter of the financial year which were subject to limited review by Statutory Auditors.

3. These consolidated financial results have been prepared in accordance with the recognition and measurement principles of Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS) as notified under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015, as amended. The said consolidated financial results represent the results of the Company, its subsidiaries, partnership firms (together referred as "the Group"), its joint operations and its share in the results of joint ventures and associates which have been prepared in accordance with the Ind AS-110 – 'Consolidated Financial Statement' and Ind AS-28 – 'Investment in Associates and Joint Ventures'.

4. The standalone financial results of the Company for the quarter ended 30 June 2026 are available on the Company's Website at <https://www.dlf.in/investor.php>.

Key standalone financial information is given below:

(₹ in crores unless otherwise stated)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
		30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited) (refer note 2)	30.06.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1.	Total income	479.61	3,655.80	611.00	6,739.74
2.	Profit before exceptional items and tax for the period/ year	87.23	2,853.57	48.58	4,276.29
3.	Profit before tax for the period/ year	87.23	2,868.10	48.58	4,490.74
4.	Net profit for the period/ year	65.34	2,400.64	39.40	3,747.91
5.	Other comprehensive income/ (loss) for the period/ year	(0.94)	(1.99)	(0.11)	(3.74)
6.	Total comprehensive income for the period/ year	64.40	2,398.65	39.29	3,744.17
7.	Paid up equity share capital (face value of ₹ 2/- per share)	495.06	495.06	495.06	495.06
8.	Other equity	—	—	—	31,092.72
9.	Earnings per share (face value of ₹ 2/- per share) (not annualised)				
i) Basic (₹)		0.26	9.70	0.16	15.14
ii) Diluted (₹)		0.26	9.70	0.16	15.14

The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarter ended Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the quarter ended Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchanges' websites at www.bseindia.com/ www.nseindia.com and on Company's website at <https://www.dlf.in/investor.php> and can also be accessed by scanning the below QR Code:



On behalf of the Board of Directors

Place: Gurugram
Date: 3 August 2026

Devinder Singh
Managing Director

Ashok Kumar Tyagi
Managing Director

DLF Limited

Regd. Office: Shopping Mall, 3rd Floor, Arjun Marg, DLF City, Phase I, Gurugram - 122 002 (Haryana) India
CIN – L70101HR1963PLC002484, Website: www.dlf.in, Tel.: +91-124-4334200, E-mail: investor-relations@dlf.in

responsible for
renewables

ENERGY FOR EVER

IREDA

ONCE IREDA ALWAYS IREDA
(A Navratna CPSE)

THE LARGEST PURE-PLAY GREEN FINANCING INSTITUTION IN THE COUNTRY

‘Q1 FY 2026-27 vs Q1 FY 2025-26

PROFIT AFTER TAX*
₹337 crore

Up By **37%**

LOAN BOOK*
₹94,936 crore

Up By **19%**

REVENUE FROM OPERATIONS*
₹2,250 crore

Up By **15%**

NET WORTH*
₹14,133 crore

Up By **14%**

EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS (STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED) FOR THE QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30, 2026

(₹ in crores)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Standalone				Consolidated			
		Quarter ended		Year ended		Quarter ended		Year ended	
		30-Jun-26	31-Mar-26	30-Jun-25	31-Mar-26	30-Jun-26	31-Mar-26	30-Jun-25	31-Mar-26
		(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)
1.	Total Income from Operations	2,249.54	2,180.90	1,959.53	8,337.48	2,250.60	2,181.28	1,959.84	8,338.89
2.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	412.72	619.26	304.63	2,336.92	413.75	619.14	304.84	2,337.58
3.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	412.72	619.26	304.63	2,336.92	413.75	619.14	304.84	2,337.58
4.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	337.50	492.75	246.68	1,873.34	338.53	492.62	246.88	1,874.00
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	277.65	577.74	265.37	1,993.46	278.30	579.20	266.21	1,997.15
6.	Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face Value of ₹10/- each)	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,809.23
7.	Other Equity	11,323.27	10,972.12	9,592.63	10,972.12	11,327.96	10,976.19	9,593.20	10,976.19
8.	Securities Premium Account (net)	2,737.56	2,737.56	2,737.57	2,737.56	2,737.56			
9.	Net Worth	14,132.50	13,781.35	12,401.86	13,781.35	14,137.19			
10.	Paid-up Debt Capital/Outstanding Debt	79,002.01	77,845.63	66,398.32	77,845.63	79,058.77			
11.	Debt Equity Ratio	5.59	5.65	5.35	5.65	5.59			
12.	Earnings Per Share (of ₹10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)								
	A. Basic:	1.20	1.76	0.91	6.73	1.21	1.76	0.91	6.73
	B. Diluted:	1.20	1.76	0.91	6.73	1.21	1.76	0.91	6.73
13.	Debt Redemption Reserve	-	-	439.01	-	-	-	439.01	-

Notes:

a) The above results have been approved by the Board of Directors in its meeting held on 03.08.2026 and have been subject to limited review by the Joint Statutory Auditors of the Company.

b) The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly financial results filed with Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 & 52 of the SEBI LODR Regulations. The full format of the said financial results are available on the website of the Company, www.ireda.in/financial-results, and on the websites of the Stock Exchanges, www.bseindia.com & www.nseindia.com.

c) For the other line items referred in Regulation 52(4) of the SEBI LODR Regulations, pertinent disclosures have been made to the Stock Exchanges and can be accessed at www.bseindia.com & www.nseindia.com, respectively.

For and on Behalf of the Board of Directors

Sd/-

Dr. B.K. Mohanty

Chairman & Managing Director (Additional Charge)

Director (Finance)

DIN No.: 08816532

Date: 03.08.2026

Place: New Delhi

INDIAN RENEWABLE ENERGY DEVELOPMENT AGENCY LIMITED

(A Government of India Enterprise)

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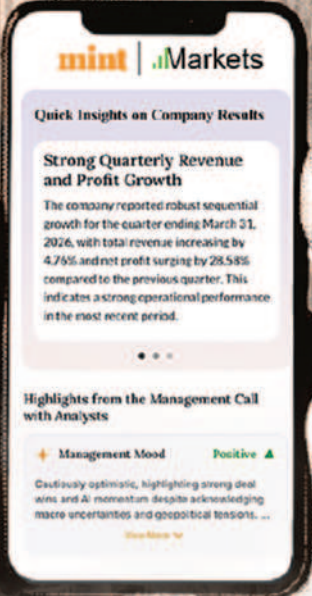
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mint | Markets

Quick Insights on Company Results

Strong Quarterly Revenue and Profit Growth

The company reported robust sequential growth for the quarter ending March 31, 2026, with total revenue increasing by 4.7% and net profit surging by 28.5% compared to the previous quarter. This indicates a strong operational performance in the most recent period.

Highlights from the Management Call with Analysts

Management Mood: **Positive**

Cautiously optimistic, highlighting strong deal wins and AI momentum despite acknowledging more uncertainties and geopolitical tensions. ...

The markets are noisy your view doesn't have to be

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Un-audited Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026

Particulars	(INR in Lakhs except earnings per share data)			
	Quarter Ended		Year ended	
	30.06.2026 Un-audited	31.03.2026 Audited (Refer Note 5)	30.06.2025 Un-audited	31.03.2026 Audited
Revenue from Operations	12,330	11,835	11,045	48,873
Profit/(Loss) for the period (before tax and exceptional)	(186)	220	(208)	2,094
Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional)	(186)	220	(208)	505
Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after exceptional)	(193)	90	(233)	81
Total Comprehensive Income/(Loss) for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(113)	105	(185)	396
Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face Value - INR 2/- per share)	1,164	1,164	1,164	1,164
Other Equity excluding Revaluation Reserves as per the balance sheet				2,529
Earnings/(Loss) per share (of INR 2/- each)	(Not Annualised) (0.33)	(Not Annualised) 0.15	(Not Annualised) 0.40	0.14
Basic	(0.33)	0.15	0.40	0.13
Diluted	(0.33)	0.15	0.40	0.13

Notes:

1
The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on the Company's website "www.digicontent.co.in".

2
The above un-audited consolidated financial results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 were reviewed and recommended by the Audit Committee and were approved by the Board of Directors at their respective meetings held on August 3, 2026. The Statutory Auditors of the Company have conducted "Limited Review" of these results in terms of Regulation 33 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended from time to time and have issued an unmodified review conclusion.

3
The consolidated financial results have been prepared in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standards ('Ind AS') prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015, as amended from time to time.

4
Additional Information on Standalone financial results is as follows:-

(INR in Lakhs)

Particulars	Quarter Ended			Year ended
	30.06.2026 Un-audited	31.03.2026 Audited (Refer Note 5)	30.06.2025 Un-audited	31.03.2026 Audited
Revenue from Operations	30	29	31	119
(Loss) Before Tax	(216)	(229)	(305)	(1,018)
(Loss) After Tax	(216)	(229)	(305)	(1,018)
Total Comprehensive (Loss)	(216)	(232)	(303)	(1,017)

5
The figures of the quarter ended as on March 31, 2026 are balancing figures between the audited figures in respect of the previous financial year and the published year to date figures upto December 31, 2025, being the third quarter of the previous financial year, which were subjected to limited review.

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors

Sameer Singh

Director

(duly authorised by Board of directors)

(DIN: 08138465)

New Delhi

August 3, 2026

Jordan is learning its U.S. alliance has a price in the Iran war

David S. Cloud
feedback@livemint.com

For much of the past month, Iran fired missiles and drones day after day at Jordan. But for many Jordanians, the blame for putting their small country on the front lines falls on President Trump.

"Trump is the cause of this war," said Tahani Khalaf, 63 years old, as she walked with her sisters here in the Jordanian capital on a recent day, hours after another attack. "America forced Jordan to become part of this."

Lacking oil and surrounded by bigger powers, Jordan has relied on the U.S. for decades as a protector and for as much as \$2 billion in annual military and economic aid.

Now, the U.S. needs Amman's help more than ever. Jordan's greater distance from Iran and willingness to let the Pentagon use its territory have made the country an increasingly important partner as the war drags on and Kuwait and other Persian Gulf allies have reduced their role.

But the expanded American footprint at bases in Jordan has come with risks, pulling the kingdom closer to a conflict that has already damaged its economy and shattered its sense of security. Trump's decision to hold off on a planned attack this weekend provides hope for a respite, but over more than five months of conflict, renewed violence has often broken the calm suddenly.

Jordan is now firmly in Iran's crosshairs. On eight of the last 14 days, Jordan's military has reported on its website intercepting missiles or drones fired from Iran.

By raising the military pressure, Iran is seeking to stir up opposition to the war in Jordan and to the U.S. presence, analysts say. It is a strategy that puts Jordan's King Abdullah II in a bind. Even more so than other U.S. allies in the region, he is heavily dependent on Washington and one of its most reliable partners. But many Jordanians and much of the country's large Palestinian population oppose U.S. Middle East policies and its backing of Israel.

"Jordan is so dependent on the U.S. that they can't say no to them launching attacks from their territory," said Danny Citrinowicz, a senior fellow at the Institute for National Security Studies, an Israel-based think tank. "But at the same time, these attacks could weaken the fragile stability in Jordan."

Iran has fired at least 60 missiles and drones at Jordan since a ceasefire between Tehran and Washington collapsed July 8, said the Jordanian military, a faster pace than early in the conflict when the kingdom was targeted by 125 attacks



Iran hasn't hit any civilian targets in Jordan.

AFP

over three months.

Most salvos have been aimed at bases hosting U.S. forces and have been intercepted, U.S. and Jordanian officials said. Three American service members were killed on July 17 in a missile strike that struck prefabricated housing units at Muwaffaq Salti Air Base in Jordan's eastern desert. Iran launched another four-missile barrage last Wednesday that the U.S. military said was "an attempted surprise attack" on troops in Jordan's eastern desert. At least one attack targeted Jordan's only port, Aqaba.

"Jordan's orientation regarding the U.S. or the presence of U.S. forces is unlikely to change," said Behnam Ben Taleblu, an Iran expert at the Foundation for Defense of Democracies, a policy organization that opposes Iran's rulers. "But Tehran is comfortable just dialing up the pressure."

Tehran hasn't hit civilian targets in Jordan, but air-raids sirens have sounded multiple times in recent weeks in the capital and other areas, residents say.

That has sparked a rare public display of opposition to the government over the past month by over 300 former members of the kingdom's parliament, tribal leaders and civic activists who called for the removal of U.S. forces.

"Jordan is not a party to this war, and its people should not bear its consequences or pay the price for policies that do not serve the country's supreme interests," said the letter, which demanded an end to the 2021 bilateral agreement that gives the U.S. military "unimpeded access" to Jordanian bases.

Amjad Majali, a former member of Jordan's parliament and a former minister who signed the letter, said it "reflects the position of the overwhelming majority of Jordanians. Yes, we support the state, but we do not support all of its practices."

For years, Jordan sought to play down its close military and intelligence cooperation with the U.S. But Jordan's role is now becoming too visible to obscure. Jordan is an attractive base for U.S. forces because it

is among the Arab world's most permissive hosts for U.S. military operations.

Muwaffaq Salti Air Base in Jordan's eastern desert and several other bases in the country host U.S. fighters, air defense batteries and other military units used against Iran.

The White House and U.S. military didn't respond to requests for comment.

Jordanian officials have condemned Iranian missile and drone attacks as violations of the kingdom's sovereignty, stressing that Jordan will defend its airspace and protect its citizens. But they also publicly play down Jordan's cooperation with the U.S.

"There are no American bases in Jordan. We have American troops that are in Jordan as part of our long-standing military cooperation," Foreign Minister Ayman Safadi said last month at the Aspen Security Forum.

Iran filed a formal protest at the United Nations against Jordan in March, accusing Amman of "facilitating hostile acts against Iranian territory."

Jordan has tried to stay out of the region's wars since the 1973 Arab conflict with Israel. But after the Oct. 7 Hamas attacks on Israel that plunged the region into conflict, Jordan has not only found itself attacked by Iran for hosting the U.S. military but also shooting down Iranian missiles headed toward Israel, a move that was unpopular internally.

Saed Hasan, 41, who runs a stall selling mobile-phone accessories in Amman, said his sales have fallen steeply since the war began.

"Do you believe you could be sleeping in your house and a missile could fall on you? This is something we have never experienced before. Until when? God knows," he said.

At the same time, anger at Trump for starting the Iran war doesn't equate to support for Iran and its Shiite Muslim leadership. Jordan's population is 95% Sunni.

"If Iran had the chance, it would wipe us off the face of the earth," said Hamada Qrada, 52, a barber. "God willing, may the oppressors destroy one another and stay far away from us."

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Iran déjà vu: Trump once again threatens, retreats

The hardball strategy aims to create movement in negotiation through pressure and chaos

AP
feedback@livemint.com
WASHINGTON

President Donald Trump has played this hand before during the 5-month-old Iran war.

It starts with a grim warning to Tehran that the Republican president is on the cusp of ordering US forces to "obliterate" its power plants or seize key parts of its oil industry if its leaders don't quickly agree to US terms to end the war. It ends with him edging away with a last-minute declaration, sometimes at the behest of Gulf allies, that he's going to give diplomacy more time.

The hardball strategy—one that Trump honed during his years competing in New York's real estate scene and has employed in politics—aims to create movement in negotiation through pressure and chaos. But the tactic is facing a challenge with an Iranian theocracy that believes it holds a higher threshold for strategic pain than Washington.

While Trump has revelled in the US military decimating layers of Tehran's leadership and devastating its air force and navy, Iran is betting it can outlast Trump as he faces diminished stockpiles of munitions and the difficulty of executing a war that is unpopular with the American electorate ahead of November's midterm election.

The latest episode began on Friday when Trump, surrounded by his Cabinet, grimly declared that he was "losing faith" in negotiations with Iran and warned that the US military "will be hitting them very hard."

Hours later, the White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt heightened speculation in Washington—and around the globe—with an ominous statement asserting "Iran will continue to pay until they come to the table in, what President Trump deems, a meaningful way."

But by late Saturday night, Trump declared on social media that there were signs of progress on reaching an



Donald Trump has revelled in the US military decimating layers of Tehran's leadership and devastating its air force and navy.

AFP

agreement and he was calling off a plan to carry out new, massive strikes for the time being.

The next day Trump emphasized that requests to give diplomacy more time from unnamed Iranian officials as well as leaders from Gulf allies—Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates—were key to his about-face.

"It would have been disastrous for them. And they didn't want us to do it," Trump said of Iran as he spoke to reporters on his way back to Washington from a weekend at his New Jersey golf club. "And frankly, Saudi Arabia didn't want it either. They thought that a deal is imminent."

Trump may still come to the conclusion that a massive escalation in the conflict with Iran is necessary.

But critics say his hesitation also might reflect an unspoken under-

standing inside the administration that US military might alone may not be enough to compel Iran to back down and bring an end to a now months-long war that Trump had earlier downplayed as a weeks-long excursion.

Trump may still come to the conclusion that a massive escalation in the conflict with Iran is necessary

"I think what we're seeing here is a president who has an approach that's just rather erratic," said Sen. Mark Kelly, an Arizona Democrat on the Senate Armed Services Committee, on *CBS News' "Face the Nation."* "At this point, he's trying to get us back to February. And I think if he could—if he had a big reset button he could hit—he would certainly take that option."

There have been several moments over the course of the conflict when Trump has demonstrated his proclivity for the bellicose only to back off at the last minute, while declaring his

threats spurred progress.

In early April, the US and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire in an announcement that came less than two hours before a deadline Trump had set for Tehran to capitulate or face attacks on bridges and power plants—strikes he said would mean "a whole civilization will die." After days of dire threats against Iran, Trump announced on 18 May he was holding off on a major planned military strike because "serious negotiations" were underway, crediting Gulf allies for persuading him to show restraint. With this latest episode, Trump suggested that Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman played a particularly important role in him turning away from escalating the fight. The US president spoke by phone with the de facto leader of the kingdom on Saturday before announcing he was halting strikes that he later boasted would have been one of the biggest US operations since World War II.

Amazon joins list of stocks to top \$3 trillion in value

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Amazon.com Inc. surpassed \$3 trillion in market value for the first time, becoming only the fifth company to ever reach the milestone.

The e-commerce and cloud-computing company's shares rose as much as 5.3% as of 9:35am on Monday, adding to the raucous rally last week following second-quarter earnings that showed accelerating cloud-computing revenue.

Amazon joins Nvidia Corp., Alphabet Inc., Microsoft Corp. and Apple Inc. as the only companies that have

reached that size.

Amazon had been mired in a selloff for much of the last three months as investors soured on shares of companies that had committed to spending billion of dollars on artificial intelligence.

Its stock sank nearly 18% between its May 6 record and the three-month low it hit last month.

Those fears were eased last week after the firm reported that revenue for its Amazon Web Services unit last quarter jumped by the most since 2021.

Shares surged more than 15% in response, their biggest one-day jump in more than 14 years, to add nearly \$400 bil-



Amazon had hit a 17-year low in late March.

BLOOMBERG

lion in value.

That's helped propel Amazon back into position as the best-performing Magnificent Seven stock this year.

The gauge of its big tech

peers has struggled this year, gaining only 2.1% compared to a 10% gain for the broader S&P 500 Index.

While the rally has lifted Amazon's valuation from the 17-year low it hit in late March, it's still far below where it has traded historically.

At roughly 25 times forward earnings for the next 12 months, the stock is about 44% cheaper than its average over the last decade.

It took Amazon just over two years to reach a market

capitalization of \$3 trillion after first hitting \$2 trillion in June 2024.

That's faster than the more than six years between that

Amazon joins Nvidia, Alphabet, Microsoft and Apple as the only companies that have reached that size

milestone and when it first hit \$1 trillion in late 2018.

Wall Street remains overwhelmingly upbeat on Amazon's long-term prospects too.

The average analyst price target calls for the stock to rise about 14% over the year from where it currently trades, according to data compiled by Bloomberg.

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Big Tech earnings are sending valuations in opposite directions

Hannah Erin Lang
feedback@livemint.com

Financial markets faced a series of crucial tests last week. The results? Not as clear as investors might hope.

Earnings reports from the country's largest tech companies sent their stocks flying in different directions, propelling Apple's shares to their worst day since the tariff turmoil and Microsoft's to the largest one-day market cap gain for any U.S. company, ever. A press conference from the new chairman of the Federal Reserve left analysts issuing notes with titles like "Doved and Confused" and "Erm... What?"

The question now is whether broadening equity gains and a renewed zeal for the artificial-intelligence trade can power the rally's next leg, even as chip-stock swings and a bond-market selloff drag on

major U.S. stock indexes. The Nasdaq fell 3.2% during the month of July, while the Dow edged higher and the S&P 500 was little changed.

That modest move in those broader indexes has masked sharper moves beneath the surface, as investors re-evaluate their tech bets and grapple with the looming threat of rising interest rates.

It's all "kind of chaotic," said Victoria Fernandez, chief market strategist and portfolio manager at Crossmark Global Investments.

"Even though the top layer says things are fine, underneath there's a lot of churning and uncertainty."

That tumult was especially pronounced last week, as traders took a more discerning look at the market's biggest AI players—with drastically dissimilar results. After Amazon reported accelerating sales in its cloud computing business, the stock surged 15% in Friday

trading. Meanwhile, shares of Apple slumped 7.4% after the iPhone maker's forecast for its September quarter fell short of Wall Street's expectations.

Traders issued a similar verdict exactly one day prior, sending shares of Meta Platforms 8% lower following the Facebook parent's projections that its free cash flow would turn negative in the second half of the year. On the other hand, Microsoft's stock jumped 16%. That boosted the company's market capitalization by some \$450 billion, marking the biggest one-day leap in market value for any U.S. company on record.

After months of growing concern aimed at the hundreds of billions that tech companies are spending—and borrowing—to finance the AI infrastructure build-out, shareholders are starting to demand some evidence of returns on that investment, Fernandez said.

"Investors are tired of saying 'We're going to give you the



Earnings reports from the country's largest tech companies sent their stocks flying in different directions.

AP

benefit of the doubt," she said. "They're losing their patience. They want proof." Those firms that fall short are seeing their stocks punished, she noted.

The update that the so-called "hyperscalers" were still spending big on the AI build-out benefited hard-hit shares of chip makers, memory suppliers and other "picks and shovels" plays during the week. The PHLX Semicon-

ductor Index eked out a gain on Friday, though the benchmark is still down some 21% for July.

Another dizzying market move came in the wake of Fed chairman Kevin Warsh's second postmeeting press conference on Wednesday, which sparked furious selling in stocks and bonds. After policy-makers at the central bank opted to hold interest rates

steady, Warsh seemed to imply that a near-term rate increase might not be needed.

Instead, the chairman implied, higher bond yields have already done some of the Fed's work for them.

Bond traders reacted by firing a kind of warning shot. The yield on the 30-year U.S. Treasury bond climbed to its highest levels in 19 years, a sign that Wall Street is unconvinced the new Fed leader is committed to wrangling inflation.

That bond selloff picked up new momentum on Friday, with the 10-year Treasury yield advancing to a new 18-month high. Yields climbed across maturities, as investors dialed up bets on a near-term rate increase.

Warsh is considering reducing the frequency of policy meetings at the Fed, which would mark a substantial shift

in operations and reduce the number of occasions on which the bank's meetings are the main focus of markets.

A sustained climb in bond yields would lift the cost of capital for businesses and consumers, slow the economy and likely drag on stocks. To make matters worse, tensions in the

Middle East are still threatening to lift oil prices, amping up inflationary threats.

Investors will get a clearer reading on the health of the U.S. economy in the week ahead, with a much-awaited jobs report Friday and earnings reports due from consumer-facing firms such as McDonald's and Walt Disney.

Even as yields climb and AI skepticism lingers, the bull market has a sturdy tailwind. The S&P 500's overall earnings growth rate—blending projections with

the results that are already in—is some 47%. That is the highest level in more than five years, and analysts are still lifting their estimates for next quarter.

Analysts at Goldman Sachs on Friday noted that draw-downs are common after the kind of meteoric gains that hit memory stocks earlier in the year. And while AI spending has surged at Amazon, Alphabet, Meta and Microsoft, analysts now expect revenue for that group to grow at an annualized rate of 18% over the next two years.

"There's a lot of health in the market under the surface, but I think it's all lost in this AI narrative," said Joseph Zappia, co-chief investment officer at L&W Advisors.

"We're in an economic expansion. The question is how long it will go, and at what point it has gone too far," he said. "I'm not seeing many indications that we're there."

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m
NEWS
NUMBERS

\$5.78 bn

THE AMOUNT companies raised through initial public offerings in India so far in 2026, down from \$732 billion in the same period last year.

25k acres

THE ESTIMATED land area now under rambutan cultivation across Kerala, generating about ₹1,000 crore in revenue this season, as per a farmers' organization.

₹483 cr

THE CONSOLIDATED net profit reported by Persistent Systems in the April-June quarter, up 13.67% from ₹424.93 crore in the year-ago period.

250,000

THE NUMBER of travellers hit by flight cancellations over a three-day holiday weekend, after Canada's Westjet flight attendants went on strike.

₹20,200 cr

THE VALUE of Indian stocks bought by foreign portfolio investors in July after four consecutive months of selling, driven by stable macroeconomic conditions.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Willie Walsh takes over as IndiGo CEO

Willie Walsh, a pilot and an aviation industry leader, on Monday, took charge as the chief executive of India's largest airline IndiGo.

An Irish national, Walsh is now at the helm of IndiGo after completing his tenure as the director general of the International Air Transport Association (Iata) on 31 July.

The appointment of Walsh was announced by IndiGo on 31 March, which is less than three weeks after the sudden exit of Pieter Elbers against the backdrop of massive operational disruptions at the airline in December 2025.

He has taken over the reins at a pivotal moment for IndiGo, which commands more than 66% of the country's domestic market and is pursuing ambitious international expansion, with wide-body A350-900 aircraft expected to join its fleet from early 2028. IndiGo already has more than 900 planes on order.

PTI



ONGC in July announced plans to build the strategic petroleum reserve at Mangaluru. REUTERS

Half of ONGC's new storage for reserves

Oil and Natural Gas Corp. (ONGC) will reserve half of its planned 1.75 million metric tonnes (about 13 million barrels) oil storage facility to meet the country's strategic needs, junior oil minister Suresh Gopi told lawmakers on Monday.

ONGC, India's top oil explorer, last month announced plans to build the strategic petroleum reserve at Mangaluru in Karnataka state, where its Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals subsidiary operates a refinery with capacity of 300,000 barrels per day.

New Delhi is expanding its Strategic Petroleum Reserve (SPR) capacity with private participation. Indian rules allow commercial use of a part of the existing SPR storage built at three locations—Mangaluru, Padur and Vizag—in southern India with 5.33 million tons of capacity. These storage facilities are managed by the government-owned Indian Strategic Petroleum Reserves Ltd (ISPRL).

MRPL leased half of the 1.5 million ton Mangaluru SPR. Gopi said India has capacity to store crude oil and petroleum products to meet 74 days of its net crude import needs.

REUTERS

Centre proposes amendments that could revive MDR on UPI

Sitharaman will introduce the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill today

Anshika Kayastha & Harsh Kumar
MUMBAI/NEW DELHI

The Union finance ministry has proposed amendments to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, that could pave the way for the return of merchant discount rate (MDR) on unified payments interface (UPI) transactions.

The changes, which are unlikely to burden UPI users, would give government the flexibility to levy merchant charges on notified digital payment modes, as it seeks a sustainable funding model for the platform's next phase of growth.

The government had banned MDR on UPI and RuPay debit card transactions from January 2020 to accelerate digital payments and promote home-grown payment systems.

Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman will introduce the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday. The Bill will allow the Centre to decide which digital payment methods may attract fees. The government is expected to notify the rate of MDR and the type of transactions it can be levied on, once the Bill has been approved. Reports had earlier suggested that MDR may only be applicable on large value or large merchant transactions.

With the Bill, the government aims to provide statutory backing to three key tax and financial measures announced by the government earlier.



ISTOCKPHOTO

The government seeks to replace the Income-tax (Amendment) Ordinance, 2026, which provided tax relief to foreign portfolio investors (FPIs), by incorporating its provisions into law through amendments to the Finance Act, 2026. The Lok Sabha agenda includes the laying of an explanatory statement detailing the reasons for promulgating the ordinance.

In addition, the Bill proposes amendments to the Income-tax Act, 2025 to extend the tax

exemption available for contract manufacturing undertaken for foreign companies. The proposal is expected to extend the sunset period for the tax benefit from assessment year FY31 to assessment year FY41, providing a longer policy horizon for eligible manufacturing arrangements.

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For an extended version of this story, go to live-mint.com

Centre raises windfall tax on petrol, diesel, jet fuel exports

The Union finance ministry has increased the windfall tax on exports of petrol, diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) to ₹3.5 per litre, ₹25.5 per litre and ₹22 per litre, respectively.

The total export levy on diesel includes a special additional excise duty (SAED) of ₹24 and a road and infrastructure cess (RIC) of ₹1.5 per litre.

The new rates have come into effect from Monday. For the past fortnight, the windfall levy on exports of petrol, diesel and ATF stood at ₹2.5, ₹15.5 and ₹14.5 per litre, respectively.

These windfall export levies were introduced with effect from 27 March so as to ensure domestic availability of petroleum products by disincentivizing exports amid the West Asia war.

The rates are revised every fortnight based on the average international prices of crude oil, petrol, diesel and ATF during the period since the last review.

RITURAJ BARUAH

Essar Group to invest \$5.8 bn in UK energy hub transition

The Essar Group plans to invest £4.3 billion (\$5.8 billion) in the expansion of its UK Stanlow refinery to include an energy transition hub with a focus on low-carbon hydrogen production.

The group's energy unit is nearing a final investment decision on projects worth more than £1 billion, according to a statement from Essar Energy Transition Fuels, which operates the 230,000 barrels-a-day refinery near Liverpool. Plans include reconfiguring the refinery into a single-train operation to boost yields of higher-value products and expand the range of crude grades it can process.

The firm will also expand its fuel retail network. It has recently completed a £100 million project to boost Stanlow's processing capacity by about 8%, and has built a hydrogen-ready refinery furnace as part of the transition to low-carbon operations, according to the statement.

The group is betting on hydrogen and other low-carbon businesses to diversify earnings.

BLOOMBERG

Inside the sudden layoffs at Visa India

FROM PAGE 1

power of AI to execute work and tasks with our supervision."

He said agentic commerce will expand the company's addressable market and drive growth for Visa. Agentic commerce refers to the emerging use of autonomous AI agents to research, select, negotiate and make purchases on behalf of humans.

Visa did not say how many of the roles being eliminated would be in India, its largest technology base outside the US. Its global headcount rose about 8% in fiscal 2025 to roughly 34,100. While the number of employees in India is not public, the company said in a statement in 2024 that its workforce exceeds 3,500 employees here.

Visa operates corporate, business and major technology hubs in India from Bengaluru and Mumbai, with additional corporate presence in Chennai and Hyderabad. Bengaluru is the company's primary large-scale technology and software development centre.

Mint spoke to six former and current employees from India to piece together what happened last week. All of them spoke on condition of anonymity. Visa did not respond to queries.

The cuts were deep enough to hollow out whole teams. On one India team of 28 people, 10 were let go, employees said. Seniority did not help. Among those who lost their jobs were a director with about two decades at the company and a senior director with 21 years, along with several long-serving engineering



Visa did not say how many of the roles being eliminated would be in India, its largest technology base outside the US. REUTERS

managers.

Severance packages varied widely and came with roughly 15 to 30 days of notice. "Some are getting a lot and some are getting less," one employee said on condition of anonymity as they were not authorized to speak publicly.

Although they were asked to serve notice periods, many employees had to hand over their ID cards and laptops and their access to company email was removed by Friday. The Bengaluru office emptied out within days. On Friday, people had been scuffling about to find places to sit. By Wednesday the place was dead silent.

"Seeing your colleagues' empty tables hurts a lot, and you can be the next any time," said an employee who kept their job but lost their manager. The experience was draining, they said, even for those who

were safe.

Several of those laid off turned down invitations from former teammates for a farewell.

"When I reached out to all of them, most of them were not ready to come," one employee said. They did not want anything to do with the company that had just let them go.

The Visa job cuts show how AI is slowing the pace of hiring and taking over or supplementing some roles in companies. Goldman Sachs, in a 28 July report, said 8% to 12% of India's non-agricultural employment is at risk of substitution from generative AI and 42% to 48% of jobs are more likely to be complemented by it, closer to augmentation than displacement.

It found that job cuts in Indian technology have been concentrated in the six largest listed IT services firms, which shed a net 64,000 roles

out of 1.7 million, while the rest of the sector, including global capability centres like Visa's in Bengaluru, added 700,000 people in three years.

"For instance, in financial services, Gen-AI can complement analyst roles by automating some form of basic modelling, but may completely substitute routine back-office functions like basic compliance checks," Goldman Sachs said in the report.

The advent of AI has also led companies to reduce hiring. Total new hires at nine of the 30 S&P 500 companies fell 27% between from FY24 to FY26, Mint reported on Monday.

The cuts at Visa did not come out of nowhere, employees said, even if the timing was a surprise. Over the preceding months, contractor hiring was pulled back and spending on outside software vendors was cut with the justification that AI could replace some of it.

In July, caps appeared on AI tool usage where access had been open before. Developers in the US said they were expected to use large language models for their work, then handed a \$1,500 monthly limit on the tokens they could consume.

"This is the fourth such cost-cutting measure within the last quarter," a Bengaluru-based employee said.

The contradiction is not lost on the people in Visa. AI is simultaneously the reason costs have escalated and the justification offered for the headcount reduction.

"It's making us more efficient but we are not seeing the impact that is expected by the CXOs," the employee said. "On the other hand, the cost has gone out of hand."



ICICI Lombard is looking to boost its product portfolio and improve customer engagement. MINT

ICICI Lombard eyes risk manager tag

ICICI Lombard General Insurance wants to be known as a risk manager for its customers, and not just as an insurance company. For this, the insurer is looking to boost its product portfolio and increase customer engagement touchpoints, the company's chief financial officer Gopal Balachandran told Mint.

"What we have tried to create is to significantly enlarge the role of ICICI Lombard from not being just a risk transfer partner but to aid risk management," said Balachandran, adding that this is a continuing effort, and the company is now aiming for some scale.

Having been slower than some peers in terms of product launches, ICICI Lombard is now betting on new product launches as well as policy add-ons and value-added services to increase revenue and customer retention, and improve customer experience and operational efficiencies, Balachandran said.

"Honestly, we did not do a great job historically in terms of our ability to come out with product launches or for the matter of fact, in relative benchmark with competition. But, over the last 2-3 years, we made cognizance of it," Balachandran said.

SAMRIDHI MAHAR & ANSHIKA KAYASTHA

Derivatives trading sinks on RBI curbs

India's largest stock exchange was severely hit by the central bank's tighter funding rules implemented in July, with spending on derivatives slumping to a 17-month low.

Average daily notional turnover for futures and options on National Stock Exchange of India Ltd (NSE) declined 23% to ₹214 trillion (\$2.2 trillion) in July from June, the lowest since February 2025. Meanwhile, at listed peer BSE Ltd, it jumped 8.4% to ₹232 trillion.

Another closely watched gauge of options activity, average daily premium turnover, slid 18% to ₹50,200 crore last month for NSE and 3.1% to ₹25,400 crore for BSE.

The drop comes after the Reserve Bank of India required bank guarantees be fully backed by collateral, with at least half in cash. While this reduces risk for lenders, it curbs leverage among local trading firms, raising funding costs and limiting capacity to execute deals.

BLOOMBERG



Founded in 1995, the company has expertise in topical and transdermal dosage forms. BLOOMBERG

Encube Ethicals eyes ₹3,000-cr IPO

Specialty pharmaceutical company Encube Ethicals has filed preliminary papers with the markets regulator for an initial public offering (IPO) worth ₹3,000 crore.

The Mumbai-based company's public offering is completely an offer for sale (OFS) by promoter Mehul Madhusudan Shah and existing shareholder Frontier Investment Holdings Pte. Ltd, according to the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) filed on Friday.

Founded in 1995, the company is a global specialty pharmaceutical formulations platform with deep domain expertise in technically complex topical and transdermal dosage forms, serving 50 countries, including regulated markets such as the United States, UK and Europe, and India as of 31 March 2026.

On the financial front, its revenue from operations was at ₹1,848.7 crore and its net profit at ₹436.7 crore during FY26.

PTI

LEAP eyes \$734 mn valuation in IPO

KKR-backed supply chain firm LEAP India is seeking a valuation of about ₹7,000 crore (\$733.91 million) for its \$260 million initial public offering (IPO), according to a newspaper advertisement and the company's red herring prospectus.

The IPO will open for public subscription on 7 August and close on 11 August.

The IPO comprises of a fresh issue of shares worth \$50.3 million and an offer for sale of \$209.7 million of shares.

KKR-backed Vertical Holdings II will sell shares worth \$209.5 million in IPO, while promoter group KIA EBT Scheme 3 will sell remaining shares. Anchor investors can bid for shares on 6 August, while the shares are expected to begin trading on 14 August.

LEAP has 30 warehouses, 7 outsourced pallet manufacturing units, over 900 customers, and over 3,250 employees.

REUTERS

DBS hires former StanChart banker

DBS Group Holdings Ltd has hired Nitin Chengappa, a former Standard Chartered Plc banker, to head its wealth management business in India as it bets on rising demand for tailored products from the country's newly rich.

Chengappa joined the lender in July and reports to Ambuj Chandra, who heads DBS's consumer banking business in India, said people familiar with the matter who requested not to be identified as the appointment has not been publicly announced. DBS Bank India confirmed to Bloomberg News that Chengappa had joined the firm as managing director and head of Treasuries Business and Wealth Management but didn't provide further details.

Chengappa spent nearly a decade at Standard Chartered in India where he last worked as head of affluent distribution and branch network, according to his LinkedIn profile. Previously, he spent more than a decade at HSBC Holdings Plc, among others.

BLOOMBERG



WHY MOST AI PILOTS END UP IN THE GRAVEYARD

Scaling AI isn't a technical problem—it requires fixing messy data and redesigning legacy processes

Mastufa Ahmed
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NEW DELHI

Tata Steel has spent eight years building artificial intelligence (AI) into the fabric of its business. Today, more than 680 AI applications run across the steel major's operations in India. They monitor equipment for early signs of failure, process invoices, and guide engineers through troubleshooting before a breakdown occurs.

Soumo Bose, the company's chief AI officer, does not call any of it 'artificial intelligence'. "We call it augmenting intelligence," he says, reflecting the company's belief that AI should enhance human capability rather than replace it.

The distinction matters. That journey took a decade of investment in data infrastructure and specialized talent before a single model went into production.

Most Indian enterprises have not made that investment. Getting AI to work was never the hard part. The harder part is everything that comes after—embedding it into legacy systems, redesigning how people work, and proving it is worth the cost.

FLIRTY BUSINESS

There used to be a joke among Indian technology leaders. There were more AI pilots in Indian enterprises than airline pilots in Indian skies.

Rajesh Nambiar, president of Nasscom, the IT industry's lobby body, still uses the line, but with a different conclusion attached. "We're now beginning to see many of those pilots move into production," he says. "That's the good news."

But the headline tells only part of the story. Nearly half of Indian enterprises—47%, according to a 2026 EY-CII survey of 200 companies—now have multiple AI use cases running in live workflows. But running AI in one department is not the same as running it across an organization. Data from Nasscom and IBM's Institute for Business Value independently found that only 15% of organizations have reached that harder milestone: scaling AI cross-functionally, with unified governance and measurable outcomes across the business. "Many organizations are flirting with AI," says Nambiar. "Only 15% are actually scaling it."

Prasanto Kumar Roy, a Delhi-based technology policy advisor and a former technology editor, has a sharper description for what the rest are left with. "Many businesses are now AI pilot graveyards," he says. "Proof-of-concepts that may have been successful on their own, but created operational friction when forced to scale enterprise-wide."

Rishi Aurora, managing partner at IBM Consulting, sees another pattern. Some companies, he says, treat AI as a "tick-in-the-box exercise", pursuing programmes largely to demonstrate progress to their boards.

WHERE IT WORKED

The companies that have crossed from experimentation into operational AI share one characteristic that has nothing to do with the sophistication of their models. They started earlier, invested longer, and built the foundations that allowed AI to disappear into every-day operations.

At Tata Steel, the journey began eight years ago. Its internal platform, the Tata Steel Digital Assistant or TDA, has an unexpectedly mundane origin: when ChatGPT launched in 2023, the company blocked public generative AI platforms over data security concerns and built its own alternative. Today, TDA runs nearly 200 AI agents used by more than 12,000 officers across India and some UK group companies.

The more consequential work sits inside the plants. Predictive modelling applied to critical equipment has improved availability by between 5% and 20% depending on the asset. Invoice processing has reached approximately 95% automation. The employee who once validated every line item now reviews only what the AI flags as uncertain. "Data and talent have been our two strategic investment vectors for the good part of the last decade," says Bose. "The results you see today are not something we turned around in a year."

Apollo Hospitals has 20 certified AI algorithms—12 in live clinical use, having processed 5 million interactions (API calls) across its platforms over two and a half years. Its cardiovascular risk prediction tool, AICVD, has been used in 3.5 million patient assessments over five years. A prospective study found that screened patients showed 4.92 times lower mortal-



Tata Steel's AI and IoT-integrated fleet management system tracks mining, logistics, and supply chain operations in real time, part of a deployment spanning 850-plus AI models globally.

ity, though Apollo notes the analysis is observational, unadjusted for confounding, and currently under peer review.

What distinguishes Apollo is its operational discipline. Each certified system carries a monthly tracker covering uptime, error rates, and change frequency. Value is assessed per 100,000 interactions. One disease-progression tool is projected to generate approximately \$9 million in revenue for every 100,000 patient assessments it processes, based on what comparable healthcare systems in developed markets charge for similar diagnostics.

"The differentiator between organizations that scale and those that stall," says Dr Sujoy Kar, Apollo's chief medical information officer, "is whether AI is treated as a governed clinical capability or a procurement decision."

The impact of AICVD is most visible in the patients it identifies before symptoms appear. Earlier, cardiovascular risk assessment relied on symptoms, ECG findings, laboratory values and clinical judgement. Patients with no obvious warning signs often left routine health checks reassured, unaware of the risk building beneath the surface. When the system flags a patient as high risk, the consultation becomes more proactive. The physician reviews the AI score alongside the patient's history and examination, then considers additional investigations, preventive medication, specialist referral and more intensive lifestyle counselling.

Trust did not come overnight. When AICVD was first introduced, many clinicians treated it as a decision-support tool that had to prove itself. Confidence grew gradually as its predictions were repeatedly validated through subsequent clinical evaluations.

"Rather than waiting for disease to become clinically apparent," says Dr Kar, "the clinician can now intervene earlier with greater confidence, using AI as a trusted decision-support partner while retaining full responsibility for the final clinical decision."

At Hindustan Unilever's Haridwar factory, recognised by the World Economic Forum as a Global Lighthouse site in June 2026, an AI-powered 'Supply Chain Nerve Centre' coordinates production in real time. Response times have fallen 72%, inventory days are down 24%, and on-time in-full (OTIF) delivery has reached 99%.

In telecommunications, Airtel's network-level AI has intercepted more than 27.5 billion spam calls. When fraudsters adapted by routing traffic through interna-

tional networks, Airtel extended the system to cover overseas calls and added multi-lingual alerts in nine Indian languages.

At DBS Bank India, a generative AI content-capture tool used by 1,500 branch employees has cut data-entry time by around 50%. A separate customer service tool has improved the identification of secondary customer signals by more than 40%. More than two-thirds of the bank's India employees now use generative AI as part of their daily work.

Tech policy advisor Roy points to Air India's customer assistant, AIg, as a case of the transition done well. What began as the airline's Maharaja chatbot has evolved into an agentic system integrated directly into core operational infrastructure. AIg now handles nine out of ten customer queries.

THE SANDBOX TRAP

Getting a pilot to work is one thing. Scaling it across the enterprise is another.

"AI can look sexy when the 'AI guy' in a company picks up a problem or two and uses prompts to show how quickly he can get outputs," says Roy. "But they can't scale that."

The reason is rarely the model. The hardest part begins after the pilot works, says Vic Gupta, executive vice president and head of product development at Coforge, which implements AI across large enterprises. "Technology is rarely the constraint. Change management, process redesign, ownership, and governance usually are."

Four failure modes emerge consistently across the companies that have tried.

The first is data. At Kiroloskar, the journey of an AI-powered quality inspection tool from pilot to production began an education in what controlled environments hide. The pilot worked. The defect detection model performed well on curated datasets assembled by the team—spreadsheets, isolated databases, carefully selected examples. Then it met the factory floor.

"We encountered a far wider array of defect combinations in the real-world environment than we had captured in our controlled pilots," says Ashok Jade, the global chief information officer of Kiroloskar Brothers Ltd. "Many variables were siloed in disparate systems or were not yet digitized."

The model had to be rebuilt. Jade calls this the 'sandbox trap'—the gap between data that is tidy enough to prove a concept and data that reflects industrial reality. The quality inspection tool eventually delivered a 50% reduction in inspection cycle times and a 20% to 25% improvement in employee efficiency, but only after that rebuild.

Nasscom's Nambiar identifies data quality as the single most common barrier to scaling AI across Indian enterprises.

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KEY
NUMBERS

15%

Organizations that successfully scaled AI cross-functionally with unified governance and measurable business outcomes.

200

AI agents run by Tata Steel's digital assistant. They are used by more than 12,000 officers across India and the UK.

3.5 MILLION

Patient assessments that used Apollo Hospitals' cardiovascular risk prediction tool, AICVD, over the last five years.

Today's reality

A majority of Indian organizations haven't yet scaled AI

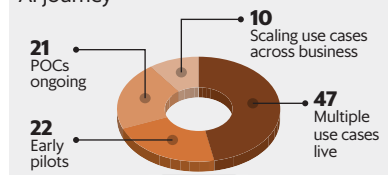
Metric	Value (%)
Organizations scaling AI today	15
Organizations locked in pilots	85
Organizations expected to scale AI by 2030	62

Methodology: Survey of 1,500 Indian executives conducted by Oxford Economics across industries and the public sector.

Source: IBM Institute for Business Value, From Promise to Power: How AI is redefining India's economic future (2026)

Scaling up AI

Enterprises in their GenAI/agentic AI journey



Methodology: Survey of 200 organizations across 20+ industries.

Source: EY-CII, The Aldea of India: Outlook 2026

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

human decision and signature close every chain."

DBS Bank India takes a similar approach through its PURE framework, ensuring all data use is purposeful, unsurprising, respectable, and explainable. Rather than auditing AI after deployment, the bank embeds business, risk, and governance teams into the design phase from the outset. At Tata Steel, every AI system must clear three stages before going live—cold, warm, and hot trials—designed as much to build operator confidence as to test technical accuracy.

The underlying approach is the same across all three. "The best performers bake compliance directly into the product lifecycle," says Roy. "You cannot do AI now and figure out compliance later."

THE DESTINATION

Most Indian enterprises still derive AI value from first-phase efficiency gains—faster processing, fewer manual steps, lower error rates. These are real achievements, but they are not the destination.

"If you are deploying agentic AI effectively," says Nambiar, "the objective should not simply be cost reduction. It should be about changing your business model, entering new markets, reaching new customer segments. Otherwise, if AI is only being used as automation on steroids, you don't necessarily need AI."

Apollo Hospitals applies the same discipline to AI economics as it does to clinical outcomes. A model that is clinically accurate but cannot demonstrate a credible economic case does not earn the infrastructure investment needed to expand.

At Kiroloskar, every AI initiative is tied directly to a performance indicator owned by the relevant business unit—not a technology metric but a business one.

"CEOs really talk about one thing," says Aurora. "If my revenue was supposed to grow by X using these technologies, have I achieved that business outcome? Nobody talks to me about the how."

The companies in this story represent the leading edge of Indian enterprise AI. Even they are only at the beginning. IBM's India study found that 62% of technology executives expect to be scaling AI broadly across their organizations by 2030. Nasscom's Nambiar estimates that Indian enterprises have realised only about 20% of AI's overall potential.

Closing that gap does not require a better model. It demands investment in data architecture, talent, governance, and the unglamorous work of redesigning processes long before anyone can see the return.



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Passive funds go niche: should you bet on sectoral or thematic funds?

As index funds, ETFs become mainstream, fund houses are increasingly launching sectoral or thematic products

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MUMBAI

Passive investing is no longer just about buying the Nifty 50 or the Sensex. As index funds and exchange-traded funds (ETFs) become mainstream, fund houses are increasingly launching sectoral or thematic products tracking banks, metals, energy, chemicals, defence, capital markets and more.

The timing has helped. Even as headline indices have struggled, several sectoral indices have delivered strong returns, attracting investor interest. In the six months to 30 July 2026, the Nifty 50 Total Return Index (TRI) fell 3.3%, while the Nifty 500 TRI gained just 1.8%. Over the same period, the Nifty Pharma TRI rose 22%, Nifty Healthcare 20.8%, Nifty Realty 15.3%, Nifty Capital Markets 13% and Nifty India Defence 12.7%. TRI returns capture both stock price gains and dividends.

Passive sectoral or thematic funds simply track their underlying index. Their base expense ratios range from about 0.14% to 0.50%, offering investors a relatively low-cost way to gain exposure to specific sectors or themes.

Beyond broad indices

The appeal is straightforward: investors get exposure to an entire sector without taking fund manager risk.

"If you want exposure to a particular sector but don't want to take fund manager risk, sectoral ETFs and index funds are a good way to do it," said Anubhav Srivastava, partner and fund manager at Infinity Alternatives.

Fund manager risk refers to the possibility that a manager's stock selection or portfolio weightings underperform the sector benchmark. A passive fund eliminates that risk by simply holding the index.

"If investors can identify favourable sector cycles, then such funds can be useful," said Anish Teli, managing partner at QED Capital Advisors.

A thematic index differs slightly from a sectoral index by tracking a broader investment idea rather than a single industry.

Defence is one such theme. Companies sit across capital goods, autos and chemicals. As of 30 June 2026, the Nifty India Defence index was 74% capital goods, 14.47% automobiles and auto components, and 11.53% chemicals.

Know the risks

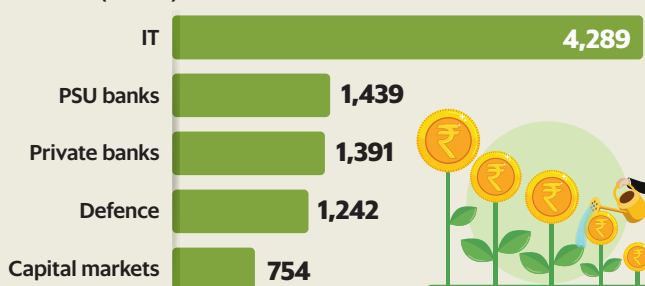
Investors should understand how these indices are constructed before investing.

Buying a sector or theme

With market benchmark indices range-bound, investors are showing appetite for passive funds tracking sectoral and theme indices.

Top five sectors and themes by passive flows in 2026 (up to 30 June 2026)

Net flows (₹ crore)

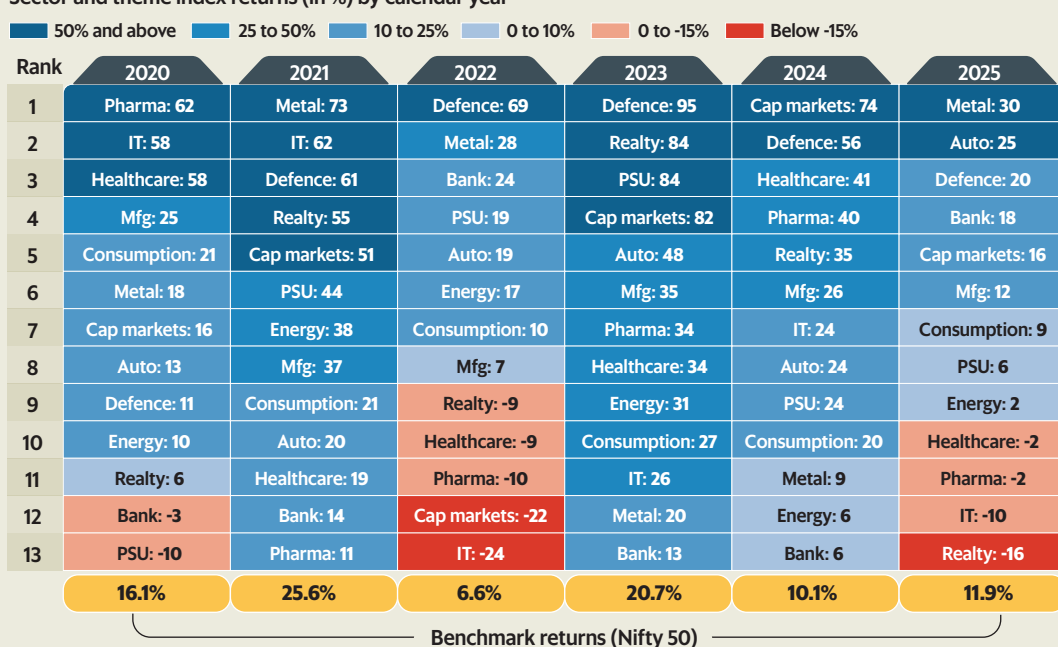


Source: Compiled by DSP Mutual Fund

Note: Index and ETF flows are combined, flows are estimated by stripping out impact of returns on change in AUM

Sector or theme returns can oscillate, making it difficult to time these investments

Sector and theme index returns (in %) by calendar year



Source: niftyindices.com; returns are based on Total Return Index of indices, which captures stock price movement and dividend gains

Note: table doesn't represent rankings of an exhaustive list of sector and thematic indices; cap markets stands for capital markets; PSU stands for public sector undertakings or government-owned companies, Mfg for manufacturing, IT for Information Technology

What to watch out for

► **Concentration:** sector indices are market-cap weighted, sector leaders can dominate

► **No trimming:** index fund must hold a falling heavyweight until the index is rebalanced

► **Timing risk:** sectors are cyclical, entry and exit points can be critical

► **Not for everyone:** needs high-risk appetite and grasp of sector cycles for a tactical bet

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"Investors should always understand how the underlying index is constructed," said Teli. "Many sector indices are market-cap weighted, meaning one or two companies can dominate the portfolio."

Thematic indices can also be concentrated. As of 30 June 2026, in the Nifty India Defence index, Hindustan Aeronautics carried a weight of 19.93%, while Bharat Electronics accounted for 19.79%.

These tend to be narrow portfolios. Nifty IT holds just 10 companies, while Nifty Realty and Nifty Private Bank each hold 10. Nifty Bank has 14 constituents, Nifty Auto and Nifty Metal 15 each, and Nifty India Defence holds 19 stocks.

Market-cap weighting, however, also helps with liquidity.

"It generally improves liquidity because the larger companies also typically have higher trading volumes," said Teli.

There are safeguards against excessive concentration. Sectoral indices such as Nifty Healthcare, Nifty Pharma and Nifty IT cap any single stock at 33% and the top three combined at 62%. Nifty India Defence caps each stock at 20%.

These weights are rebalanced quarterly on the last trading day of March, June, September and December, while index constituents are reviewed twice a year. Between rebalancing dates, funds continue to hold stocks in line with the index, even if a heavy-weight undergoes a sharp correction.

According to Teli, investors should also be cautious about investing in new fund offers (NFOs).

"Often a sectoral fund gets launched when the sector is already hot and drawing investor interest, and that is often not the right time to enter. An investor should never rush into a sector or theme because of FOMO."

Tracking error and tracking difference are other things to watch out for—how closely the fund replicates its benchmark.

ETF or index fund?

For most investors, an index fund is the simpler option. It is purchased at end-of-day net asset value (NAV), supports systematic investment plans (SIPs) and does not require a demat account.

An ETF, meanwhile, trades on stock exchanges. Investors incur brokerage, bid-ask spreads and impact costs in addition to the expense ratio. ETFs can also trade above or below their indicative net asset value (iNAV).

However, ETFs allow taking advantage of intraday market dips.

Tactical allocation

These funds are not suitable for everyone. Investors with a higher risk appetite who understand sector cycles and can judge entry and exit points may consider allocating a portion of their portfolio to them.

For everyone else, experts say diversified equity funds remain the better option, leaving sector allocation decisions to professional fund managers.



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POINT

ARAVIND VENUGOPAL

We welcome your views and comments at
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WHY INCENTIVES ARE BETTER THAN COMMISSION CAPS

For two decades, India capped the commission an insurer could pay on each product. In April 2023, it removed those caps, allowing insurers to set commissions as their boards decide, subject to an overall ceiling on expenses. While the reform was sound, it has already triggered a backlash. As evidence mounts of intermediaries mis-selling insurance to customers, calls to bring commissions back under control are growing.

Before India reaches for the cap again, however, one question must be answered: What did 20 years of caps actually achieve?

Caps circumvented

Between 2018 and 2022, while the old caps were firmly in force, tax investigators uncovered a systemic practice of insurers paying intermediaries far above the permitted commission and disguising the excess as service fees, supported by invoices that also yielded ineligible tax credits. The cap had not held commissions down. It had merely pushed them into costumes.

The insurance regulator's own files tell the same story. In 2024 it penalized a large life insurer after finding that payments presented as marketing and advertising expenses were, in substance, excess commissions. Wherever a hard limit sits on what may be paid, ingenuity finds a way to pay more without appearing to do so. The lesson is uncomfortable but clear. What disciplines distribution is rarely the headline commission number, which can be circumvented, but the transparency and structure of what is paid.

Singapore lessons

Singapore's experience is instructive. It combines three measures, and it is the combination that matters. First, its caps target structure rather than merely the level. Commission on a regular-premium life policy must be spread over at least six years, with no more than 55% paid in the first year. Spreading the commission means advisors are paid in full only if the policy persists, reducing the front-loading that fuels churn. Second, it links an adviser's pay to the quality of the sale, docking commissions for poor suitability or inadequate disclosure.

Third, insurers must disclose the cost of distribution to customers as a specific figure. Every individual life policy's benefit illustration states the total distribution cost, allowing customers to make informed choices.

India's progress

India is closer to Singapore's model than it first appears. The 2025 changes to the Insurance Act allow the regulator to prescribe how commissions are paid and disclosed. Insurers already operate board-approved commission policies within an overall expense ceiling, meaning much of the scaffolding for a disclosure-led regime already exists. The regulator's June 2026 paper on intermediary regulations moves further in this direction by requiring large distributors to publicly disclose commissions.

Better path

What the evidence rules out is the reflex to bring back product-level commission caps. That regime produced hidden commissions. Reimposing it would simply repeat a known failure. The better path completes a principle India already applies: costs should track the premium-paying term. But that principle currently binds only the insurer's expenses, not the agent's remuneration. Nothing requires the commission itself to be spread over time, allowing the bulk of it to still be paid in the first year. An agent paid upfront has little stake in whether the policy survives. The reform, therefore, is to carry the same principle through to distributor compensation, so that agents, like insurers, earn commissions only as the policy persists: commissions spread across the premium-paying term, clawed back when policies lapse early, and enforced through persistency data.

Long-term goal

India still has a long journey ahead. Insurance premiums account for just 3.7% of GDP—only a little over half the global average of 7%. With the goal of achieving "Insurance for All by 2047", the temptation is to close this gap through more aggressive selling. But mis-sold policies lapse, and a lapsed policy is not penetration—it is churn. What will close the protection gap sustainably is a framework that aligns the intermediary's interests with those of the policyholder: spreading commissions over time, rewarding the quality of advice, and disclosing distribution costs transparently. That alignment, far more than any commission cap, is what the next round of insurance reforms must secure.

Aravind Venugopal is partner at Khaitan & Co. The views expressed are personal.

Govt moots tax relief for offshore funds using local managers

Reuters
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MUMBAI

India has proposed tax law amendments to shield offshore investment funds from Indian tax liabilities when they route investments

through India-based fund managers, a draft bill showed.

The proposed change comes as the country faces significant foreign outflows, prompting the government to take measures to attract overseas investors by easing access. The government described

the new rules as being framed "in order to promote fund management activity and provide tax certainty."

An email query sent to the finance ministry was not answered immediately.

Under the existing rules, an offshore fund must maintain a

minimum corpus of ₹100 crore (\$10.49 million), have at least 20 investors, and cap any single investor's contribution at 25% in order to be shielded from Indian tax. Funds that fail to meet these conditions risk having their India-sourced profits taxed at rates of up to

38%.

The new bill proposes removing all minimum size and diversification requirements under the safe harbour rules, meaning offshore funds—regardless of their asset base or investor concentration—could use Indian fund man-

agers without triggering a tax liability, provided the bill is passed by parliament.

Nehal Sampat, a partner at PricewaterhouseCoopers, said offshore funds had previously struggled to comply with the safe harbour conditions when appointing onshore managers.

Check how your NPS investments are faring

There are very few retirement products that help you accumulate a retirement nest egg and one such product is the National Pension System (NPS). It is a market-linked, defined-contribution product that needs you to invest regularly in the funds of your choice. The returns are based on the performance of the fund that you choose. There are eleven pension fund managers to choose from and one of the ways to do that is by tracking the returns. Here is a breakdown of the performance of different funds—equity fund, government bond fund and corporate bond fund—of the private sector NPS. This NPS table shows returns for pension fund managers who have completed at least 1 year

Fund Manager	Returns (in %)								
	1 year			3 years			5 years		
	Equity fund	Government bond fund	Corporate debt fund	Equity fund	Government bond fund	Corporate debt fund	Equity fund	Government bond fund	Corporate debt fund
Axis Pension Fund	-0.76	9.23	-	2.90	6.78	-	5.55	7.73	-
Aditya Birla Sun Life	3.39	10.39	11.61	3.17	7.14	6.58	5.19	7.66	6.74
DSP Pension Fund	-5.57	-	-	2.49	-	-	5.69	-	-
HDFC Pension Fund	3.08	10.99	11.67	2.39	6.71	6.16	5.58	8.07	7.00
ICICI Pru. Pension Fund	3.48	11.87	12.57	2.91	6.91	6.26	5.53	7.85	6.79
Kotak Mahindra Pension	1.54	11.42	12.25	2.35	6.49	6.14	5.79	7.92	6.82
LIC Pension Fund	1.51	10.00	11.49	3.05	7.12	6.51	5.26	7.55	6.59
SBI Pension Funds	2.20	8.86	10.71	2.92	7.10	6.42	5.65	7.92	6.79
Tata Pension Fund	4.19	12.47	-	2.25	6.57	-	5.15	7.73	-
UTI Pension Fund	0.84	11.48	11.89	3.09	7.17	6.59	5.83	7.90	6.75
NPS Equity Index									
2.6 11.38 12.12									
NPS Govt. Security Index									
3.34 7.42 6.61									
NPS Corporate Bond Index									
5.46 7.49 6.64									
Benchmark index									

Non-Government POP returns data as on 1 August 2026
Source: Npstrust.org.in

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How foreign share gains are taxed in India

Harshal Bhuta

I returned to India in 2023 after working in the US for over 15 years. During my stay in the US, I had acquired shares of several companies listed on the NYSE. I now want to book gains and reinvest the money into new shares. Since I will not be remitting the money back to India, are these capital gains to be computed at the rupee exchange rate at the time of purchase or at today's exchange rate? If it is today's exchange rate, are there any provisions to protect against rupee depreciation given that I had purchased the shares in USD long before?

—Name withheld on request

Since you returned to India in 2023, I assume you will qualify as a Resident and Ordinarily Resident (ROR) in India for the tax year 2026–27. Further, although you may have acquired the shares during your stay in the US, since you propose to sell them in August 2026, the tax implications of



ASK MINT
TAX IN INDIA

such sale will be governed by the provisions of the Income Tax Act, 2025, which came into effect on 1 April 2026.

Notwithstanding the fact that you do not wish to repatriate the sale proceeds to India, the capital gains earned in foreign currency are still required to be computed in INR. There is no separate tax relief or concession available in respect of the rupee depreciation that

the last day of the month immediately preceding the month in which the shares are sold. In your case, the applicable exchange rate would be the SBI TT buying rate as on 31 July 2026 considering the proposed sale in August 2026.

As you have held the foreign-listed shares for more than 24 months, they qualify as long-term capital assets. The resultant long-term capital gains will be taxable in India at 12.5%, plus the applicable surcharge and cess. Also, since you held foreign shares during calendar year 2026, you are also required to disclose these, along with the income from them, in Schedule FA of your income-tax return for the tax year 2026–27.

Harshal Bhuta, Partner, P.R. Bhuta & Co.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at
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and get them answered by industry experts.

OUR VIEW



Policy churn: the Centre as a venture capitalist?

India's government plans to share the risks of oil and gas exploration with explorers. The success of this bold new policy would partly depend on how smartly its outlay is deployed

The Samudra Manthan exploration policy framework announced by India's government offers a well-structured and realistic approach to improving the chances of finding oil and gas reserves in the country. It comes none too early. The existing policy, which has been in force for a decade, has hardly yielded any significant commercial discoveries. On the other hand, supply disruptions in the wake of the Gulf crisis have made it imperative to find domestic reserves. Since we import 90% of our oil and half our gas needs, the country's risk exposure is high.

To be sure, the Centre has been tweaking its exploration policy bit by bit, be it a review of old geological data, an increase in the area on offer for exploration or moves to improve the ease of doing business. However, outcomes fell short because the core issue had largely been left unaddressed. Past measures did not make the business attractive enough for global majors to participate. Given their rich experience and skill in reading earthy data to drill at the right spot in a patch of several thousand square kilometres, that counts as India's loss. They evidently see brighter prospects of oil and gas strikes in other parts of the world. Moreover, even if they do participate, such ventures require risk capital. An explorer must spend plenty for probable access to hydrocarbons extractable at a profit. Persistence must pay off even after a few dud attempts, each of which could burn as much as \$180 million or so. The solution, hence, lies in risk sharing. Of course, this provides no certainty of success, but it shortens the odds of it considerably. A salient feature of the latest policy allows for funding of 60 wells "up to 50 per cent of the eligible

drilling costs or ₹675 crore [\$70 million], whichever is lower."

Cost evaluations pose a big challenge in this sector. Indeed, that is what led to the demise of India's New Exploration Licensing Policy (Nelp), which ran for 18 years before it was replaced in 2016 by the Hydrocarbon Exploration and Licensing Policy (Help). From an investor perspective, this rejig did not live up to its name. Nelp had let investors recover their costs while sharing production volumes from discoveries with the government, but Help got rid of cost recovery, reducing the financial appeal of the proposition. It was akin to an infant thrown out with the bathwater. Participation and commercial discoveries both dried up. Nelp lasted longer, but left a better track record on the whole. Now, India's Samudra Manthan policy goes one step ahead of Nelp, under which the Centre did not take on any of the explorer's exploration risk. For the first time, it offers to partly fund the drilling costs of private firms. While the Semicon Mission for computer chips may seem like a parallel, this business differs in its risk-return profile. Hydrocarbon hunting also happens to be a long-gestation game, with commercial strikes typically taking a decade to reach fuel tanks. How attractive the new deal proves, however, should be clear within a year. As we await the response of global explorers, it is tempting to recall that Guyana's mega discovery which made waves—a surprise since it was not seen as an oil-rich region—was on the back of a policy that resembled India's Nelp in allowing cost recovery. But what we now have is a novel form of state involvement. By stumping up money for drilling, New Delhi has decided to act in the spirit of a venture capitalist.

Is Gift City the new Mauritius? It's luring foreign F&O traders

It offers foreign portfolio investors looking to trade derivatives on the NSE an attractive avenue



AMIT BAID
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For decades, the story of foreign capital entering India had a familiar opening line: it began somewhere else—usually in Mauritius. Between 2000 and 2024, Mauritius accounted for nearly one-fourth of India's foreign direct investment—about \$179 billion. It was India's largest single-country source. The island nation was a legal address through which global capital reached India. An entire ecosystem grew around one idea: the right tax treaty could transform the returns on investing in India.

That idea is fading. As treaties narrowed and scrutiny intensified, Mauritius lost its shine. Another island nation, Singapore, has overtaken it in recent quarters. But the more interesting development is that smart capital is no longer looking for overseas islands.

The successor is a stretch of reclaimed land on the banks of the Sabarmati: the Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (Gift City) and the International Financial Services Centre (IFSC) within it. And what it offers is fundamentally different from the model it is replacing. The old structures depended on borrowed advantages—a treaty, a residence certificate and the tax relief they promised. Gift City offers something that need not be borrowed at all: a tax outcome written directly into Indian law.

The Gift City proposition is particu-

larly compelling for foreign investors trading listed Indian derivatives. A non-resident can establish a Category III Alternative Investment Fund (AIF) in Gift City, obtain foreign portfolio investor (FPI) registration and trade futures and options (F&O) on the NSE and BSE. Profits from such trading are exempt under India's own domestic tax law, rather than a treaty or any concession granted by another jurisdiction.

For derivative trading strategies, this is transformative. F&O trading is high-volume and margin-driven; it often invites tax disputes over whether gains are capital or business income and whether an offshore vehicle genuinely qualifies for treaty relief. The Category III IFSC fund sidesteps all of it. Indian law itself treats the fund's securities as capital assets and exempts trading income, so the two questions that haunted the old structures fall away.

Since such a fund takes no recourse to any treaty, an entire layer of controversy disappears—no treaty shopping, no principal purpose test, no limitation of benefits clause and no debate over treaty substance. India's General Anti-Avoidance Rule (GAAR) framework goes further by specifically carving out FPIs that do not resort to any treaty benefit, placing them beyond the reach of GAAR itself. The structure rests entirely on Indian law, instead of a bargain struck with another country.

Gift's substance requirements are deliberately light: a small office and two or three professionals are generally enough to run a fund. And since 2025, even that can be outsourced—an overseas manager can simply plug into an independent, locally licensed platform.

In practice, the local Gift entity provides the regulated presence, while the offshore investment team drives investment decisions using sophisticated tools that enable those calls to be attributed to the Gift platform. In that sense, it resembles Mauritius—arguably with even lighter substance, but within

India's own legal perimeter.

Capital is responding. By March 2026, cumulative commitments to Gift funds had crossed \$39 billion, according to the International Financial Services Centres Authority. Even India's benchmark Nifty derivatives, long traded on Singapore's exchange, have since come home to Gift City.

As capital pours into Gift City, substance matters more than ever. The framework may not demand a heavy on-ground presence, but that is not the same as substance being optional. Courts can still apply substance-over-form principles even where statutory GAAR does not apply (often described as 'judicial GAAR'). The Supreme Court's reasoning in the case of *Tiger Global* is a good example. Today, judicial GAAR poses little threat to funds in Gift City because the platform is a stated national priority, and is promoted, backed and actively encouraged by the government.

But such priorities are not permanent. Should the policy mood shift, the same substance-over-form reasoning that unsettled treaty structures could, in principle, be turned towards even a government-favoured platform. The exemption is statutory but the goodwill around it is political. Wise investors should invest on the basis of genuine substance rather than relying on the political disposition.

The lesson is simple. Gift City rewards those who bring real activity onshore—real managers, real decisions and real risk. It punishes the letterbox.

So, is Gift City the new Mauritius? The question understates it. Mauritius was a clever fix for an era when India taxed foreign capital heavily. Gift City reflects India's decision that global capital should no longer need another jurisdiction to invest tax-efficiently in India. It reflects an India that has chosen to compete.

Mauritius's biggest competitor may no longer be another island. It may simply be India itself.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

Oil is a lousy investment because it isn't an investment. It's just a bet—and it's a bet with a ticking time bomb attached to it.

DAN DICKER

THEIR VIEW

Trade is going digital and enablers need to accelerate

ARPITA MUKHERJEE & GEETIKA GUPTA



are, respectively, professor and research assistant, Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations.

The India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) sets up a framework for cross-border digital trade rules. This is important because both India and the UK are among the top global exporters of Digitally Delivered Services (DDS) or services that can be delivered electronically through digital platforms. According to the World Trade Organization (WTO), India exported \$328 billion worth of DDS in 2025, making it the world's fourth largest exporter. Any trade agreement between two large DDS exporters is incomplete if they cannot establish trade rules. India's e-commerce exports are also rising. These digital products and services depend on an open and predictable trade regime, which allows cross-border data sharing, moratorium or zero customs duty, and national security as well as consumer protection. With growing global trade protectionism, tariff threats and restrictions on cross-border data flows, it is in India's interest to secure a liberal trade regime. Not only

this, India is also seeking to reduce cross-border trade costs through paperless trade. This has led to a Digital Trade chapter in the CETA, which will benefit our exporters.

India had been an active participant and a promoter of the rules-based trading system for e-commerce under the WTO through its Work Programme on Electronic Commerce (WPEC). However, with the WPEC no longer functional, India needs a predictable regime for exports through trade pacts.

The Digital Trade chapter in CETA not only establishes a framework for cooperation in areas such as online consumer protection, cybersecurity and emerging technologies such as AI and distributed ledger, but also advances India's ambition to make cross-border trade paperless. The India-UK trade deal requires both sides to maintain a legal framework for electronic transactions consistent with the United Nations Commission on International Trade Law principles, which support harmonization of standards across countries. They restrict both sides from denying legal validity to e-signature, e-document and e-seal, and encourage them to work towards mutual recognition of electronic authentication and trust services, cooperate on paperless trading, support the cross-border exchange of electronic in-

voices and promote greater consumer confidence in digital trade. They also support cooperation on digital inclusion, helping small and medium enterprises as well as women to participate more effectively in international trade through digital platforms. All these create a more predictable environment for businesses operating across borders and will reduce transaction costs and time. This is important at a time when geopolitical conflicts, shipping disruptions and container shortages are raising logistics bills.

Over the last decade, India has invested heavily in digital customs infrastructure through IceGate, Swift, e-Sanchit and faceless assessment. According to the United Nations Global Survey on Digital and Sustainable Trade Facilitation, 2025, India has achieved 100% domestic paperless trade measures. However, in cross-border paperless trade, implementation is only at 67% and has not changed since 2021. The provision of this free trade agreement will drive up India's

rank in such surveys if the provisions are implemented on the ground.

Greater use of authenticated trade documents and closer regulatory cooperation can improve end-to-end traceability of consignments, enabling manufacturers and customs authorities to verify product movement

across authorized distribution channels. This can help identify parallel exports, detect unauthorized diversion of genuine products, strengthen brand protection and facilitate quicker regulatory action where consignments enter overseas markets without the knowledge of the original manufacturer.

To realize these gains, further steps are needed. Domestically, the proposed Draft Trade Facilitation Bill, 2026, expected to be tabled in Parliament during the monsoon session, seeks to provide legal recognition to electronic transferable records and align India's legal framework with internationally accepted principles. With a trusted partner such as the UK, India can test emerging digital trade

rules, including e-authentication and paperless trading and others, before joining wider plurilateral negotiations like the WTO Joint Statement Initiative (JSI) on e-commerce. In this sense, the agreement can act as a testing ground for India's future approach to global digital trade rule-making.

Despite this, there is one notable gap in the CETA: it does not include a commitment to maintain the moratorium on customs duties on electronic transmissions. Such a provision appears in other agreements of the UK. For example, the ones it has with Australia and New Zealand in which both sides agree not to impose customs duties on electronic transmissions. With the WPEC non-functional, bilateral deals with like-minded trade partners are the right platforms to secure zero customs duty for our exports.

The UK CETA sets out a roadmap for easier cross-border trade by leveraging digital technologies. New Delhi should accelerate its domestic reforms on the legal front and the implementation of cross-border paperless trade measures on the ground.

At the same time, wider benefits will accrue if digital trade rules, as in the India-UK CETA, are applied to more and more of India's trade partners.

These are the authors' personal views.



THEIR VIEW

The \$2 trillion illusion of climate finance: set the record straight

The global discourse mustn't obscure the data on flows from developed to developing countries—just \$58.7 billion in 2024



V. ANANTHA NAGESWARAN, CHANDNI RAINA & SHITIZ JHA are, respectively, chief economic advisor to the Government of India, advisor, and young professional, department of economic affairs, ministry of finance.

Three numbers tend to shape how the world talks about climate finance. The first is \$100 billion—the developed countries' 2009 pledge of annual financing for developing countries through 2025. The second is \$300 billion—the new annual goal for 2025-35, alongside a vision to raise \$1.3 trillion a year. The third is the headline in the Climate Policy Initiative's (CPI) *Global Landscape of Climate Finance* (GLCF), which reported in its 2026 edition that flows surpassed \$2 trillion in 2024 for the first time.

Together, they tell a comforting story. If \$2 trillion was already flowing in 2024, a reader might conclude that both the \$300 billion goal and the broader \$1.3 trillion ambition have been met.

Except they haven't. The CPI's report, by design, measures how much climate finance moved globally—flows from government budgets, multilateral development banks (MDBs), corporate loans, equity and even a household in Delhi financing an electric car.

The \$300 billion goal is different. It focuses on specific flows from developed to developing countries, reflecting obligations and historical responsibility. To read the global total as proof that obligations have been met is to conflate them—which the CPI never does, but its headline seems to invite.

Look beyond the headline figure: The report highlights that climate finance in emerging markets and developing economies (EMDEs) reached \$1.2 trillion in 2024, outpacing advanced economies. But when about 85% of that finance was raised domestically, presenting it as evidence of progress on global climate finance is misleading. If most of it is already being mobilized domestically, it also suggests that many developing countries have built an enabling environment for climate finance. The bigger gap, then, is clearly in scaling up international climate finance.

Filter the CPI dataset down to what climate finance is actually about—capital flowing from advanced economies to EMDEs as grants and on concessional terms—and the reality shrinks to \$58.7 billion in 2024, comprising concessional debt net of export credit (\$26.4 billion), grants (\$24.8 billion) and equity (\$7.5 billion). This also includes \$7 billion to 'transregional' entities under the development status category, adding uncertainty to allocation. Against the headline figure, this is roughly two and a half cents on the dollar.

Yet, the report fails to put this front and centre. It sits behind complex spreadsheets that most policymakers will never touch. It is technically retrievable but functionally invisible.

The measurement gap: The headline rests on a contested foundation. Its composite methodology borrows criteria from the Standing Committee on Finance (SCF) of the United Nations Framework



Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), the OECD's Development Assistance Committee and Joint MDB principles, creating scope for overlaps, while leaving alignment with countries' climate strategies untouched.

And not all finance is tracked equally. Of the headline, \$1.9 trillion is mitigation—electric vehicles and renewables. Adaptation is just \$64 billion. The asymmetry is methodological: mitigation is checked against "a clear list of eligible activities," while for adaptation, the needed detail "is not commonly reported." The report thus tracks mitigation well, adaptation weakly and loss and damage not at all. It is thus strongest on the priorities of developed countries and weakest on those of developing countries, even though the latter are among the most vulnerable to climate change and building resilience through adaptation is a *sine qua non* for development itself.

The way finance is measured also matters. The report records commitments, not disbursements, and values loans at face value rather than on a grant-equivalent basis, which can overstate the resource transfer.

Alongside the headline estimate, the report notes a global resource shortfall of at least \$16 trillion by 2035. The same document therefore provides ammunition to both sides of the debate, but not equally. One number becomes the headline; the other remains in the body of the report.

When a perception becomes a position: The report's shortcomings would matter less if it remained confined to analysis. It does not. The GLCF feeds directly into the UNFCCC's Biennial Assessments, Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) reports and the negotiations themselves. The CPI calls it "a crucial evidence base" for UNFCCC processes. So when the base says \$2 trillion, much of the rhetorical work is already done. The burden of proof shifts; the focus of attention is no longer whether commitments have been met, but how much the world is already spending. A methodological choice becomes a negotiating position without being debated.

The following actions are critical: *First*, developing countries should call out such headline narratives and the methodological questions they rest on before they shape the discourse that follows. *Second*, it is high time that the SCF, as the technical body of the UNFCCC, critically examines the methodologies it relies on, seeks necessary modifications or develops its own independent estimates. *Third*, if the GLCF is to inform the UNFCCC process, its authors must align the report with the architecture of the Paris Agreement by explicitly reporting climate finance flows from developed to developing countries, which, in its latest report, amount to just \$58.7 billion, alongside the headline figure of \$2 trillion.

These are the authors' personal views.

MINT CURATOR

Anthropic versus Nvidia: will private interests shape policy?

The two are at odds amid US confusion over the rise of Chinese AI



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Chips denial or model bans? America is unsure how to hold off China. REUTERS

There is much to read between the lines whenever tech leaders make sweeping public pronouncements. Anthropic's CEO Dario Amodei published a blog post this week categorically denying that the company had ever backed a ban on so-called open-weight models, appearing at first glance to defend himself against attacks from the US government's recently departed AI czar David Sacks. But read a little deeper, and Amodei is joining a recent trend of deflecting White House ire towards someone else. In this case, it is Nvidia.

His post, 'Our position on open-weights models,' argues that there are better ways to counter China's AI efforts than banning its models that freely publish their core software components so anyone can use and modify them. These have looked like bad news for Anthropic's business and upcoming public offer. Sacks seized on that to point out Anthropic was alone in refusing to sign an open letter supporting open-weight AI; Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang had promoted the letter with his first-ever post on X. The industry needed to watch Anthropic like "like a hawk," Sacks said.

Mark Zuckerberg piled on with more veiled criticism with many seemingly coordinated statements in the press which warned against curbs on Chinese AI—a position that also protects Meta's own work on open-weight models—and publicly challenged Anthropic and OpenAI. Such rules risked "regulatory capture" and "concentrating power," he said, with no hint of irony from a billionaire whose statements were aimed at shaping regulation and whose social media platforms reach roughly 3.5 billion people each day—about 43% of the world's population.

Amodei denies that framing. A ban "would protect US AI companies from competition," he writes, "but that has never been my goal." His primary worry is an authoritarian state like China building models more powerful than anything in the US and using them to achieve military supremacy or to repress their citizens. You do not need open-weight models for that, he adds, and the best way to stop it from happening is to block China's ability to build AI in the first place, through chips.

Huang probably got heart palpitations reading that. Last year, the Trump administration reversed Biden-era restrictions on Nvidia's H20 chip exports to China, thus reopening what Huang described as a potential \$50 billion market. Amodei has implied that ban shouldn't have been lifted.

The Anthropic CEO is right on one point. The popularity of Chinese models like

Qwen and DeepSeek has become unstoppable among US businesses, especially startups. So the toothpaste is effectively out of the tube. "Open source has to win," says Ulfjan Sharka, CEO of Italian AI company Domyn, arguing that companies do not want to depend on two or three AI firms for the technology they will run their businesses on. "It will win. It's inevitable."

Banning such models also shoots US entrepreneurialism in the foot, since new business owners benefit from using cheap AI agents to spin up a website or do their taxes. And a US ban would not stop those models from becoming globally popular.

But it is unclear that Nvidia should be the company that bears the economic cost of containing China. Amodei cites a six-year-old research paper on AI's scaling laws in his reasoning for focusing on chips. The paper says, in a nutshell, that an increase in computing power produces more capable AI. That still broadly holds true, but is no longer the whole story. Beijing now takes a different view to the US on AI supremacy being more about wide adoption than the smartest bot—this explains why the rise of its open-weight models matters so much.

Export controls also have not prevented China from making major AI breakthroughs over the past year. Chinese companies have compensated through efficient methods and algorithmic improvements. Export controls might slow China, but they cannot stop it.

The debate over free AI has for years been one about safety, since closed systems have guardrails that can stop bad actors from using them for harm. Now it is becoming entangled in business interests. For the wider population, cheaper models hold genuine promise, potentially cutting cost burdens for businesses and startup founders. That is surely a good thing if AI is meant to boost economic productivity; but it could also severely disrupt the current bellwethers of a buzzy new industry that is propping up the US stock market.

As the White House works out how to contain China's technology advancements, it is also figuring out which US companies can be weaponized in that fight. It is clear from this week's public sparring between Amodei, Zuckerberg and Huang that Silicon Valley would rather have someone else conscripted.

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MY VIEW | IT MATTERS

Why AI transitions need forward deployed engineers

SIDDHARTH PAI



is a technology consultant and venture capitalist

A forward deployed engineer (FDE), a term that comes from Palantir, which made the role its entire go-to-market strategy, is neither a consultant, nor a developer in the traditional sense. The FDE sits with the client, understands what the business really needs, identifies what an AI tool can actually do, and then builds a bridge between the two. It is a role that requires the ability to write production code, diagnose business processes and tolerate operating in environments where requirements are unclear and IT infrastructure is 20 years old. The profile is rare. The market has priced it accordingly, with total compensation at mid-level running between \$300,000 and \$400,000 annually at the American AI firms that have popularized this role.

In India, TCS announced that it intends to build a team of up to 8,900 of them. This number deserves more scrutiny than it has received. CEO K. Krithivasan told *Reuters* the FDE corps would represent 1-1.5% of TCS's workforce, putting the firm in direct

competition with OpenAI, Anthropic and Microsoft for onsite AI implementation talent. The ambition is coherent. The question is whether the supply of people who can truly do the job exists within the firm, or anywhere near it.

The FDE role emerged because AI has a specific and consistent failure mode. A model that works in a demo does not always work for the enterprise; this is typically because companies are complicated in ways that demos do not account for: fragmented data, legacy systems, processes designed for a different era, and users who have not been told why the new tool is better than the old one. A 2025 MIT Media Lab report noted that 95% of Generative AI pilots fail, largely on account of flawed integration and a gap between available tools and the teams implementing them. The FDE is the person hired to close that gap.

In theory, this is exactly where Indian IT services firms should be able to compete. They have spent 30 years inside their clients' environments. They understand legacy systems. They know where the data is buried and why integration is harder than it looks. N. Chandrasekaran of the Tata Group put it plainly at a conference earlier this year: the real value is the context and understanding

of every enterprise's business and technology landscape. That is a fair description of what the FDE does, and it is also a fair description of what these firms have always claimed to do.

The difficulty is that understanding an enterprise and being able to rewire it around an AI system are not the same capability. The FDE role requires an engineer who can move between a business conversation and a production codebase in the same afternoon, who can tell a client their proposed use case is not a good use of AI, and who can build a working system in an environment designed by someone else.

The traditional IT services pyramid was not built to produce that combination of business judgement, technical depth and willingness to deliver an uncomfortable answer. Rather, it was aimed at delivering process adherence at scale, for which it produced IT engineers who were very good at executing a specification that someone else had written.

The FDE has to write the specification. Frequently, this professional must convince a client that the specification they arrived at is wrong.

This matters because AI without a proper business case is expensive decoration. According to Paraform, a specialist recruiter that tracks the category, FDE job postings grew 800% between January and September 2025, which tells you how many enterprises reached the end of a pilot run with no idea what to do next.

As demand for FDEs rises, their supply remains a constraint for IT firms. The role's profile requires production engineering fluency, client-facing credibility, AI implementation experience and genuine domain understanding. This takes years to develop and cannot be manufactured quickly from an intake of fresh recruits, however large.

Which brings the latest quarter's results into sharper focus. TCS's headcount addition of 9,279 was its strongest in four years.

HCLTech grew its 'advanced AI' revenue by 62% while cutting headcount by over 3,000. These are firms navigating the same transition from different directions, and the FDE announcement is TCS's most explicit statement of where it believes the transition leads: fewer people doing routine work, more people doing work that requires an intimate grasp of client businesses.

The honest question is how many of those new positions at IT consulting firms will be filled by engineers who can already do what the role demands and how many by engineers quickly retrained and reclassified so that they can be sent to client sites with a new job title. This distinction would matter to clients trying to deploy AI in a business that cannot afford to be someone's training ground.

Consulting firms have historically billed by the hour. An engineer whose job is to make a model replace hours is an awkward thing to put on a rate card. TCS will report results again in October. While TCS may have 8,900 engineers called FDEs, what it would really need are 8,900 engineers whom clients would choose even if the title disappeared altogether.

This requirement has a way of separating the narrative from the reality.

Demand has soared for tech professionals who have a close grasp of what clients actually need



Are sushi, sashimi and ceviche safe?

India's appetite for raw fish is growing, but doctors and chefs explain the risks and talk about how diners can protect themselves

Shradha Shahani
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In August 2022, I woke up with severe heartburn and a needle-like burning sensation in my upper abdomen. The previous night, I had eaten salmon sashimi at a South Mumbai restaurant. Unable to fall asleep for nights on end, I went from one general physician to another, and each of them pinned it down to stress, anxiety, and acid reflux. Until nearly three weeks later, a colonoscopy revealed bacteria had eaten into the lining of my small intestine, carving multiple ulcers, which led to internal bleeding. "Avoid raw fish, especially in the monsoon," my gastroenterologist said. The procedure was followed by a six-month-long recovery process that involved a cocktail of medications and bland food.

I am not alone. In April this year, nearly 100 people reported food poisoning in Sweden after eating at a sushi restaurant. Back home, a group of eleven people dined at a cafe in Navi Mumbai, and each person who ate the smoked salmon suffered from food poisoning. "My son and husband were hospitalised, and my son spent four days in the hospital due to high fever, vomiting, diarrhoea, and dehydration," wrote diner Prithi Venkatram on Google Reviews.

IS IT SAFE TO EAT RAW FISH IN INDIA?

"Raw fish can harbour bacteria such as non typhoidal Salmonella, Vibrio species, pathogenic E. coli, and Staphylococcus, all of which thrive if fish is not kept consistently cold or handled hygienically," says Dr Aashik Y S, associate consultant—Medical Gastroenterology, Manipal Hospital, Bengaluru.

While these bacteria can exist in other countries as well, India poses its own challenges when it comes to raw fish. "High ambient temperatures, combined with humidity and heavy monsoon rains, make it easier for bacteria to multiply on fish during transport, storage, and preparation if the cold chain is not perfect. In summer and monsoon, even a short break in refrigeration or exposure to contaminated water and surfaces can turn otherwise safe fish into a high risk ingredient when served raw," the doctor adds.

To kill parasites, the Food and Drug Administration in the United States mandates that restaurants need to freeze raw fish at -20°C for seven days or blast freeze it at -35°C for a shorter duration. The European Union, too, mandates that raw fish be frozen for 24 hours at certain temperatures to kill parasites before serving. In India, the Food Safety and Standards Authority

Fish tends to be fresher in a busy restaurant with a high turnover of guests, says restaurateur Gauri Devidayal



of India (FSSAI) mandates that raw fish must be quick-frozen using appropriate equipment until the temperature reaches -18°C or colder at its thermal centre, but there are no guidelines on freezing temperatures for parasite destruction at restaurants.

Japanese restaurants are opening in spades in India, but not all restaurants are equipped to handle raw fish, say doctors, chefs and restaurateurs. "Problems usually arise when there are lapses in cold chain, cross contamination in the kitchen, or inadequate staff training—these are often behind cluster episodes of food poisoning," says Aashik.

Lakhan Jethani, head chef and co-founder of Mumbai's Mizu Izakaya, follows the internationally recognised multi-step food safety management system, Hazard Analysis and Critical Control Points (HACCP). "It starts with working

with trusted suppliers who import fish from Japan or Norway. At Mizu, 150 kg of fish is flown in from Japan every week," he says. "The second step is a surface temperature check. Fresh fish needs to be stored at less than 4°C, the fish will then measure less than 8°C. If it's over, the fish is rejected."

Then comes the inspection of body markers. "We check the belly. The fish needs to be gutted, otherwise it could carry infections. We check if the fish looks fresh and smells fresh. It should not be over slimy, the eyes should look fresh, and the gills should be bright red in colour," Jethani adds.

The fish then goes for an initial wash; it's quickly filleted and then put into a freezer or lightly cured. "This is all done in an air-conditioned room. We have to follow the two-to-four-hour rule, where

all ingredients have to be stored below 4°C within two to four hours," he says. The fish, especially tuna, is frozen at -35°C to kill bacteria in a medical-grade freezer. "99% of restaurants are not equipped to freeze fish at that temperature. Tuna is a very fatty fish, and it resides in waters that are below -30°C; if it's not stored properly, it will start harbouring bacteria," says Jethani.

Izumi in Mumbai and Goa follows a similar process. The salmon is frozen at -40°C, while tuna at -50°C, says Noorsha Kably, co-founder and chef at Izumi. "We work with very small portions, and even before the fish completely thaws, we put it back into the freezer. It's never left out for too long," she adds.

While Kably was not particularly a fan of delivering sushi and didn't do it initially, she now sends ice packs along with it to ensure it doesn't start to spoil.

HOW TO BE SMART SUSHI CONSUMERS?

In the United States, menus come with a disclaimer: "Consuming raw or undercooked meats, poultry, seafood, shellfish, or eggs may increase your risk of foodborne illness." In



India, no such warning exists on menus. The FSSAI conducted nearly 4 lakh inspections across food establishments in 2025-26, and as many as

23,580 adjudication cases were decided, as per reports.

So, diners must choose their restaurant wisely. "Since there is no standardisation in the industry, consumers need to keep in mind that handling raw fish is a more demanding task than handling cooked fish," says Dr Subrata Das, lead consultant and HOD—Internal Medicine, Aster Whitefield Hospitals, Bengaluru. "Restaurants that specialise in sushi and ceviche tend to be careful. They audit their suppliers, store fish at appropriate temperatures, use separate cutting boards and knives for raw items, and train staff in hygiene," he adds.

"A busy restaurant is a good sign. High turnover of guests means fresher fish," adds restaurateur Gauri Devidayal. Aashik advises besides picking places with visible hygiene standards, diners should avoid sushi and ceviche that has been sitting out at room temperature, especially in hot or very humid weather. "People who are pregnant, immunocompromised, have advanced liver disease, or have had recent GI surgery should avoid raw fish altogether."

Kably also suggests that customers can look out for body markers too. "It should look and smell fresh at all times. Raw fish is also paired with wasabi, pickled ginger, soy, and vinegar for a reason. They have anti-bacterial properties."

If all fails and you do experience fever, vomiting, or diarrhoea after consuming raw fish, seek medical advice immediately, both doctors advise.



Why your body never forgets exercises

The brain stores movement patterns that make returning to exercise easier

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When starting a fitness activity, consistency matters most in the beginner phase. This is because, for the muscles, it is the first phase or the cognitive phase of learning new moves and patterns—just like when you typed on a keyboard for the first time, or learnt how to catch a ball or tie your shoelaces. The more you do this task, the more the body starts understanding other factors like how much weight is too little or too much.

Despite its name, muscle memory is less about the muscles alone and more about the brain and nervous system remembering how to perform a movement. "As your muscles don't have the capacity to retain memories like your brain does, they increase the amount of muscle fiber nuclei (myonuclei) within the trained muscle cells," says a medically reviewed article on Cleveland Clinic's website from 2025. "Think of these as crew members on a boat. The more members rowing the boat, the better it will perform in a race. As myonuclei increase, so does your muscle mass."

The same principle also helps explain why returning to a sport after a long break is often easier than expected. It could be getting on a bicycle ten years after you last rode one, or returning to the football pitch after a long-term injury derailed you.

"Neural memory is what your brain and spinal cord remember: movement patterns like hitting a badminton smash, riding a bicycle, or kicking a football. Your strength and fitness decline with inactivity, but the blueprint for the motor movement often remains. You may be slower or weaker

initially, but the nervous system relearns much faster than it learned the first time," says Udgam Baxi, a neurosurgeon in Vadodara with a FIFA-accredited diploma in football medicine.

The National Academy of Sports Medicine (NASM) put out a YouTube video on this topic a year ago, on their Peak Fitness Podcast. This also helped explain "newbie gains"—the rapid uptick in muscle size and strength when one starts regularly lifting weights for the first time—and their links with creating new neural pathways.

"People who just start lifting are creating different pathways and will see a sudden rise in the neuromuscular control and strength output. These are especially evident in the first 6-12 months of training and an athlete might gain almost twice the muscle in the same period as a more experienced lifter," says NASM trainer Andre Adams in the video.

All of which means that maintenance work to stay fit is not just for size and strength, but to make sure the movement patterns you learnt in your fittest days continue to be used. Aside from that, learning entirely new movements offers other benefits too and help develop neuroplasticity: the more frequently and correctly you practice a movement, the stronger the neural pathways become.

TRANSFORMATIVE JOURNEYS

Doing the heavy lifting to protect my spine and knees

Turning 59 and finding the elixir for a plethora of health issues lies in regular weight training, yoga and swimming

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Weight lifting for me is the elixir that if I'm unable to take, I shrivel up, turn brittle and begin withering from within. That is metaphor but not too far from truth.

This is a road that I started on in boardingschool in 1979 but only half-heartedly. The full-bore purposefulness of making physical activity a part of my daily routine came when I went to Hofstra University in the US in 1985. It happened to be the year that my college along with many others decided to make Physical Education a requirement for all Freshman.

The one credit course that the college required called for an hour-long PE course of our choice. I picked weight training. My teacher for that class was an older gentleman, a very fit, former Olympian and a no-nonsense guide for a class of

twelve freshmen, a mix of young men and women in their late teens. His name has slipped my memory. We fumbled around the weight room, figuring out how to get the most out of calf raises and lat pull downs, how to squat while pushing our bums back and keeping our knees behind our toes. We learned how to protect our backs and our knees, while strengthening our glutes and hamstrings. Very simply, the class was an introduction to the school of slow and steady, heavy and heavier, and simple is best.

By the time I graduated in 1989, went on to graduate school for an MBA in 1990 and on to various jobs, regular exercise had become a part of my life—mostly. There were many times that I slacked off. But in retrospect, those were precisely the times when life went sideways for me. I was diagnosed with Ulcerative Colitis, hospitalized six times in five years, had multiple blood transfusions and was on the verge of losing my colon in 1994. But exercise re-entered with a vengeance and miraculously, my colitis symptoms vanished. I joined a local gym, one I could barely afford, and stopped for a workout on my way home from work, three to four times a week. At the time, I had not quite registered that exercise was my medicine but I had an inkling.



When I was pregnant with my first child in 1997, I didn't exercise. I thought, mistakenly, that it was a time to take it easy. I escaped any flares during pregnancy but they returned soon after I delivered. I began exercising, spending scarce time and money on a gym membership, and voila, good health returned. I continued

exercising when I got pregnant with child #2 in 2002, at a wonderful maternity exercise class at my gym. I went from work at lunchtime, got in an hour of walking lunges, bicep curls, tricep dips and what not and came back energized and strong.

My husband, me and my two young children moved to India in 2004, settling

in Pune. I continued to work. The stress levels were higher, the drive times longer, the expectations greater. I floundered till I found a gym and a trainer I could afford and magically, the mental stress eased as the physical body found strength again. In 2018, at age 51, I was in the US for a holiday when I felt a little twinge in my lower back. A good stretch solved the problem. Upon returning to India, that twinge had become more of an ache. I ignored it and went on with work and life. A few weeks later, I couldn't get off the bed. It was a slipped disc which after an MRI several days later was confirmed to be a herniation of L5 and S1 discs. I was confined to my bed, couldn't get up even if I wanted to.

Two weeks later, a doctor, aghast at the state of my spine as reflected in the MRI insisted I see a surgeon right away. The surgeon had intended to recommend immediate surgery but backed off when he saw me walk in quite comfortably. The MRI didn't match what he was seeing. I began swimming. My back got stronger. I began walking, first 1-2 kms, later 5-6 kms. But I couldn't do yoga and I couldn't lift weights. So, I kept swimming.

In June 2023, I began Yoga under the able guidance of Trisha Maharaj Singh. Always mindful of my back, much more so than I had ever been, I did Yoga with Singh

twice a week and swam or walked on the other days. In June 2024, I returned to weight training with young Atharva Bendarkar, a fantastic trainer who made me believe once again that my body was strong and capable. My yoga classes with Singh also continued.

I don't know if my years of weight training helped me recover quicker and better. I do know that if I hadn't gone back to weight training when I did, the ravages of time and menopause would have worn me down a lot more than they have been able to. At 59, I am no longer afraid of low back pain or weak knees. I've also gone through a variety of iterations—lift light with more reps, heavy with less reps, full body relaxed workouts, focus on upper body and lower body, micro movements, macro movements, strength vs. endurance vs. cardio health.

I have concluded that it doesn't matter which iteration you adopt as long as you keep increasing resistance, slowly and steadily, heavy and heavier, and keep it simple. Add regular Yoga to the mix and top the whole thing up with just a little good cardio of your choice.

Transformative Journeys is a monthly series on triumphs, failures and shifts related to health.